



Evaluation of the UNICEF L3 response to the Earthquake in Syria

This report is one of three deliverables for the evaluation of the UNICEF L3 response to the earthquake in Türkiye and Syria

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New York, New York 10017

January 2025

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Preface

I am pleased to present one of the three deliverables from the evaluation of the **UNICEF L3 response to the earthquake in Türkiye and Syria**: the Syria evaluation report.¹ The report covers strengths and areas of improvement of the response across the following themes and corresponding criteria: i) the adaptation to the context and alignment with the CCCs (Appropriateness); ii) the effectiveness of the response, including the role of targeting, advocacy and internal systems (Effectiveness); iii) cross-cutting issues (such as protection from sexual exploitation and abuse (PSEA), social and behavior change (SBC), gender, etc.) and whether they were meaningfully and systematically integrated in the response; iv) the humanitarian-development-peace nexus and resilience-building considerations (Connectedness); v) the collaboration and engagement with relevant authorities and the UN system at large (Coherence); and vi) the coordination in the clusters/sectors and partnerships with implementing partners (Coordination).

The evaluation was conducted by ITAD Ltd, UK. I would like to thank Dr. Natalie Hicks and Pierre Townsend for their leadership, expertise and professionalism, together with David Fleming, Dr. Hana Asfour, Tulika Jain, and the rest of the team for their committed efforts throughout the evaluation.

A special thanks is due to the UNICEF Syria Country Office, the UNICEF MENARO Outpost in Gaziantep, UNICEF Whole of Syria (WoS) staff, as well as UNICEF colleagues in MENARO at large and colleagues on the Evaluation Reference Group, who contributed valuable time to the evaluation process, including the fieldwork, and through the various iterations of the evaluation report. These include, among others: Yasumasa Kimura, Mioh Nemoto, Anoop Singh Gurung, Aya Elbizem, Olivia Roberts, Danee Luhar, Talal Mahgoub, Alhaji Bah, Myriam Van Parijs, Segolene Adam, Maddalena Bertolotti, Joseph Barnes, Boris Zinsou Lissassi, Lola Galla, Catherine Dickehage, Dorian Druelle, Jonas Berntsson, Olga Basurmanova, Claire Mariani, Priya Marwah, Katherine Mahoney, Olivier Mulet, Patrick Konan Nguessan, Akshay Sinha, Andrea Petkovic, Ndeye Marie Diop, Erin Tettensor, Jan Eijkenaar, and Anthea Moore. All are gratefully acknowledged.

I would also like to thank my colleagues in the Evaluation Office, Michele Tarsilla and Carlotta Tincati, who have managed this evaluation, as well as Celeste Lebowitz and Geeta Dey, who provided critical administrative support throughout the whole process.

Robert McCouch
Director, Evaluation Office

¹ The three deliverables reflect the Syria and Türkiye Country Offices' earlier request to issue separate/country-specific reports for this L3 evaluation. Therefore, we encourage to review them jointly, as relevant.

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List of acronyms

Note on use of non-standard terms

The following acronyms and terms are used throughout the report:

GCA for Government of Syria-controlled areas

Non-GCAs (NGCAs) for areas of Syria not under government control

NWS (non-GCA) for non-government-controlled areas of northwest Syria

NES (non-GCA) for non-government-controlled areas of northeast Syria

'Cross-line' to describe aid or services provided from GCAs to non-GCAs in NWS

AAP	Accountability to Affected Populations
ADAP	Adolescent Development and Participation
AFNS	Aid Fund for Northern Syria
AHCT	Area Humanitarian Coordination Team
AoR	Area of Responsibility
BMS	Breast Milk Substitute
CA	Cash Assistance
CAAC	Children and Armed Conflict
CAAFAG	Children Associated with Armed Forces and Armed Groups
CC	Climate Change
CCCs	Core Commitments for Children
CERF	Central Emergency Response Fund
CLA	Cluster Lead Agency
CO	Country Office
COP28	28th United Nations Conference of the Parties
CP	Child Protection
CS	Collective Shelters
CSO	Civil Society Organization
CT	Cash Transfer
CwD	Child with Disabilities
CWG	Cash Working Group

CWM	Child Well-Being Monitoring
DfA	De Facto Authority
DG-ECHO	Directorate-General for European Civil Protection and Humanitarian Aid Operations
DoH	Directorate of Health
ECA	Europe and Central Asia
ECD	Early Child Development
ECF	Emergency Case Fund
EMOPS	Emergency Operations
EORE	Explosive Ordnance Risk Education
EPF	Emergency Programme Fund
EPF	Emergency Preparedness Plan
EQ	Earthquake
FAO	Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations
FCDO	Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office
FGD	Focus Group Discussion
FMM	Field Monitoring Module
FO	Field Office
GBV	Gender-Based Violence
GBViE	Gender-Based Violence in Emergencies
GoS	Government of Syria
H&N	Health and Nutrition

HAC	Humanitarian Action for Children
HACT	Harmonized Approach to Cash Transfers
HCT	Humanitarian Country Team
HNAP	Humanitarian Needs Assessment Programme
HP	Hygiene Promotion
HQ	Headquarters
HR	Human Resources
HRP	Humanitarian Response Plan
HTS	Hay'at Tahrir al-Sham
IDP	Internally Displaced Person
IEC	Information, Education and Communication
IM	Information Management
IMO	Information Management Officer
INGO	International Non-Governmental Organization
IOM	International Organization for Migration
IP	Implementing Partner
ISC	Intersectoral Coordination
IYCF	Infant and Young Child Feeding
KII	Key Informant Interview
KPI	Key Performance Indicator
L3	Level 3
LNS	Lipid-Based Nutritional Supplements
LTA	Long-Term Agreement
MENA	Middle East and North Africa
MENARO	Middle East and North Africa Regional Office
MHNT	Mobile Health and Nutrition Team
MHPSS	Mental Health and Psychosocial Support

MIS	Management Information System
MoE	Ministry of Education
MoH	Ministry of Health
MoSAL	Ministry of Social Affairs and Labour
MoWR	Ministry of Water Resources
MSF	Médecins Sans Frontières
MSNA	Multisector Needs Assessment
NGO	Non-Governmental Organization
NWS	Northwest Syria
OCHA	Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs
OIAI	Office of Internal Audit and Investigations
PD	Project/Programme Document
PDM	Post-Distribution Monitoring
PFA	Psychological First Aid
PiN	People in Need
PLW	Pregnant and Lactating Women
PME	Planning, Monitoring and Evaluation
PSEA	Protection from Sexual Exploitation and Abuse
PSS	Psychosocial Support
PwD	Person with Disabilities
RAM	Results Assessment Module
RC	Resident Coordinator
RCCE	Risk Communication and Community Engagement
RNA	Rapid Needs Assessment
RO	Regional Office
RR	Regular Resources
SAM	Severe Acute Malnutrition
SARC	Syrian Arab Red Crescent
SBC	Social and Behaviour Change

SBC-CE	Social and Behavioural Change and Community Engagement
SCHF	Syria Cross-Border Humanitarian Fund
SCO	Syria Country Office
SDG	Sustainable Development Goal
SEA	Sexual Exploitation and Abuse
SERNA	Syria Earthquake Recovery Needs Assessment
SIG	Syrian Interim Government
SitRep	Situation Report
SMART	Standard Monitoring Assessment for Relief and Transitions
SNA	Syrian National Army
SOM	Senior Officials Meeting
SOP	Standard Operating Procedure
SP	Social Protection
SSG	Syrian Salvation Government
SYNAT	Syria Rapid Needs Assessment Tool
TOR	Terms of Reference

TPF	Third-Party Facilitator
TPM	Third-Party Monitor
UN	United Nations
UNCT	United Nations Country Team
UNDP	United Nations Development Programme
UNDSS	United Nations Department for Safety and Security
UNFPA	United Nations Population Fund
UN-Habitat	United Nations Human Settlements Programme
UNHCR	United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees
UNICEF	United Nations Children Fund
UNSC	United Nations Security Council
UNSCR	United Nations Security Council Resolution
WASH	Water, Sanitation and Hygiene
WFP	World Food Programme
WHO	World Health Organization
WoS	Whole of Syria



Executive Summary

Introduction

The United Nations Children Fund (UNICEF) commissioned an evaluation of its Level 3 (L3) emergency response to the 2023 earthquakes in Türkiye and Syria. This report covers UNICEF's L3 response in Syria. A separate report covers UNICEF's L3 response in Türkiye and an Overarching Report draws on findings at country, regional and Headquarters (HQ) levels and focuses on issues of corporate-wide relevance. These three reports should be read together and treated as the main deliverables from this evaluation.

UNICEF's L3 response in Syria aimed to address the immediate life-saving and urgent humanitarian needs of girls, boys, adolescents and families through an integrated and gender-responsive approach, prioritizing highly affected areas and areas of large displacement. UNICEF's priorities were to restore essential services and provide cash and winter items where possible. UNICEF leveraged the established system for accountability to affected populations (AAP) and put measures in place for the prevention of gender-based violence (GBV) and sexual exploitation. UNICEF appealed for US\$172 million to reach 5.4 million people, including 2.6 million children, between February and May 2023.

Evaluation purpose, objectives and intended users

The evaluation of UNICEF's L3 earthquake response has both an accountability and learning purpose. In terms of accountability, it fulfils UNICEF's Policy requirement that all L3 emergencies be evaluated. With regard to learning, the evaluation has assessed the evidence as to what worked and did not work in the L3 response to inform good practice in ongoing and future emergencies.

The overall objective of the evaluation is to provide a comprehensive assessment of UNICEF's organization-wide L3 earthquake response in Syria (including Government Controlled Areas and Non-Government Controlled Areas), measured against UNICEF's own mandate, corporate commitments, stated objectives and standard evaluation criteria, including appropriateness, effectiveness, connectedness, coherence and coordination. The evaluation also examined the extent to which cross-cutting issues – protection from sexual exploitation and abuse (PSEA), social and behaviour change (SBC), protection needs, climate change (CC), gender, and disabilities – were systematically and meaningfully integrated in the response.

The evaluation findings and recommendations will inform the work of the UNICEF Syria and Türkiye Country Offices as well as that of the Europe and Central Asia (ECA) and Middle East and North Africa (MENA) Regional Offices, the Whole of Syria (WoS) approach, and various divisions in UNICEF Headquarters (HQ), especially with regard to their strategies, programming, operations, and humanitarian responses to other future sudden onset disasters.

Methodology

The evaluation has been guided by the questions and approach articulated in the UNICEF Terms of Reference and by UNICEF stakeholder feedback during the inception period. It is not a theory-based evaluation but, as agreed with the UNICEF Evaluation Office, has drawn on a reconstructed logic model. The evaluation approach is both summative and formative and has been designed to ensure that the findings and recommendations are relevant and actionable and can measurably support decisions by the relevant UNICEF stakeholders. To help achieve this, the evaluation has followed three core principles:

- ▶ It is **learning and utilization-focused**, to ensure the generation of practical solutions to support UNICEF;
- ▶ It is **field-focused**, to ensure that the evaluation adds as much value as possible to improvements and innovations at the field level, for the benefit of those most affected by emergency humanitarian crises;
- ▶ It is **participatory**, to ensure buy-in and ownership of the evaluation's findings and recommendations by UNICEF stakeholders.

The evaluation employed a range of methods, including a document review, context analysis, semi-structured key informant interviews (KIIs), focus group discussions (FGDs) and an online survey of UNICEF staff. The data collection was underpinned by a sampling strategy for GCAs and NGCAs, whereby nine stakeholder groups were identified for FGDs or KIIs. For the data collection in NWS, recipients of UNICEF services and service providers were sampled in camps in earthquake-affected locations. The sampling was purposive of both sector and multi-sector interventions covering child protection (CP), education, adolescent development and participation (ADAP), nutrition, health, and water, sanitation and hygiene (WASH).

Key findings, conclusions and recommendations

The findings, conclusions and recommendations are aligned with the five evaluation criteria (appropriateness, effectiveness, connectedness, coherence and coordination), with the addition of a section specifically focusing on cross-cutting issues.

Appropriateness: Adaptation to context, alignment with CCCs, and accountability to affected populations

The gravity of the impact of the earthquake on UNICEF partners and staff challenged early response activities such as developing quality needs assessments. However, these early difficulties were mitigated effectively by UNICEF's alignment within wider UN targeting, pre-existing preparedness measures (outside of the Emergency Preparedness Plan), and alignment with the CCCs in planning and implementing the L3 response.

The application of the No Regrets approach, although hesitant at times, brought some innovative multi-sectoral initiatives to the fore that aimed to address needs at scale, with considerations for transformative outcomes in NWS. The evaluation found that UNICEF Implementing Partners were key to the application and coverage of Accountability to Affected Populations (AAP) but there was an over-focus on accounting for the use of reporting/feedback mechanisms and limited evidence that these mechanisms placed people at the centre of determining their own needs. This was compounded by the use of an AAP indicator that focused solely on whether people were using feedback mechanisms.

Key conclusions

Integrated programme initiatives were evident in both regions, with activities that had potential to be transformative leading to sustained change beyond the earthquake response. An example of this was the WAQTI initiative in NWS. The evaluation concluded that the Syria Country Office's focus on involving adolescents in multisector awareness raising campaigns was highly appropriate in terms of working at scale and maximizing the potential of adolescents to build trust in communities in support of SBC approaches.

Key recommendation 1 (NGCAs):

Increase knowledge base on multisector programming to apply in future sudden onset emergencies and in early recovery and resilience building stages.

Effectiveness: Extent to which approaches to coverage, advocacy and internal systems contributed to an effective response

For the WoS, there was an uneven distribution in achieving funding targets between the sectors. Cash transfer was a critical intervention in the response, but it was challenged by UN-agreed financial envelopes, a lack of shared UN positioning on data protection and associated difficulties in horizontal expansion. The evaluation found that indicators for AAP, SBC and youth engagement did not fully capture the extent of UNICEF's engagements in these areas. UNICEF data for sector and cross-sectoral progress against targets was not always aligned between different datasets.

In GCAs and NGCAs, coverage with equity was hard to determine given the fluidity of movement and scale of needs in both regions. The Syria Country Office demonstrated a do no harm approach to addressing needs inside and outside of the shelters and the inclusion of youth volunteers and mobile teams was an effective strategy to cover hard to reach and rural locations.

In GCAs, monitoring was maximized by the (gendered) use of third party monitors (TPMs) and third party facilitators (TPFs) across the six Field Offices. For some sectors, such as CP, limited access to data and evidence for programming and advocacy has been a consistent operational reality. The evaluation found that monitoring systems could be enhanced with deeper consultation with the Field Offices. In NGCAs, the Outpost has maximized the opportunities to monitor on the ground by use of the Field Monitoring Module (FMM) ETool but both regions lacked sufficient Information Management (IM) officers at the outset of the response to ensure highly effective information management systems.

Key conclusions:

The criticality of cash transfer (CT) in emergencies was well-documented, thanks to careful monitoring and analysis of this intervention by the Syria Country Office and looking forward to current and future emergencies, it will be important to find ways to improve horizontal expansion. Coverage with equity was complex to plan and monitor for given the dynamic context and scale of needs. However, approaches to do no harm and mitigate dangers of over- and under-coverage were found in GCAs. Information management emerged as a critical issue the emergency in this report and in the Overarching Report. In line with UNICEF's strategic priority on digitalization, the role of Information Management Specialists is critical both during an L3 response and in recovery phases.

Key recommendations 2 and 3 (NGCAs):

Revisit the regional and global surge rosters and adjust to ensure IM specialists (at all levels) are well represented, facilitating a quicker drawdown of these skills in an L3 emergency; Attain greater clarity on IMS management in the Outpost, in line with revised guidelines issued by MENARO.

Key recommendation 1 (GCAs):

Coordinate with the UN to finalize an agreed set of standards in CT; Enhance timeliness and effectiveness of CT in emergencies; Use the solid evidence on CT for evidence-based advocacy and credibility-building to donors.

Cross-cutting issues

In GCAs, the evaluation found that PSEA could be more effectively applied by investing greater efforts in raising awareness and encouraging the application of PSEA by the government. SBC effectively built on the 2022 cholera response but extended beyond health messaging to issues such as disaster preparedness. SBC was most effective when initiated in a multi-sector approach and engaged youth in messaging and trust-building activities within affected communities.

The evaluation observed some climate change initiatives in GCAs. However, climate smart technology vital to resilience building in both regions is difficult to fund. Although gender was disaggregated and reported on, there were no specific gender indicators. Such indicators could have told a more evidence-based story on UNICEF commitments to gender in an L3 response. It was difficult to match the scale

of needs on the ground for People with Disabilities, although UNICEF made some targeted responses to reaching children through CT, WASH facilities and psychosocial first aid.

Key conclusions:

In both regions, the evaluation concluded that PSEA and protection awareness raising and trainings could have more systematically included men. This was a missed opportunity to initiate a more transformative approach to PSEA and some protection outcomes. The review of SBC in emergencies was valuable to look deeper into strategies leading to transformative outcomes. The evaluation concludes that there is more scope to look at how SBC interventions can be maximized by using a multi-sector approach and engaging youth.

Connectedness: Extent to which the response considered the humanitarian-development-peace nexus and resilience building considerations

The evaluation found that resilience building in the recovery phase of the response was, and is, critical for both regions in Syria. The Syria Country Office created opportunities for important rehabilitation work in WASH and sewage facilities, and efforts towards early recovery were assisted in part by some donors' increased flexibility towards early recovery programming. Resilience building in NWS has been more constrained, owing to the lack of an agreed early recovery strategy among international organizations, continued uncertainty over the border crossing, and an overall funding drop in NWS. Significantly, there is a lack of formalized governance systems in NGCAs of Aleppo and Idlib to anchor resilience interventions. Despite these challenges, UNICEF has developed creative, if ad hoc, initiatives to building resilience, especially in the area of CP.

Key conclusions:

The evaluation concluded that multi-year resilience programming in both regions will involve recalibrating approaches to funding with donors (elaborated upon in the Overarching Report) and re-doubled efforts at pushing forward on the localization agenda with government and partners.

Coherence: Extent to which UNICEF had engaged with relevant government authorities and the UN system

In GCAs, while UNICEF was proactive in leveraging relations with existing government interlocutors during the L3 response, more could be done to build strategic relationships with government authorities in charge of emergency response, i.e., developing relations beyond UNICEF's existing ecosystem of Syrian counterpart ministries. The Syria Country Office contributed to a coherent wider UN response and was praised by other UN agencies for its collegial approach.

In NGCAs, the earthquake provided an opportunity in crisis to engage with the DfAs in Idlib and Aleppo. This opportunity was seized in the early phases of the response but became increasingly self-restricting, because of ambiguity over who would lead this engagement and a lack of strategy for the engagement. Overall, the Outpost collaborated constructively with the wider UN system working on the cross-border response. However, UNICEF's initial appetite for risk with regard to access in NWS, coupled with its forward-leaning duty of care policies, created some tensions with some UN agencies.

Key conclusions:

There are some compelling reasons for the MENARO Outpost (and the WoS team in Amman) to redouble efforts on engagement with the DfAs. In terms of coherence and sustainability, there is a need to anchor UNICEF's programming within the prevailing systems in NWS. It will also be important for the Outpost to mitigate programme risk by developing sound communication channels with the DfAs while ensuring UNICEF's adherence to core commitments of a principled humanitarian approach in NWS.

Key recommendation 4 (NGCAs):

Develop a phased strategy for UNICEF engagement with De facto Authorities.

Key recommendations 8-10 (GCAs):

Work with UN agencies to improve joint UN-government coordination in emergency preparedness and response; Attain greater traction with the government, NGO and INGO partners on PSEA in emergencies: Build strategic partnerships with the Ministry of Local Administration and Environment (MoLAE) as an essential part of preparedness for future emergencies.

Coordination: Extent to which UNICEF has provided coordination in the cluster/ sectors and formed effective partnerships with implementing partners

In GCAs, the evaluation found that UNICEF played a strong role in the national-level sectors but was less prominent in subnational sectors because of understaffing in the early stages of the response.

For both GCAs and NGCAs, Implementing Partners were the fulcrum of the L3 response on the ground. In NWS, the pivot from remote programming to on-the-ground monitoring opportunities tested the relations between UNICEF and its Implementing Partners but ultimately did not impact on the functionality of the partnerships.

In GCAs and NGCAs, UNICEF provided Implementing Partners with a range of capacity building opportunities, particularly emergency preparedness training, in line with the CCCs on localization. Although UNICEF is providing more than double the Grand Bargain funding target to national NGOs, this alone is not a key criterion for measuring the advancement to localization principles. Despite some creative approaches in programme development (PD) extensions instigated in the L3 response, multi-year planning and funding is challenging to achieve.

Key conclusions:

The evaluation concluded that UNICEF offices are accountable to localization principles above and beyond capacity building and financial allocations and could systematically measure accountability to the CCCs on localization.

Key recommendations 5-7 (NGCAs):

Provide support for Implementing Partners to access longer-term and more predictable funding sources; Introduce accountability to progressing the localization agenda, as described in the CCCs; Develop a shared multisector vision on early recovery with national partners.

Key recommendations 4-7 (GCAs):

Progress further on the localization agenda for increasing national NGO responder capacities in emergency response; Provide capacity building for Implementing Partners in financial management and risk in order for them to be better positioned to (independently) access more predictable funding sources; Harness the role of youth volunteers as trust-builders in communities to enhance AAP in emergencies; Introduce accountability to progressing the localization agenda.



1

Evaluation Background

Introduction

The United Nations Children Fund (UNICEF) has commissioned an evaluation of its Level 3 (L3) emergency response to the 2023 earthquakes in Türkiye and Syria. This report covers UNICEF's L3 response in Syria; a second, separate report covers UNICEF's L3 response in Türkiye; and a third, the Overarching Report, draws on findings at country, regional and Headquarters (HQ) levels and focuses on issues of corporate-wide relevance.¹ These three reports should be read together and treated as the main deliverables from this evaluation.

This Syria evaluation report addresses the L3 response in two very divergent contextual and operating contexts: government-controlled areas (GCAs), led by the UNICEF Syria Country Office; and northwest Syria (NWS) non-government-controlled areas (NGCAs), led by the UNICEF Middle East and North Africa Regional Office (MENARO) Outpost in Gaziantep and Whole of Syria (WoS) staff. The findings, conclusions and recommendations (for immediate

actions and future crises) have been clearly delineated for both regions to ensure they are relevant to the specificity of each context and are, therefore, as useful as possible for the Syria Country Office and MENARO Outpost. By taking this approach, the evaluation aligns with UNICEF's Syria L3 Evaluation (2022),² which identified the need to recognize the distinct challenges of responding to needs in GCAs on the one hand and NGCAs on the other. The evaluation thereby avoids a 'compare and contrast' exercise between these two distinct theatres in the earthquake response.

The report is structured as follows:

- ▶ Section 1 of the report provides a description of the intervention and outlines the evaluation purpose, intended users, objectives, scope and focus areas for GCAs and NGCAs in the evaluation.
- ▶ Section 2 presents the evaluation approach and methodology, including evaluation questions, a reconstructed logic model identifying outcome pathways, data collection and analysis methods, and key limitations.

¹ The third, the Overarching Report, will draw on evaluation findings at country, regional and HQ levels and will focus on three main areas selected for their corporate-wide relevance: first, preparedness, roll-out of the emergency procedures and associated application of the No Regrets approach; second, needs assessments and targeting and alignment of Humanitarian Action for Children (HAC) with United Nations (UN)-wide Flash and other appeals; third, internal coordination among UNICEF departments and the Outpost/Country Offices (COs)/Regional Offices (ROs)/HQ – especially around early onset resource mobilisation, Human Resources (HR) surge and supply & logistics. The reports are therefore complementary and designed to be used as one evaluation.

² Evaluation of UNICEF's L3 Response in Syria (2022), p.127.

- ▶ Section 3 elaborates upon the context in Syria within which the earthquake took place and explores UNICEF's evolving role and strategy in the L3 response.
- ▶ Sections 4–9 present the evaluation findings, structured around the key evaluation questions. A summary of findings is provided at the outset of each section and subsection. Where possible, the finding summaries have been combined for both regions of Syria. However, where findings are divergent and require more specificity, they have been presented separately.
- ▶ Sections 10 and 11 present the summary of conclusions linked to recommendations.

Description of the intervention

As described in the Terms of Reference (TOR) for this evaluation (Annex 18), in Syria UNICEF's L3 response aimed to address the immediate life-saving and urgent humanitarian needs of girls, boys, adolescents and families through an integrated and gender-responsive approach, prioritizing highly affected areas and areas of large displacement. UNICEF's priorities were to restore essential health and water, sanitation and hygiene (WASH), provide psychosocial support (PSS), provide family separation support and protection case management, and provide cash and winter items where possible. UNICEF leveraged the established system for accountability to affected populations (AAP) and ensured measures were in place for the prevention of gender-based violence (GBV) and sexual exploitation. UNICEF appealed for US\$172 million to reach 5.4 million people, including 2.6 million children, between February and May 2023.³ UNICEF continued to lead or co-lead the cluster coordination of WASH, nutrition and education, as well as the area of responsibility (AoR) for Child Protection (CP) at the national and subnational levels. A more detailed description of the intervention is provided in Section 3.3.

Evaluation purpose, objectives and scope

Evaluation purpose and intended users

The evaluation of UNICEF's L3 earthquake response has both an accountability purpose and a learning purpose. In terms of accountability, it fulfils the requirement of the UNICEF Evaluation Policy⁴ whereby all L3 emergencies must be evaluated. The evaluation has sought to address the level of UNICEF performance against its envisaged objectives and the needs on the ground, with a view to strengthening UNICEF's AAP, partners and donors. The evaluation further gauges to what extent the preparedness and implementation of the response were congruent with UNICEF emergency procedures and related processes.

With regard to learning, the evaluation aims to analyse the evidence as to what worked and did not work about the response. This will inform the work of the UNICEF Syria and Türkiye Country Offices as well as that of the Europe and Central Asia (ECA) and Middle East and North Africa (MENA) Regional Offices, the WoS approach, and various divisions in UNICEF HQ, especially with regard to their strategies, programming, operations, and humanitarian responses to other future sudden onset disasters. A full list of intended users is provided in Annex 13.

³ UNICEF, [Earthquake Response for Children of the Syrian Arab Republic](#). 2023.

⁴ Revised 2023.

Evaluation objectives

The general objective (as described in the TOR) of the evaluation is to provide a comprehensive assessment of UNICEF's organization-wide L3 earthquake response in Syria (including GCAs and NGCAs), measured against UNICEF's own mandate, corporate commitments, stated objectives and standard evaluation criteria, including appropriateness, effectiveness, connectedness, coherence and coordination. The evaluation also examines the extent to which cross-cutting issues – protection from sexual exploitation and abuse (PSEA), social and behaviour change (SBC), protection needs, climate change (CC), gender, and disabilities – were systematically and meaningfully integrated in the response.

Evaluation scope for the Syria Country Report⁵

Thematic scope: The evaluation assesses the programmatic, operational and cross-cutting dimensions of the response since the L3 activation. It also includes a review of the preparedness actions that preceded the scale-up and an assessment of the recovery efforts.

Geographic scope: In Syria, the scope includes areas impacted by the earthquake in GCAs and NGCAs and the L3 response enacted by UNICEF and its partners from the Syria Country Office, including Field Offices (FOs) and the NWS Outpost in Gaziantep.

Temporal scope: The focus is on the period of the L3 Corporate Emergency Activation Procedure from February 2023 to March 2024. Attention has also been given to preparedness planning prior to the earthquake in February 2023 and to early recovery and resilience building strategies in the recovery stage of the response.

Focus areas in Syria GCAs and NWS NGCAs

During the inception period, the Evaluation Team developed a tailored evaluation approach to account for the very different contexts in the Syria GCAs and in NWS NGCAs.

Syria GCAs: In these areas, the UNICEF L3 response was operationalized from Damascus and the FOs. These areas have been subject to long-term protracted humanitarian crises, with high numbers of displaced persons. The Evaluation Team addressed all the relevant evaluation questions (as presented in the matrix in Annex 1). However, given the context in Syria GCAs and the importance of capturing formative findings for this evaluation, a stronger focus has been placed on the **criteria of coherence (positioning with government partners and the UN) and connectedness (considerations focused more closely on resilience building and effective partnerships with implementing partners).**

NWS NGCAs: The UNICEF L3 response in NWS was operationalized by the MENARO Gaziantep Outpost and its Implementing Partners using a cross-border approach. This region has also been subject to long-term humanitarian crises and a large, fluid internally displaced person (IDP) population. In the NWS context, the Evaluation Team focused more closely on the **criteria of coordination (particularly with regard to effective partnerships and localization with national Implementing Partners) and connectedness (resilience building).**

⁵ The evaluation includes an assessment of the leadership and support provided by HQ divisions and MENARO, which is predominantly addressed in the Overarching Report.



2

Methodology

Overall evaluation approach

The evaluation is guided by the questions and approach articulated in the TOR (Annex 18) and by UNICEF stakeholder feedback during the inception period. It is not a theory-based evaluation but, as agreed with the UNICEF Evaluation Office, has drawn on a reconstructed logic model. The evaluation is both summative and formative and has been designed to ensure that the findings and recommendations are relevant and actionable and can measurably support decisions by the relevant UNICEF stakeholders. To help achieve this, the evaluation has followed three core principles:

- ▶ It is **learning and utilization-focused**, to ensure the generation of practical solutions to support UNICEF Headquarters, Regional Offices, Country Offices and MENARO Outpost to tackle challenges in the roll-out of L3 emergency responses and to improve the quality of their humanitarian operations;
- ▶ It is **field-focused**, to ensure that the evaluation adds as much value as possible to improvements and innovations at the field level, for the benefit of those most affected by emergency humanitarian crises;
- ▶ It is **participatory**, to ensure buy-in and ownership of the evaluation's findings and recommendations by UNICEF stakeholders.

Logic model

The Evaluation Team has developed a reconstructed logic model setting out the pathways between response activities, outputs and outcomes (Figure 1). The activities, outputs and outcomes have been extracted from the Syria Immediate Response Plan and Humanitarian Action for Children (HAC). The evaluation has reviewed the sector activities by the evaluation criteria and evaluation questions (Annex 1) to assess how, and if, they have led to the expected output results and contributed to the three outcome areas. The challenges of outcome measurement in emergencies are described in Section 2.6. The ways of working and UNICEF policies and procedures, primarily the Core Commitments for Children (CCCs), are mapped in the evaluation matrix and used as benchmarks analysing whether the intervention was operated in line with UNICEF commitments. Given the complexity of evaluating two very different regions in one evaluation, it is, by design, a simplified model to cover both contexts.

Figure 1. Syria L3 earthquake response logic model (reconstructed by Evaluation Team)

Evaluation criteria and questions

The evaluation matrix is formulated against the five evaluation criteria of appropriateness, effectiveness, connectedness, coherence and coordination. There is an additional sixth area that focuses on cross-cutting

themes. This is in line with the proposed evaluation criteria and questions outlined in the TOR. The full Evaluation Matrix in Annex 1 presents the sub-questions, key data sources and proposed data collection tools for the questions.

Table 1. Evaluation criteria and overarching evaluation questions

Evaluation criteria	Overarching evaluation questions
Appropriateness	To what extent: ▶ have UNICEF's response strategies and plans been adapted to the context? ▶ have UNICEF's response strategies and plans been aligned with global standards? ▶ have UNICEF's response strategies and plans been in line with the needs and preferences of the affected populations? ▶ has the response been multisectoral/integrated and coherent?
Effectiveness	▶ To what extent has UNICEF achieved its intended objectives for the response and commitments, including of coverage and quality consistent with standards and policies (CCCs)? What are the main factors that contributed to or hindered the ability to respond to the needs of the affected populations? ▶ To what extent have human resources, advocacy, communications, monitoring, evaluation, learning, reporting, managing information, resource mobilization (obtaining flexible/tied funding), supply and logistics (internal structure and processes) supported the response as per the emergency procedures and the expectation that needs on the ground be fully met?
Cross-cutting	▶ To what extent were cross-cutting themes – such as PSEA, SBC, the centrality of protection, CC, gender and disability inclusion dimensions – considered systematically and meaningfully to integrate in the needs assessments, planning, implementation, monitoring and reporting of the response?
Connectedness	▶ To what extent did the response take into account the humanitarian-development-peace nexus, including resilience, preparedness and longer-term development goals? ▶ Has the UNICEF team effectively planned/been planning or initiating actions linking the emergency response to longer-term development goals? ▶ What factors hindered or assisted in linking the emergency response to longer-term development goals?
Coherence	▶ To what extent has UNICEF collaborated, engaged and positioned itself with relevant government authorities and other United Nations (UN) agencies and UN-led coordination mechanisms during the response, and what effects (if any) did any of the above have on the ability of the response to meet the needs on the ground? ▶ What lessons can be drawn about how UNICEF can better position itself to be as effective as possible?

Evaluation criteria	Overarching evaluation questions
Coordination	▶ How did the coordination between HQ, ROs and COs contribute to or hinder the success of the response? (In the Overarching Report, this question will include looking at coordination <i>across</i> ROs.) ▶ To what extent has UNICEF provided appropriate and context-specific leadership and coordination for the clusters and areas under its responsibilities? ▶ To what extent has UNICEF formed effective partnerships with its Implementing Partners (both national and international)? To what extent has UNICEF advanced the localization agenda during the response implementation?

Data collection

The evaluation employed a range of methods, including a document review, context analysis, semi-structured key informant interviews (KIIs), focus group discussions (FGDs) and an online survey of UNICEF staff. The data collection was underpinned by a sampling strategy for GCAs and NGCAs, whereby nine stakeholder groups were identified for FGDs or KIIs. For the data collection in NWS, recipients of UNICEF services and service providers were sampled in camps in earthquake-affected NGCAs. The sampling was purposive of both sector and multi-sector interventions covering CP, education, nutrition, health, and WASH. The more detailed sampling strategy is presented in Annex 15. The data collection in this evaluation has been subject to Itad's ethical procedures and received UNICEF's HML IRB ethics approval (presented in Annex 14).

Document and literature review: There has been an iterative document and literature review throughout the evaluation. During inception, the Evaluation Team analysed a wide range of UNICEF policy documents, reporting data and field-level data. The evaluation was appreciative of a wide set of surge mission reports that were made available to the Evaluation Team. UNICEF dashboards, Results Assessment Module (RAM) reports and situation reports (SitReps) have been used extensively to inform results reporting and financial analysis. The evaluation has maximized the use of relevant evaluation sources. Internal audit reports (from the Office of Internal Audit and Investigations (OIAI)) have been analysed, and previous evaluations on UNICEF corporate issues, such as cluster functionality⁶ and the WoS Review,⁷ have informed the evaluation. More general evaluations on Syria and external reviews on the earthquake response have been consulted alongside UNICEF's internal earthquake response reflections.⁸ See Annex 8 for the full list of sources consulted.

⁶ Evaluation of the UNICEF Role as Cluster Lead/Co-Lead Agency – CLARE II (UNICEF, 2022).

⁷ Four main documents from the WoS Review were shared with the Evaluation Team: WoS Review Mapping of Coordination Structures (14 November 2023); WoS Review Phase 1 Report Final (28 November 2023); Recommendations on Priority Programme Areas and Effective Modalities for UNICEF Support to Children in Northwest Syria via Cross-Border Operations; and WoS Recommendations for Risk Management.

⁸ UNICEF, GZT XB NWS 2 Months Post-Earthquake Mini-Moment of Reflection. 6 April 2023; UNICEF, Syria Earthquake Response: Internal After-Action Review Summary Note. June 2023; IASC Operational. Peer Review Mission Report. Syria Earthquake. 2-13 July 2023; iMMAP and USAID, Post-Earthquake Perspective: Challenges and Strategies for Humanitarian Aid in Northwest Syria. Building Resilience: An Analysis of Principled Humanitarian Action in the Protracted Crisis of Northwest Syria, Ad Hoc Series Part 2. 17 September 2023; Recommendations on priority programme areas and effective modalities for UNICEF support to children in NW Syria via cross border; UNICEF, Syria RO-HQ Social Protection and Cash Peer Review Report. June 2023. Final draft; UNICEF, [Coping with a Disaster. How Behaviour Change and Community Engagement Supported Survivors of the February 2023 Earthquake in Syria](#). November 2023; iMMAP and USAID, [Post-Earthquake Perspective, Challenges and Strategies for Humanitarian Aid in Northwest Syria](#). System Failure: How the Earthquakes Exposed the Limits of the International System in Northwest Syria, Ad Hoc Series Part 1. 15 June 2023; Evaluation of UNICEF's L3 Response in Syria (2022).

Context analysis: The context analysis was conducted through primary sources (KIIs and discussions held by the Evaluation Team when collecting data in Syria and Gaziantep). The analysis was also informed by the document review, focusing on different political, financial and human rights contexts in Syria. The context review has been used to understand how these factors impacted the L3 response in both regions.

Table 2. Number of KIIs by group

Number of KIIs: Syria (GCAs and NGCAs)	
Donor	4
Government	3
Implementing Partners (NWS and Syria Country Office)	13
Third party – third-party monitor (TPM), third-party facilitator (TPF)	2
UN partners	6
MENARO	11
NWS Outpost	9*
Syria Country Office	19
WoS	6
HQ and Emergency Operations (EMOPS)	7
Inception	9
TOTAL	89

*Includes 1 FGD with the team who were in post during the earthquake.

Semi-structured KIIs: During the Syria evaluation, 89 semi-structured KIIs were conducted. The KII questions were mapped to the evaluation matrix and are presented in Annex 17. These combined both remote and in-person interviews. As highlighted in the inception methodology, all the KIIs in Syria GCAs were conducted remotely. A full interview list is provided in Annex 3, and Table 2 shows the number of KIIs conducted across Syria, mapped against identified evaluation stakeholders. In line with UNICEF's Do No Harm protocol, the NWS Implementing Partners' names have been coded.

FGDs and KIIs with affected populations using UNICEF emergency response services in NWS:

The Evaluation Team developed a specific FGD question guide for data collection with recipients of UNICEF services in NWS. This guide is presented in Annex 17. In May 2023, four FGDs were held with affected populations in five camps in the districts of Jebel Saman, Atarab, Afrin and A'zaz in NWS. Four KIIs were conducted with UNICEF service providers in these camps. These locations were selected based on where sampled Implementing Partners were implementing earthquake response services. Table 3 shows the breakdown (including by gender) of the participants.



Table 3. FGDs conducted with affected communities and number of participants

District	Community	Sector	Respondents	
			Female	Male
FGDs				
Jebel Saman	Abin Samaan	WASH	5	5
Atarab	Batbu	Education	8	
Afrin	Afrin	Protection	7	
A'zaz	Akhtrein	Nutrition	8	
		TOTAL	28	5
KIIs (Camp Managers)				
Jebel Saman	Batbu	Education		1
A'zaz	A'zaz	Protection		1
Afrin	Afrin	Protection		1
A'zaz	Akhtrein	Health		1

Online surveys for UNICEF personnel: To gather further perspectives from UNICEF staff, an online survey was conducted across the Syria Country Office, including FOs, Gaziantep MENARO Outpost Office and WoS personnel based in Amman, in April–May 2023. The questions aligned with key lines of enquiry as presented in the evaluation matrix. The survey questions are presented in Annex 17. The response rate is shown in Table 4.

Table 4. Number of survey respondents

Region	# of respondents
Syria Country Office	37
WoS	2
Gaziantep MENARO Outpost	15
Total respondents	54

Data analysis

Overall approach to data analysis and synthesis

Data and evidence were ordered and coded using the analytical framework shown in Figure 2. Results from the different data sources were triangulated with one another to verify and strengthen implementation findings and contributions to strategic outcomes.

The systematic review of documents, data, KIIs and surveys was designed to critically examine the topics of interest under each of the evaluation questions, uncovering the details about how and why any changes came about. The evaluation adopted a pragmatic but systematic approach to analyse the data, draw conclusions, and provide recommendations. This followed the process outlined below:

Step 1. Coding and initial analysis of the data:

The MAXQDA coding software was used to code all data sources. The code system was linked explicitly to the evaluation matrix, with the flexibility to capture important and unexpected new themes and lessons learned as they emerged.

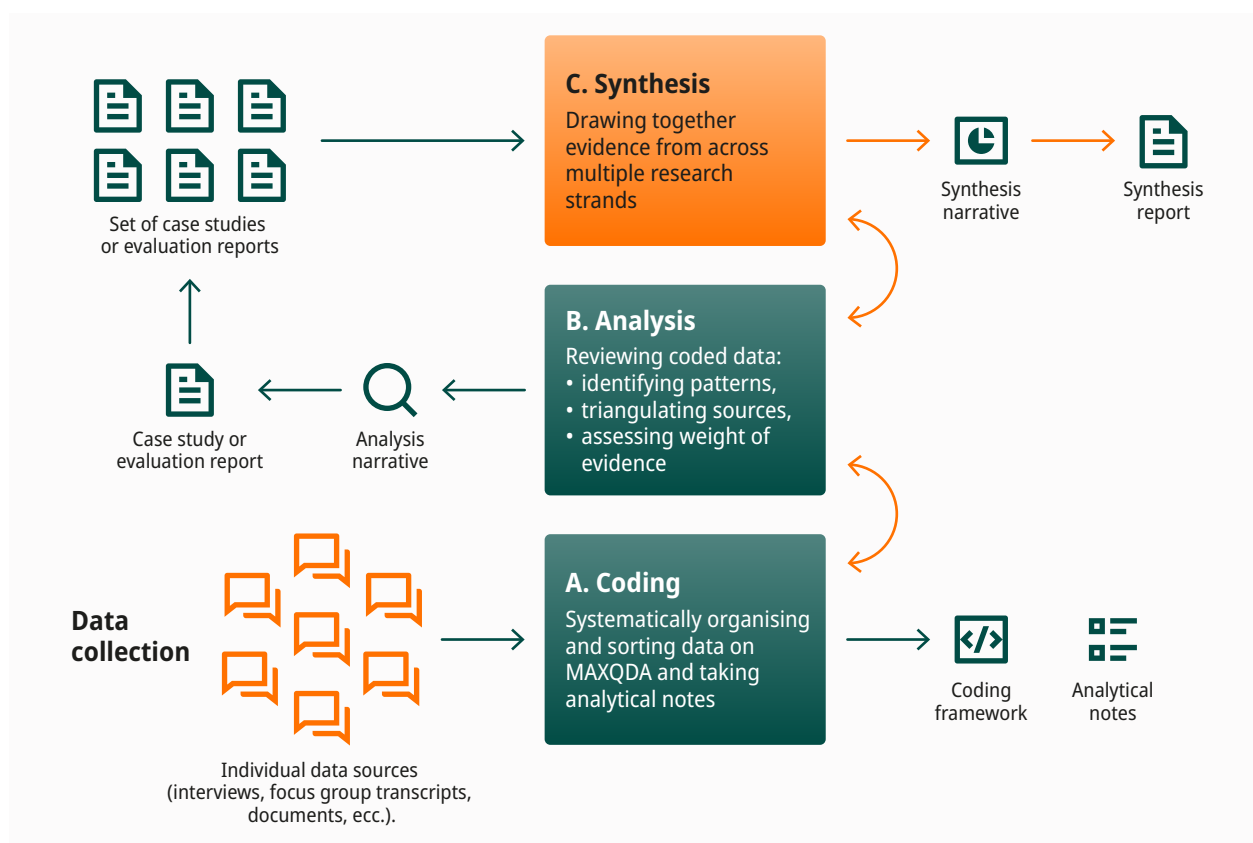
Step 2. Iterative mapping of themes: Emerging themes from across the whole dataset were summarized by drawing out connections and relationships between the themes and linking and merging them.

Thematic matrices, constructed with the aid of the coded segments from MAXQDA, were used to identify patterns and trends across a wide dataset. They allowed data to be arranged coherently and concisely to permit careful comparisons, detections of differences, and identification of patterns, themes and trends.

Step 3. Systematic review of themes: The team returned to the data to seek examples and assess the weight of significance of the emerging themes. Where possible at this stage for each theme, the Evaluation Team gathered both a qualitative narrative around how and why approaches and strategies have been relevant, effective, coherent and equitable, and a quantitative indication from UNICEF data of the factors involved. The Evaluation Team ensured that several members of the team were involved in this process, as an inbuilt challenge function, using a set of standards for the strength of evidence, denoting where this was strong, moderate or weak. The strongest evidence was sufficiently detailed and triangulated from several different sources.

Step 4. Evidence summary: All items of evidence related to a given evaluation question were then clustered in an Evidence Summary Table where the team summarized key evidence against each of the thematic areas. These evidence summary tables formed the basis of the evaluation report structure.



Figure 2. Approach to data analysis

Approach to gender analysis

As stated in the evaluation TOR and the description of the intervention, one of UNICEF's key objectives was to operationalize a gender-responsive approach in the response. The evaluation design has considered the need to mainstream gender analysis throughout the evaluation and not just address these issues in the cross-cutting section elaborated in the evaluation matrix. In line with UNICEF's *Gender Policy and Action Plan 2022-2025*,⁹ where relevant the evaluation analysed response interventions along the gender continuum illustrated in Figure 3. This required the Evaluation Team to use their judgement to determine how interventions fell in the range of:

- ▶ gender-discriminatory (for example, services or assistance provided to only one gender at the exclusion of another)

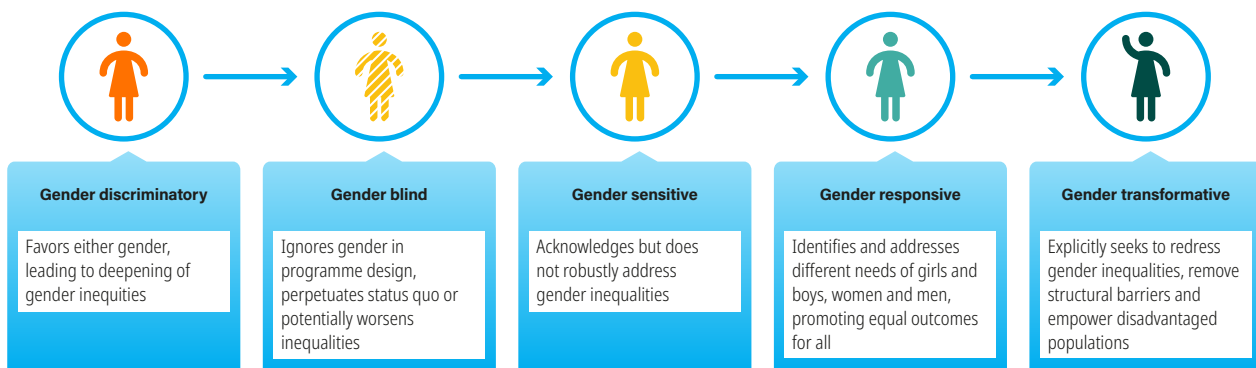
- ▶ gender-blind (instances where, for example, there was no gender-disaggregation in planning and reporting documents)
- ▶ gender-sensitive in terms of acknowledging different gender needs (for example, provision of separate latrines in the camps)
- ▶ gender-responsive and meeting the objective of the L3 response by addressing different needs of boys and girls and contributing to more equal outcomes (for example: provision of education in menstrual hygiene; initiatives to increase availability of menstrual supplies).¹⁰

Given the stated objectives of the UNICEF L3 response, the evaluation will not determine whether activities were gender-transformative unless this was an unintended outcome. This continuum will provide an overall frame for gender analysis that is broad enough to encompass different interventions in very different contexts.¹¹

⁹ Rachel Marcus, Fiona Samuels, Shoubo Jalal, and Helen Belachew, *Background Paper Series; UNICEF Gender Policy and Action Plan 2022-2025 - Gender-Transformative Programming*. 2021, p.1.

¹⁰ Example provided in Rachel Marcus, Fiona Samuels, Shoubo Jalal, and Helen Belachew, *Background Paper Series; UNICEF Gender Policy and Action Plan 2022-2025 - Gender-Transformative Programming*. 2021, p.9.

¹¹ UNICEF has acknowledged that there are challenges in using the continuum model: "Our consultations suggest that in practice, practitioners and project managers do not always find the continuum easy to apply, given the number and fine-ness of its distinctions. We caution against too strong a focus on categorizing where programmes fall on the continuum (which could become a rather technical and 'tick-box' exercise)." Rachel Marcus, Fiona Samuels, Shoubo Jalal, and Helen Belachew, *Background Paper Series; UNICEF Gender Policy and Action Plan 2022-2025 - Gender-Transformative Programming*. 2021, p.4.

Figure 3. The gender continuum¹²

Limitations

There were six main limitations in the evaluation, relating to the methodological approach, context diversity, use of UNICEF data sources, and implementation of data collection with affected populations and government officials in GCAs. These limitations are in common with the typical challenges of conducting complex emergency evaluations. In all cases, the Evaluation Team endeavoured to find mitigation strategies to counter each limitation.

Methodological challenges: The first methodological challenge in this evaluation was assessing outcome-level results. This is because in the UNICEF L3 response, in common with many other emergency responses, results were measured at output level rather than at outcome level. The scope of this evaluation is broad and spans a wide range of diverse results pathways across multiple thematic areas, programme sectors and operating environments. In complex emergency settings such as Syria, data and evidence gaps have likely compounded the challenge of assessing outcome-level results. The evaluation has tried to mitigate this challenge by looking at interventions to assess whether they have the *potential* for transformative change at outcome level in terms of approaches employed and indicators that measure change levels rather than just reach targets. The analysis of the WAQTI model presented in Section 4.3 is an example of this approach.

The second methodological limitation relates to breadth versus depth. The scope of the evaluation as presented in the TOR questions was very broad and required coverage of many operational and

programmatic questions for both GCAs and NGCAs. To partly address this limitation, the evaluation adopted a ‘focus area’ approach, whereby the most contextually relevant lines of enquiry were applied with more focus and specificity to certain regions and countries (see Table 1). However, the evaluation necessarily has been calibrated to breadth rather than depth in some areas. A related limitation was the question presented in the TOR on the extent to which the response was “aligned with global standards, principles and commitments to the CCCs, human rights, humanitarian principles, do no harm, conflict sensitivity and centrality of protection.”¹³ This is a very broad-spectrum question and is difficult to answer comprehensively in one section. To mitigate this limitation, the Evaluation Team identified a discrete set of areas of alignment and challenges in adherence to global principles and the CCCs (see Section 4.2). By mapping the CCCs and other policy commitments to each question in the evaluation matrix, the evaluation has been able to address alignment to the CCCs (in particular) throughout the wider report.

Context diversity: The UNICEF TOR for the L3 response provided a set of evaluation questions that were intended to cover the response in Türkiye, NWS NGCAs and Syria GCAs. However, the significant contextual differences between these countries and regions made the meaningful application of a ‘one size fits all’ evaluation matrix very challenging. In the case of the criteria on coherence and coordination with government authorities (Sections 8 and 9), these questions have, out of necessity, been adapted to each country and region, in recognition of the vastly differing governance arrangements in Türkiye, Syrian GCAs and Syrian NGCAs.

¹² Ibid.

¹³ Appropriateness criteria, question 1.b; UNICEF Evaluation TOR, p.8.

Use of internal data sources: The evaluation found that the figures for the WoS results (i.e., reach against set targets) did not always align between different datasets as presented in SitReps, dashboards and RAM reports. This has made determining results very challenging. The evaluation has sought to address this issue by using dashboard data (as shared by the Syria Country Office) as the primary results determinant. This limitation was also encountered with UNICEF global financial reporting and is explored in more detail in the Overarching Report.

Implementation of data collection with government officials in GCAs: Despite the best efforts on the part of the Evaluation Team and Syria Country Office, only three government key informants were available to participate in this evaluation. Therefore, for findings related to UNICEF's partnership with the government, evidence has been drawn from internal stakeholders, partners, and secondary sources.

Implementation of data collection with affected populations: Data collection among affected populations in the camps in NWS took place 15 months after the initial earthquake response. Many of the participants acknowledged at the outset of the FGDs that they struggled to remember the exact assistance provided, owing to trauma and the amount of time that had passed since the early interventions. The evaluation balanced this limitation by also undertaking KIIs with UNICEF-funded service providers in the health and education sectors who had taken part directly in the response, to triangulate with FGD feedback.



3

Context and role of UNICEF in the earthquake response in Syria

Overall context

On 6 February 2023, a powerful (7.8 magnitude) earthquake hit southeast Türkiye and NWS, causing widespread damage and destruction in both countries.¹⁴ The earthquake was followed by aftershocks that affected at least 8.8 million people in Syria.¹⁵

This disaster further exacerbated the protracted humanitarian crisis in Syria, compounded by a cholera outbreak in 2022 as a result of which UNICEF was already providing assistance in the country. Even before the earthquake, Syria was facing one of the world's most complex emergencies, with significant humanitarian needs, displacement and destruction of civilian and social infrastructure.¹⁶ In 2021, 13.4 million people, including 6.08 million children, were estimated to be in need of humanitarian assistance. For children that represented an increase of 27 per cent compared to 2020.¹⁷ Sustained economic downturn and the damage of physical infrastructure, particularly social service sectors such as water and sanitation services, decimated people's access

to basic services. The impact on society has been profound: 5.6 million were internally displaced in 2022, of whom 2.5 million were children.¹⁸ The gender gap has worsened since the conflict broke out in 2011 – indicated by, for instance, an increase in child marriages for young women and girls.¹⁹ The health situation has also deteriorated; for instance, between 2008 and 2019 the under-five mortality rate increased from 17.8 deaths per 1,000 live births to nearly 23.7.²⁰ The COVID-19 pandemic, followed by a severe cholera outbreak in 2022, has put further pressure on the health care system. It is in this context that UNICEF was providing integrated multisectoral programming, to improve access to critical basic services where needs were highest.²¹

The earthquake further aggravated the situation, and the number of people requiring humanitarian assistance increased from 14.6 million to 16.7 million by December 2023.²² Of those earthquake-affected populations, 41 per cent were children under 18 years of age, and 11 per cent were adults over 60. Forty-eight per cent of the population were women and

¹⁴ OCHA, [Türkiye: 2023 Earthquakes Situation Report No. 6](#), As of 3 March 2023.

¹⁵ OCHA, [Flash Appeal: Syrian Arab Republic](#). 2023.

¹⁶ UNICEF, [Country Office Annual Report 2023: Syrian Arab Republic](#). 2023.

¹⁷ UNICEF, [Country programme document: Syrian Arab Republic](#). 2022.

¹⁸ UNICEF, [Country programme document: Syrian Arab Republic](#). 2022.

¹⁹ Government of the Syrian Arab Republic, [The First National Report on the Sustainable Development Goals SDGs, 2019](#).

²⁰ UNICEF, [January to March 2023: Whole of Syria: Health and Nutrition Response](#). 2023.

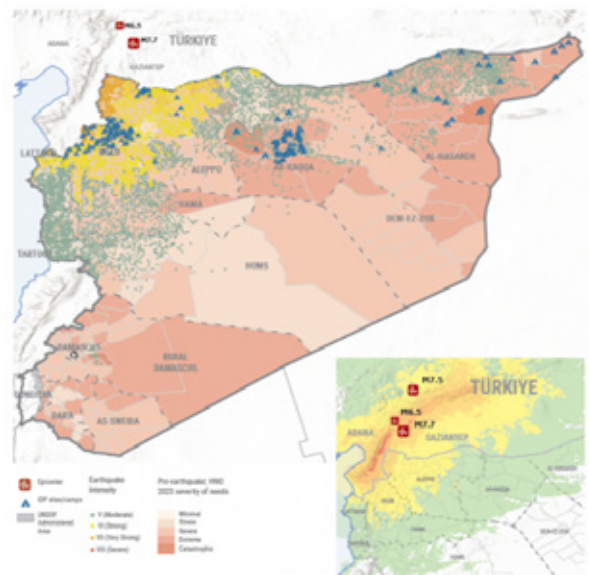
²¹ UNICEF, [Syrian Arab Republic: Consolidated Emergency Report 2023](#). 2024.

²² UNICEF, [Country Office Annual Report 2023: Syrian Arab Republic](#). 2023.

girls, who faced heightened vulnerabilities to sexual exploitation and abuse (SEA) and GBV.²³ According to the Humanitarian Needs Assessment Programme (HNAP), approximately 27 per cent of the population in GCAs and 33 per cent in NGCAs were disabled prior to the earthquake, and those numbers undoubtedly rose after 6 February 2023. It is within this context that the UNICEF intervention described in Section 3.3 took place.

The earthquake impacted 10 governorates in Syria, comprising 43 districts and 170 subdistricts, and all were exposed to shaking levels V to VII on the modified Mercalli intensity scale.²⁴ The governorate of Aleppo was the most-affected area in the country, along with approximately 3 million people in Idlib governorate. More than 1,700 buildings were destroyed in NWS and more than 5,700 were partially destroyed.²⁵ In addition to impacting 4.5 million people living in NWS, up to 4 million people in GCAs were also affected.²⁶

Figure 4. Earthquake intensity by community (Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA), Flash Appeal Syria - February - May 2023)



The earthquake resulted in more than 677,000 internal displacements in Syria, which is almost four times the total number of displacements resulting from the crisis dating from 2014.²⁷ The majority of internally displaced persons (IDPs) were from Aleppo, Idlib and Latakia governorates, which are also the locations where more than 50 per cent of all conflict-IDPs reside.²⁸ The initial movement of earthquake-displaced people in NWS was very ad hoc, and many people established temporary camps across the region. The dynamic nature of movement and displacement complicated needs assessments at the outset of the response.

Annex 11 provides a detailed analysis of the humanitarian consequences of the earthquake for children and their families in terms of food insecurity, health and nutrition, WASH, education, and social protection (SP).



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²³ OCHA, Earthquake rapid assessment – HCT response area. 2023.

²⁴ The Mercalli intensity scale (or, more precisely, the Modified Mercalli intensity scale) is a scale to measure the intensity of earthquakes. Unlike with the Richter scale, the Mercalli scale does not take the energy of an earthquake into account directly. Rather, they classify earthquakes by the effects they have and the destruction they cause.

²⁵ OCHA, Flash Appeal: Syrian Arab Republic. 2023.

²⁶ OCHA, Flash Appeal: Syrian Arab Republic. 2023.

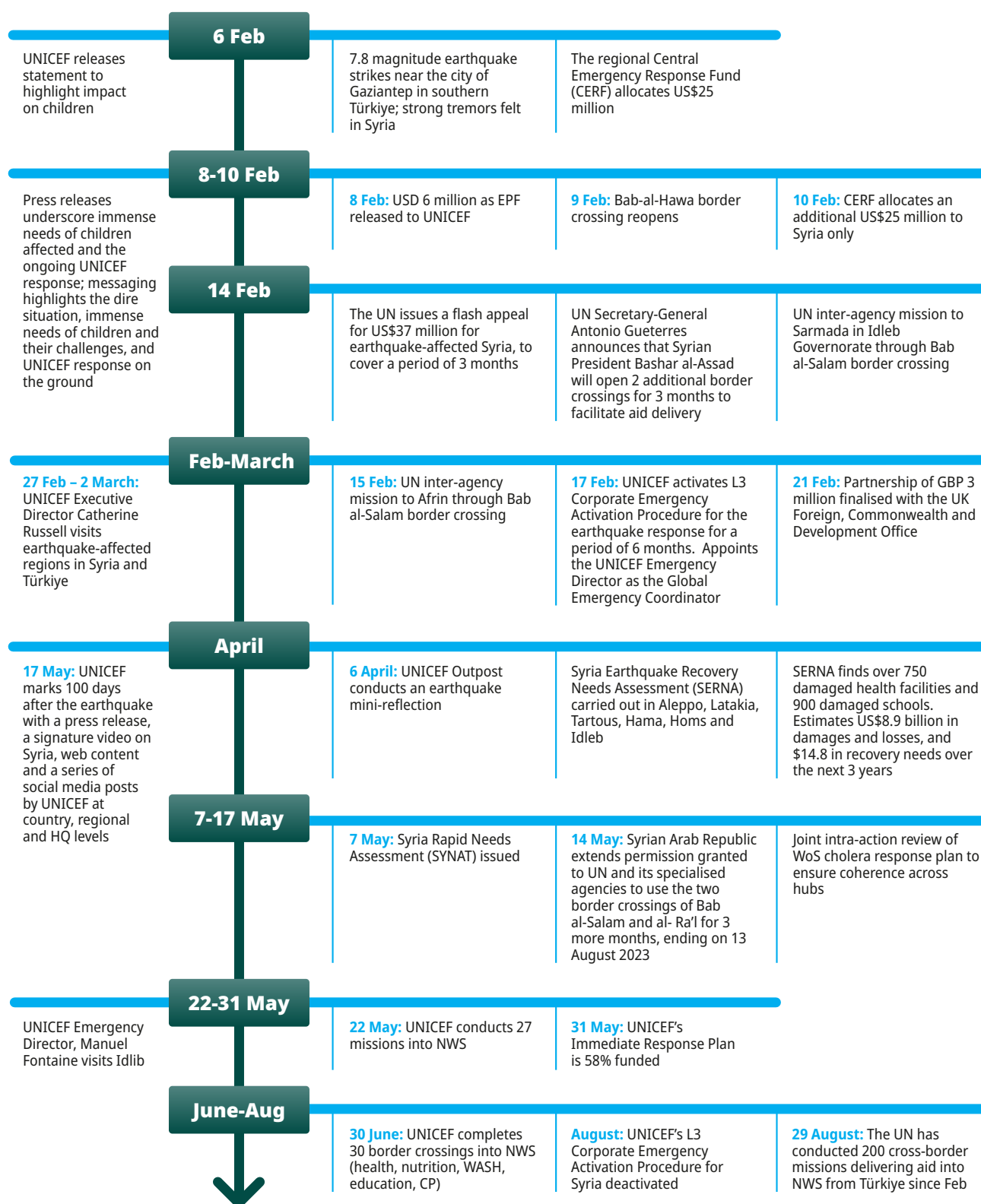
²⁷ IDMC, Shaken to the core in Syria. 9 August 2023.

²⁸ IDMC, Shaken to the core in Syria. 9 August 2023.

The international humanitarian aid context post-earthquake

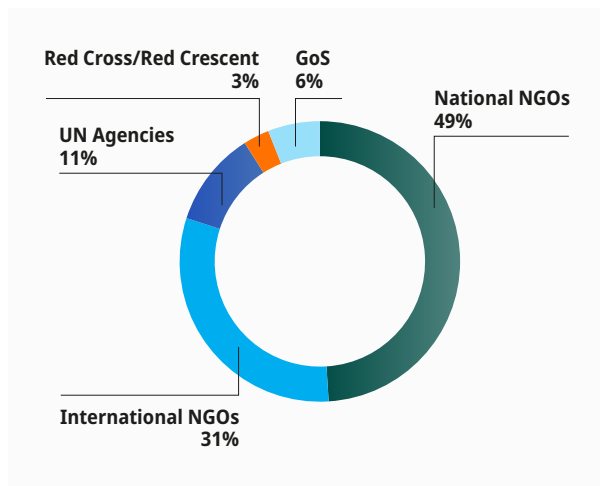
Figure 5 presents the timeline of the earthquake response in Syria, highlighting key international and UNICEF-specific events.

Figure 5. Timeline of earthquake and response in Syria



In March 2023, OCHA reported that 88 organizations were assisting with the earthquake response in Syria. These are broken down by category in Figure 6.²⁹ At the immediate outset of the response, the impact and trauma on international and national responders in Syria (and those working on cross-border assistance in Gaziantep) was immense. The evaluation has considered the situation of survivors as responders when assessing the results of the intervention.

Figure 6. Partners responding to the earthquakes in Syria (OCHA, [Syrian Arab Republic Earthquake response dashboard](#), 6 Feb- 23 Mar 2023)



Funding was needed that was both immediate and flexible for humanitarian organizations to address the critical needs on the ground. To respond directly, many organizations repositioned their funding towards the earthquake, despite some of the resources targeting already extremely vulnerable populations. On 7 February, the regional CERF allocated US\$25 million, with an additional US\$25 million on 10 February for Syria only.

Before the earthquake in NWS, the UN and international non-governmental organizations (INGOs) had no physical access into NWS, so programmes were operationalized remotely by Implementing Partners in the politically complex areas of Aleppo and Idlib. These areas are managed by de facto authorities (DfAs), although multiple factions exist beyond the DfAs in both regions. The Türkiye-backed Syrian Interim Government (SIG) controls the Aleppo region of NWS. Hay'at Tahrir al-Sham (HTS) has established

the Syrian Salvation Government (SSG) in Idlib. HTS is on international terrorist lists and is subject to sanctions. The earthquake response provided the opportunity for international aid organizations to gain access into NWS for the first time in eight years. This required a significant pivot from the remote programming approach prior to the earthquake. Access into NWS had implications for international organizations, including UNICEF, on the type of engagement strategy to pursue with the DfAs, the modality of access (whether to move towards a more sustained 'protective presence'), and recalibrating relationships with national Implementing Partners.

UNICEF's role and strategy in the L3 earthquake response

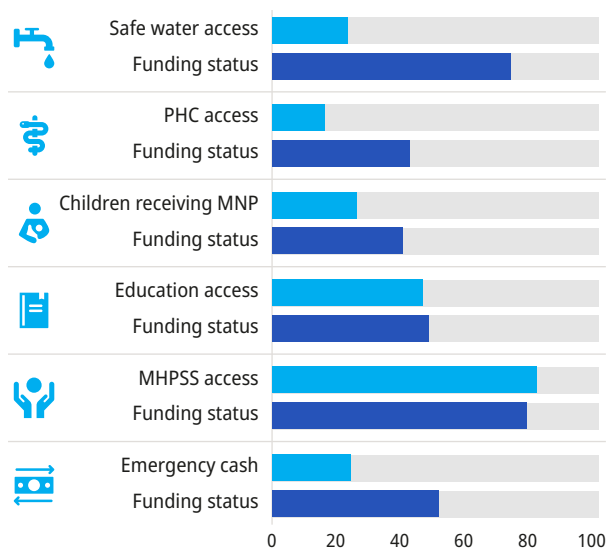
On 16 February 2023, UNICEF launched an Immediate Response Plan (which constituted part of the Inter-Agency Flash Appeal). The UNICEF funding target for the earthquake response for the WoS was set at US\$172.7 million, with targets allocated per sector and cross-sector. The Humanitarian Action Plan, HAC (which was underfunded prior to the emergency), was also revised as a result of the emergency, with a funding appeal for US\$328.5 million. HAC aimed to provide life-saving support to 7.8 million people (of whom 5 million were children). Of the total funding requirements, only 44.4 per cent was made available, and the highest funding needs were for WASH, health and education. These sectors were most resource-intensive because of the rehabilitation and restoration works required owing to the earthquake.³⁰ Figure 7 indicates UNICEF's response and funding status as of May 2023.³¹

²⁹ OCHA, [Syrian Arab Republic: Earthquake response dashboard \(HCT-coordinated response areas\)](#), 6 Feb - 30 Mar 2023, 4 April 2023.

³⁰ UNICEF Syria, [Humanitarian Action for Children \(HAC\) 2023 Revision 1](#), June 2023.

³¹ DRAFT Terms of Reference Note on Evaluation of UNICEF's L3 Response to the Earthquake in Syria and Türkiye, October 2023.

Figure 7. UNICEF's response and funding status as of May 2023 (Evaluation TOR)



UNICEF in Syria (GCAs and NGCAs) follows a WoS approach³² and prioritizes interventions across affected areas that are identified as high severity. UNICEF Syria leads the education, nutrition and WASH sectors/clusters as well as the CP AoR.³³ As the L3 response has evolved, UNICEF has gradually implemented early recovery programming in Syria while continuing to focus on humanitarian assistance, which includes the response to both the cholera outbreak and the earthquake. UNICEF has strategized a nexus approach to the early recovery phase by aiming to establish linkages between the needs-based emergency response and basic service restoration and resilience building.³⁴

During the first six months of 2023, UNICEF was able to reach more than 6.8 million people, including 1.9 million girls and 1.7 million boys.³⁵ In GCAs and NGCAs, usually UNICEF operationalized the response by scaling up existing partnerships and programmes. Although UNICEF and its partners were able to respond swiftly to the immediate needs of communities affected by the earthquakes in GCAs, infrastructural damage and international political bargaining over the Türkiye–NWS border crossings delayed the immediate wider UN response into NWS.

Despite these political machinations, which were beyond UNICEF's control, the MENARO Outpost had pre-positioned US\$6 million of supplies inside NWS as a contingency in case of the non-renewal of the UN Security Council Resolution (UNSCR) in January 2023.³⁶ As a result, when the earthquake hit, within 48 hours UNICEF partners were able to dispatch some (but not all) key life-saving supplies, such as hygiene kits, drinking water and high-energy biscuits, to the affected population.

In terms of sectoral and cross-cutting interventions to meet the response objectives, UNICEF coordinated with the UN and partners to conduct initial needs assessments. The needs assessments were more difficult to conduct in NWS owing to earthquake damage, the fluidity of displacement, the impact on partners, and the lack of a shared rapid needs assessment (RNA) tool.

In line with Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) 6, WASH was identified as a priority sector in the L3 response. UNICEF Syria's priority response activities in WASH included providing water trucking to shelters and affected communities in Aleppo, Hama, Idlib, Latakia and Tartous governorates, in addition to distributing non-food items to ensure that basic hygiene and water purification were present at household level. UNICEF Syria also provided water pumping into the network as a temporary solution until the elevated tanks were reinstalled. In NWS, UNICEF scaled up water trucking operations to increase reach from 175,000 persons to 732,000.³⁷ UNICEF also rehabilitated WASH facilities that were gender-sensitive for people in temporary settlements. Between January and June 2023, a total of 1,410,859 people, including 604,221 in NWS, were able to access safe water. SBC was applied in this sector response to raise awareness on good hygiene practices and improved sanitation practices.³⁸

In the area of health (SDG 3), UNICEF focused on life-saving interventions, including the provision of medical supplies, medical check-ups, and vaccinations. The Syria Country Office advocated with the

³² UNICEF carries out its humanitarian response through the SCO, based in Damascus, and its six FOs, in addition to the Gaziantep office (which is a MENARO Outpost Office situated in Türkiye) and the WoS office in Amman, Jordan.

³³ Under the Humanitarian Country Team's (HCT's) framework, which is led by the UN Humanitarian Coordinator.

³⁴ UNICEF Syria, Humanitarian Action for Children (HAC) 2023 Revision 1. June 2023.

³⁵ UNICEF, Humanitarian Situation Report: 1 January to 30 June 2023. 2023.

³⁶ Prior to the earthquake in 2023, the Bab al-Hawa border crossing was the main route for supplies from Türkiye into NWS. This crossing had been subject to the requirement of a new UNSCR every six months for the border to stay open. In early January, it was not certain that the UN Security Council (UNSC) would pass this resolution.

³⁷ UNICEF, [Immediate Response Plan For Syria \(Earthquake\)](#). 16 February 2023.

³⁸ UNICEF, [Immediate Response Plan For Syria \(Earthquake\)](#). 16 February 2023.

Ministry of Health (MoH) to expedite customs clearances for emergency medical shipments. UNICEF also increased availability of health services through the provision of static health centres and mobile medical teams, and supported the rehabilitation of primary health centres and capacity building of health workers on maternal and child health care.

In the area of nutrition (SDGs 2 and 3), the Syria Country Office focused on interventions to prevent child mortality and morbidity attributed to malnutrition. To achieve this, the response targeted more than 1 million people (including 452,000 children) in Aleppo, Idlib, Hama, Tartous and Lattakia with preventative and curative nutrition services. Rapid nutrition assessments were carried out, and high-energy biscuits were distributed to children aged 24–59 months as well as to pregnant and lactating women (PLW), and lipid-based nutrient supplements were supplied for children aged 6–23 months.³⁹ In NWS, UNICEF provided multiple micronutrient supplementation to address the increase in micronutrient deficiencies among children. Through the Cash Plus Nutrition programme, UNICEF was able to improve access to and awareness of suitable nutritionally balanced diets for PLW and caregivers with children under two years of age.

In education (SDG 4), the Syria Country Office prioritized the safe reopening of schools affected by the earthquake in Aleppo, Hama, Lattakia, Homs and Idlib to ensure that children could return to their schooling in a safe environment with the required gender-sensitive WASH facilities. Assisted by surge staff, the MENARO Outpost pioneered a multisector earthquake response named 'WAQTI.' This initiative integrated education, protection, health and SBC awareness raising in a geographically focused approach. Teachers and education personnel were also trained on providing mental health and psychosocial support (MHPSS) and learning recovery in these spaces.⁴⁰ Through the Adolescent Development and Participation (ADAP) programme in the Syria Country Office, 495,786 young people (including 259,942 females and 22,080 young persons with disabilities) were reached and engaged in youth-led initiatives, sports for development and awareness raising campaigns, which aimed to promote social cohesion and civic engagement within the communities.⁴¹

In GCAs, UNICEF was able to provide emergency cash assistance 96 hours after the earthquake hit Syria. UNICEF continued providing cash relief to 333,000 affected people (66,600 families) in Aleppo, Hama, Idlib and the coastal regions of the country to address their winterisation needs.⁴² In both regions, case management support was also provided to families with vulnerable children displaced because of the earthquake. Referrals and case management also focused on children without parental care, with significant efforts put towards tracing and reunification.⁴³ Risk communication and community engagement (RCCE) messaging on awareness of CP areas was carried out, with the objective of reducing the level of stress and the risks of violence against children, family separation, GBV, and negative coping strategies.⁴⁴



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³⁹ UNICEF, [Immediate Response Plan For Syria \(Earthquake\)](#). 16 February 2023.

⁴⁰ UNICEF, [Immediate Response Plan For Syria \(Earthquake\)](#). 16 February 2023.

⁴¹ UNICEF, [Syria Humanitarian Response Snapshot ADAP](#). January-October 2023.

⁴² UNICEF, [Immediate Response Plan For Syria \(Earthquake\)](#). 16 February 2023.

⁴³ UNICEF, [Immediate Response Plan For Syria \(Earthquake\)](#). 16 February 2023.

⁴⁴ UNICEF, [Immediate Response Plan For Syria \(Earthquake\)](#). 16 February 2023.



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4

Findings

The findings presented in this section are aligned with the five evaluation criteria (appropriateness, effectiveness, connectedness, coherence and coordination), with the addition of a section specifically focusing on cross-cutting issues.

A

Appropriateness

Adaptation to context, alignment with CCCs, and accountability to affected populations

B

Effectiveness

Extent to which approaches to coverage, advocacy and internal systems contributed to an effective response

C

Cross-cutting

Extent to which cross-cutting issues were considered and meaningfully integrated into the response

D

Connectedness

Extent to which the response considered the humanitarian–development–peace nexus and resilience-building

E

Coherence

Extent to which UNICEF had engaged with relevant government authorities and the UN system

F

Coordination

Extent to which UNICEF has provided coordination in the cluster/sectors and formed effective partnerships with implementing partners

A

Appropriateness

Adaptation to context, alignment with CCCs, and accountability to affected populations

Section A assesses the L3 response in Syria in terms of how the intervention applied corporate commitments to understand and address the needs of affected populations. This is assessed in terms of the extent to which UNICEF's response strategies have been adapted to the context in design, targeting, preparedness measures and application of the No Regrets approach. Appropriateness is also looked at through the lens of alignment to the CCCs. This section further analyses the alignment of the response strategies with the needs and preferences of affected populations and the extent to which the response was implemented in a multisector approach.



SUMMARY OF FINDINGS

The gravity of the impact of the earthquake on UNICEF partners and staff challenged early response activities such as developing quality needs assessments. However, these early difficulties were mitigated effectively by UNICEF's alignment within wider UN targeting, pre-existing preparedness measures (outside of the Emergency Preparedness Plan), and alignment with the CCCs in planning and implementing the L3 response. The application of the No Regrets approach, although hesitant at times, brought some innovative multisectoral initiatives to the fore that aimed to address needs at scale, with considerations for transformative outcomes in NWS. The evaluation found that UNICEF Implementing Partners were key to the application and coverage of AAP, but there was limited evidence that these mechanisms placed people at the centre of determining their own needs. The limited evidence was compounded by the use of an AAP indicator that focused solely on whether people were using feedback mechanisms.

Adaptation of UNICEF's response strategies to the context

Quality of the data to design the response

Finding 1

In GCAs and NGCAs, collecting quality data to design the response was challenging during the early stage of the earthquake response. In GCAs, government restrictions sometimes impacted upon timely and consistent data collection, although the Syria Country Office was able to use tools that generated child-focused, gender-disaggregated evidence that enabled the targeting of specific areas for integrated programming in the later phases of the response. In NGCAs, UNICEF Implementing Partners were initially overwhelmed by the gravity of the earthquake, but joint action with the humanitarian community (led by OCHA) helped to ramp up existing service provision and respond to need in newly created IDP camps.

In GCAs, the politicization of data has significantly constrained data access (before and during the response).⁴⁵ For some programmes, such as CP, where information can be sensitive, access to such data is even more challenging.⁴⁶ Although data has been crucial in the L3 response, challenges encountered to obtaining it included difficulties in obtaining government approvals and also restrictions during data collection for monitoring/evaluation of affected populations accessing services offered by partners.⁴⁷ During the initial phase of the response, there were inconsistencies between some of the data collected from UNICEF and that collected from sector partners. For example, UNICEF Syria Country Office developed a tool for CP that highlighted misleading information collected from other sector partners on the number of unaccompanied children in Latakia. Elaborating on this point, a key informant explained: "The emergency team in Latakia suddenly announced that we had 3,000 unaccompanied children, but when we had our team use the assessment tool that I created on Kobo, we realized that they were reporting the same children more than a hundred times. It was

really exaggerated." Despite these challenges, efforts were made to strengthen evidence generation, analysis and strategic use of this data. In 2023 UNICEF completed the Child Well-Being Monitoring (CWM) rounds 2 and 3, which generated child-focused, gender-disaggregated evidence that enabled the targeting of specific areas for integrated programming in the later phases of the response.⁴⁸ The approaches used by the Syria Country Office to mitigate data challenges are elaborated further below.

In NWS, obtaining quality data at the outset of the response was difficult. In late 2022, the International Organization for Migration (IOM)-led H NAP data collection tool was suspended, and this emerged as a key challenge in the collection of consistent and quality data for all UN agencies at the outset of the earthquake response. This data gap was "significant," but the use of REACH data "brought in some sense in the early days of the response."⁴⁹

In the first two weeks it was very challenging to get a clear understanding of needs, given the ad hoc establishment of many different camps and a highly mobile population. The needs assessment challenges were mitigated early in the response with joint action by the humanitarian community (through OCHA) agreeing that the population impacted by the earthquake was the same as the People in Need (PiN) – 4.1 million people out of 4.5 million. This improved planning in the existing service provision as well as scale-up in areas of newly created IDP camps.⁵⁰ Given UNICEF's lack of access to NWS in the immediate L3 scale-up, the Implementing Partners, who had many years of experience responding to health and conflict-related emergencies, led on the initial data collection. The Implementing Partners, who were highly impacted themselves by the earthquake, undertook the early assessments but struggled to collect accurate data at the outset, owing to the gravity of the disaster (in terms of personal impact and infrastructural damage) in NWS.⁵¹

⁴⁵ ACAPS, Thematic Report: Syria - Data and analysis ecosystem. 18 August 2023.

⁴⁶ UNICEF, Syria Surge Final Report, Sourav Bhattacharjee. 2023.

⁴⁷ UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

⁴⁸ UNICEF 2023 End of Year Summary Narrative Report. 2023.

⁴⁹ KII NWS (UN) 04/24.

⁵⁰ Outpost Office comments on Draft Evaluation Report: July 2024.

⁵¹ KII NWS 05/24; KII 04/24.

Targeting and alignment within the UN-wide response

Finding 2

In GCAs, the Syria Country Office was active in aligning with UN-wide targets and participating in joint assessments. This was facilitated through the recruitment of surge staff supporting the sector coordination mechanisms. In the case of NWS, the Outpost did align with OCHA-led targeting, which was critical in coalescing the broader response to an agreed set of targets.

UNICEF Syria Country Office's active presence in various coordination mechanisms enabled it to ensure alignment of its targets with the sector response. It also had a strong presence at the HCT and Area Humanitarian Coordination Team (AHCT) levels. UNICEF brought in surge staff to support in intersectoral collaboration and representation at the intersectoral coordination (ISC) and HCT meetings in relation to the L3 scale-up. There was also a focus on strengthening intersectoral collaborations, particularly on cross-cutting areas in relation to UNICEF policy commitments as a Cluster Lead Agency (i.e., on GBV, gender, AAP, nexus and localization). The surge staff established the UNICEF intersectoral team for moving this forward collectively in all sectors.⁵² UNICEF's engagement, and coherence with the UN system is examined further below.

Joint assessments were carried out to identify the needs. For example, the World Health Organization (WHO) conducted a mapping and looked at the risks, and UNICEF and WHO collaborated to support the provision of clean water. UNICEF also supported in the data collection of the joint assessment (SYNAT) led by OCHA, using TPFs who were trained by OCHA along with the sector coordinators prior to deploying the SYNAT tool.⁵³

Unlike the Syria Country Office, the Outpost did not have a systematic tool in place for conducting needs assessments, and this was a gap in the early response.⁵⁴ They therefore used pre-earthquake PiN data to estimate targets. In the scale-up of the response it was extremely difficult for any UN agency to know the reality of the needs in Idlib and Aleppo NGCAs. Ultimately, REACH data⁵⁵ was the key

source used by OCHA to inform targets. The initial REACH RNA was multisectoral and aimed to identify the effects of the earthquake on displacement, key infrastructures for basic services, market access and key needs of affected populations. The first two assessments (in February and March 2023) covered 704 communities in NGCAs. Although the REACH data (which, the evaluation understands, was similar to UNICEF's own estimates) was of critical importance in aligning the wider response to an agreed set of targets, there is scope for the Outpost to have a more cogent set of needs assessments on hand in the event of any future sudden onset emergencies.

Utility of the EPP and other preparedness measures

Finding 3

In GCAs and NGCAs, outside of the EPP, which did not account for the contingency of an earthquake in Syria, both the Syria Country Office and MENARO Outpost had some emergency preparedness measures in place. In the Syria Country Office these included an understanding of how to apply the simplified emergency procedures, pre-positioned supplies in place, and a cadre of senior management experienced in emergencies. These factors helped to contribute to a rapid response to the immediate needs of affected populations. In NWS, the Outpost had already pre-positioned supplies inside NWS and were working with 19 well-capacitated and experienced Implementing Partners, who had reach into 343 communities. Despite initial delays in opening the border crossing into NWS, this positioned UNICEF well for a rapid response inside NWS, led by their partners on the ground.

UNICEF Syria Country Office already had systems in place for emergencies, and staff were trained on emergency protocols. This was because of the protracted humanitarian crisis in the country, which had been going on for more than a decade. Although UNICEF Syria Country Office had experience in L3 emergency situations, specific experience was lacking in natural disaster-related emergencies such as earthquakes. Nevertheless, senior management were quick to apply the emergency procedures. The

⁵² UNICEF MENARO Mission Report Syria Arab Republic, 08-14 July 2023.

⁵³ KII GCAs 05/24.

⁵⁴ KII NWS 04/24; KII MENARO 04/24.

⁵⁵ REACH is a humanitarian initiative providing granular data, information and in-depth analysis from contexts of crisis, disaster and displacement: <https://www.impact-initiatives.org/>.

simplified emergencies procedures – such as simplified project/programme document (PD) approvals, local procurement, use of contingency budgets, and rapid deployment of pre-positioned emergency supplies – helped UNICEF and partners respond to the immediate needs of earthquake-affected people.

Overall, decisions to mobilize quickly – in terms of both supplies and financial transfers to the partners – were clear for senior management at the Syria Country Office.⁵⁶ Having senior management with strong experience in emergencies was an important asset to the Country Office during the L3 response. The Country Office went through an emergency preparedness exercise before the earthquake, which involved engaging programme staff from different levels, including the participation of (among others) HR, sector chiefs and field-level staff. The evaluation found that this EPP exercise was very useful because it raised awareness of the potential scale of a humanitarian crisis (albeit not an earthquake) and the specific responsibilities of each unit. The importance of emergency planning and preparedness is discussed in further detail in the Overarching Report.

In NWS, the EPP⁵⁷ did not include contingency planning for an earthquake, but the evaluation found that the EPP was useful in laying out the basic steps for any large emergency response. UNICEF staff in the Outpost surveyed indicated that the EPP was very useful (36 per cent) or somewhat useful (50 per cent) in the activation and scale-up of the L3.⁵⁸ Some preparedness measures were already established by the Outpost prior to the earthquake. Pre-positioned supplies were in place, owing to UNICEF scenario planning for a decision in January 2023 on the UNSCR Al-Hawa border crossing, and other preparedness measures were a result of 12 years of emergency programming in a politically volatile region.

The evaluation found that an important element of preparedness was UNICEF's pre-existing relationship with its Implementing Partners. In February 2023, UNICEF was working with 19 well-capacitated and experienced Implementing Partners, who had reach into 343 communities in NWS. This positioned UNICEF well for an immediate response led by partners on the ground. The second measure was the pre-positioning of US\$6 million of supplies inside NWS as a contingency in case of the non-renewal of the UNSCR in January 2023. In the case of WASH, multiple warehouses were located across NWS with supplies to support potential displacement and natural calamities such as extreme weather events, although the earthquake was never perceived as a possibility.⁵⁹ As a result, "When the earthquake hit, UNICEF was able to dispatch key life-saving supplies such as hygiene kits, drinking water and high-energy biscuits to the affected population within 48 hours. This was essential as the border crossing into NWS was closed for three days."⁶⁰ Other aspects of preparedness measures included the establishment of a functional vaccine cold chain system, vital to protect the integrity of medical supplies inside NWS.

The appropriateness of early UN-wide supplies was questioned in the Syria Earthquake Peer-to-Peer Review⁶¹ and by recipients of UNICEF services interviewed in this evaluation,⁶² who said that their immediate need was for warm clothes and heating. This finding indicates that the intervention objective of "provision of cash and winter items where possible" was not fully met at the outset of the response. It is understood that winterization stocking had been phased out in NWS prior to 2023 because of lack of funding.⁶³

⁵⁶ KII GCAs 04/24; KII GCAs 04/24.

⁵⁷ EPP Preparedness Plan, Syria, 2022. Note that both GCAs and NGCAs are under one EPP.

⁵⁸ UNICEF staff survey conducted in this evaluation.

⁵⁹ RAM 2023.

⁶⁰ Syria SitRep, 16 February 2023.

⁶¹ UNICEF, Syria Earthquake Report. 14 September 2023. "While prepositioned stocks played a key part in enabling the immediate earthquake response, there were limits to their relevance and quantity for the scale of the impact."

⁶² FGDs NWS 05/24.

⁶³ This was a finding of the Syria L3 Evaluation of 2020: "Funding and delivery of a winterization programme (non-food items) was consistently late, making it less relevant as an intervention. This work was (rightly) phased out to focus limited resources on other critical needs."

Application of the No Regrets approach

Finding 4

In GCAs and NGCAs, the evaluation found that there was some hesitation in applying the No Regrets approach because of concerns of being held accountable as part of a future auditing process. No Regrets was applied with more confidence and consistency by senior management (and senior surge staff, in the case of the Outpost). The judicious use of this approach led to some important results in terms of responding to immediate needs in GCAs and pioneering new multisectoral approaches while pushing for access opportunities in NWS.

The Syria Country Office staff survey conducted in this evaluation revealed that it was perceived that the No Regrets policy was very much applied (50 per cent) or somewhat applied (50 per cent). The evaluation found that the No Regrets approach was applied more fully at senior management level but with more hesitation among other staff. Elaborating on this point, one senior informant explained: “The emergency money did not arrive, and they were very anxious about using regular money. I said just do it and we will get the money to cover it. It was the anxiety of using earmarked money for new emergencies.” A MENARO mission report also highlighted follow-up actions to encourage operations to be bolder and take informed risks, with the necessary consultation and risk mitigation measures where such actions could improve service delivery.⁶⁴ A few examples of No Regrets approaches were provided, mostly by senior-level management. These included, for instance, UNICEF Syria Country Office taking a No Regrets approach to initiate data collection to assess the needs on the ground in Aleppo prior to the deployment of the inter-agency Multisector Needs Assessment (MSNA). The process was, however, stopped once the inter-agency MSNA began to avoid duplication of efforts. Overall, the evaluation found that the hesitation to use the No Regrets approach in the Syria Country Office was associated with concerns of being held accountable in later audit processes.

There are clear commonalities between both regions in terms of perception and application of the No Regrets approach. The Outpost and WoS staff survey results show that 93 per cent of personnel felt that the No Regrets policy was very much applied or somewhat applied. The Evaluation Team found that there

was a greater appetite for risk and No Regrets on the part of senior surge staff in the Outpost. This appetite was important for pursuance of more sustained access into NWS (‘Protective Presence’) and initiating large scale multisector responses such as the WAQTI initiative (discussed in further detail below).

Alignment with global standards, principles and commitments

Finding 5

In GCAs and NGCAs, the CCCs were at the heart of UNICEF’s design, implementation and monitoring of the earthquake response. This was the case at sector and cross-sector levels, with integrated emergency response interventions being a key strategy in the response in NWS. At the outset of the response in NWS, UNICEF (in common with the wider UN) was challenged to implement a principled humanitarian response to provide life-saving assistance because of delays caused by political bargaining over the opening of the border crossings from Türkiye into Syria.

The evaluation observed two effective strategies employed by the Syria Country Office to operationalize the CCCs commitments. First, the Syria Country Office pursued a staged approach (before, during and after the L3) to ensuring that the commitments were understood, and that staff were able to apply the principles in practice thereafter. Second, the Syria Country Office sought to widen both the understanding and application of the CCCs to partners.

In 2021, the initial phase of the roll-out of the CCCs focused on raising awareness and building capacity within the Syria Country Office. All staff were mandated to complete the CCCs training on the Agora online platform, with regular follow-ups to ensure compliance. In addition, the emergency team conducted section-specific training sessions, addressing the aspects of the CCCs relevant to each section. This approach not only facilitated a good understanding of the commitments but also allowed for feedback and clarification from staff.

In 2022 the focus shifted to partners. The Syria Country Office strategically integrated the CCCs sessions into existing sector meetings for WASH, CP, Education and Nutrition. This included briefings and presentations tailored to each sector, ensuring

⁶⁴ UNICEF MENARO Mission Report Syria Arab Republic, 08-14 July 2023. 2023.

that partners were equipped with the necessary knowledge to implement the CCCs effectively. Syria Country Office also utilized the opportunity of organizing a UNICEF Information Management (IM) training attended by monitoring and evaluation, IM and reporting staff from 37 UNICEF's Implementing Partners to brief them on the CCCs. A brochure on the CCCs for the government partners was prepared, translated, printed, and distributed at the local and central levels via UNICEF sections and FOs. The Evaluation Team determined that follow-up on this brochure, integrated with key takeaways from the L3 experience, could be an important entry point for engaging with the government on sensitive issues such as PSEA.

The evaluation found that the Syria Country Office work on the CCCs is iterative. For example, there is follow-up on the completion of the CCCs training on Agora among Syria Country Office staff, facilitators, and TPMs and the Country Office; and in 2024 the Country Office conducted briefing sessions within two HACT trainings. It is understood that the Country Office is currently working with HQ and RO colleagues on developing a case study on the roll-out of the CCCs. This will be an important learning resource on how to be prepared for unexpected and sudden onset emergencies. The issue of preparedness in non-emergency prone countries is discussed in more detail in the Overarching Report.

In NWS, the evaluation found that UNICEF staff were strongly committed to using the CCCs to design, implement and reflect upon the L3 response. Indeed, the CCCs were identified as the primary guidelines for designing and rolling out the response. CCCs strategic results and benchmarks were applied mostly at sector and cross-sector levels, with gender-responsive approaches underpinning the intervention objectives. Of note was the promotion of multisector programming and geographic convergence in the WAQTI intervention (Section 4.3).

The L3 response in NWS was carried out in a highly politicized theatre. At the activation of the L3 all UN agencies, including UNICEF, were challenged to operationalize the commitment to establish and maintain humanitarian access. This was because of geopolitical bargaining over the opening of further border crossings from Türkiye into NWS, which initially delayed the response. In the days following the earthquakes, UN Secretary-General António Guterres and

UN humanitarian chief Martin Griffiths both appealed for additional cross-border access to people in need, with Griffiths acknowledging on 12 February, six days after the first earthquake struck, that the UN had failed the people of NWS.⁶⁵ UNICEF also struggled to find a consistent approach for 'engaging with all parties to conflict' in NGCAs. The evaluation found that after early attempts to engage with the DfA (until June 2023), UNICEF's appetite for engagement had attenuated, especially in Idlib (this is discussed further below).

Alignment of UNICEF's response strategies with the needs and preferences of affected populations

Accountability to Affected Populations

Finding 6

In GCAs and NGCAs, UNICEF Implementing Partners were integral in the application of AAP principles. In the Syria Country Office, partners were trained on AAP, and feedback and complaint systems were scaled up. However, there was limited traction inside government facilities to display awareness material and a lack of awareness and disinclination among affected communities to use feedback and complaints systems. In NWS, the evaluation found that Implementing Partners have put in place well-elaborated AAP systems, and recipients of UNICEF services reported high awareness of formal feedback and complaint mechanisms. There was limited evidence that these mechanisms placed people at the centre of determining their own needs, which was compounded by the use of an AAP indicator that only measured whether people were using feedback mechanisms.

The evaluation has assessed AAP using the output described in the reconstructed logic model: 'communities are at the centre of needs identification and feedback.' This implies two areas of enquiry. The first is to look at the provision (and usage) of formal feedback/complaint mechanisms. The second is the centrality or involvement of affected populations in identification of their own needs.

⁶⁵ Human Rights Watch 2023.

In GCAs, UNICEF's partners were the main point of contact for recipients of UNICEF services in the application of AAP.⁶⁶ Therefore, UNICEF ensured that partners were provided with training on AAP and PSEA and were informed of UNICEF's zero tolerance policy for all forms of SEA.⁶⁷ Field visits to partners were scaled up during the response, and TPMs and TPFs were used for monitoring purposes, which further facilitated feedback and complaint mechanisms (including for SEA), with particular attention to gender considerations across all programmes and interventions.⁶⁸ Post-distribution monitoring (PDM) was also carried out during the cash emergency response.⁶⁹ UNICEF Syria Country Office increased the operating hours of its service line to address the increased number of calls. Timeliness of responding to calls greatly improved, with 95 per cent of calls closed within the same day and 5 per cent within five working days.⁷⁰

The evaluation found that people were less likely to use AAP mechanisms because of concerns that this may affect their access to services.⁷¹ This was highlighted during KIIs and affected populations' feedback from field monitoring of the earthquake response. According to this data, 81 per cent of affected populations reported that they did not know how to make complaints or give feedback/suggestions about the assistance they received, and 95 per cent had never raised a complaint or suggestion before.⁷² This finding is underlined by an observation made by a key informant: "The problem is the population don't tell us about their needs, but after we respond, they tell us that what they need. We also need to raise people's awareness and encourage them to speak more freely about their needs, so we respond to their exact needs. They don't talk because they [are] afraid of losing the available services or service that we are going to provide them."

Within the shelters and government-owned buildings (such as schools and hospitals), UNICEF and other organizations responding to the earthquake were limited in their capacities to ensure that AAP mechanisms such as awareness posters were used, because these facilities are controlled by the government. Looking forward, it will be important for the Syria Country Office to gain more traction on a shared understanding and application of AAP principles with government officials. Gaining more buy-in from the government on the importance of AAP may well help to foster a more open environment for people to express their needs and provide feedback.

As agreed with UNICEF during the inception phase of this evaluation, the Evaluation Team did not consult with affected populations in GCAs to elicit their perspectives on whether they had been adequately consulted by UNICEF or UNICEF partners in the L3 response. The AAP indicator only addressed one part of UNICEF's commitments to AAP (feedback mechanisms). There was no indicator to capture if or how affected communities were consulted in the design of interventions. Perspectives from the Implementing Partners were that they used effective strategies such as WhatsApp groups to understand and respond



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⁶⁶ KII GCAs 04/24.

⁶⁷ UNICEF, Syria Humanitarian Situation Report No. 9 (Earthquake): 12 April - 2 May 2023. 5 May 2023.

⁶⁸ UNICEF, Syria Humanitarian Situation Report No. 4 (Earthquake): 28 Feb - 6 Mar 2023. 13 March 2023.

⁶⁹ UNICEF, Humanitarian Situation Report: 1 January to 30 June 2023. 2023.

⁷⁰ UNICEF, Humanitarian Situation Report: 1 January to 30 June 2023. 2023.

⁷¹ KII GCAs 04/24.

⁷² UNICEF, Syria Country Office Earthquake Response Field Monitoring Dashboard, Field Monitoring of the Earthquake Response Beneficiaries Feedback. February – May 2023.

quickly to community needs.⁷³ Internal UNICEF documentation also points to the appropriateness of using AAP accountability clauses in PDs to ensure that partners undertake measures to reflect accountability to affected populations by: (1) provision of accessible information to affected populations on organizational procedures, structures and processes that affect them; (2) enabling affected populations to play an active role in decision-making processes that affect them; and (3) designing, monitoring and evaluating the goals and objectives of their interventions with the involvement of affected communities.⁷⁴ Internally, the UNICEF staff survey indicated that 16 per cent of the staff surveyed perceived that affected communities were highly consulted and 74 per cent believed that affected communities were somewhat consulted.

In NWS, the lack of physical access for UNICEF staff to recipients of UNICEF services prior to the earthquake meant that UNICEF had been reliant on Implementing Partners and TPMs to action and monitor AAP systems on the ground. In the activation of the response, Implementing Partners continued to lead on ensuring that AAP principles were implemented. The Evaluation Team found that the Implementing Partners sampled in this evaluation have well-elaborated AAP systems in place for both community dialogues and formal feedback mechanisms. The FGDs also revealed very high awareness of the feedback mechanisms among recipients of UNICEF services consulted in this evaluation.

In terms of community consultations on needs, the FGDs indicated a more mixed picture. Most recipients of UNICEF services said that they did not remember any needs assessments taking place but remembered plenty of post-delivery assessments. This is not surprising given that the early response was mostly a scale-up of existing services rather than an identification of new services.

UNICEF was able to use the earthquake as an opportunity to improve and redouble commitments to AAP in NWS. Access into NWS, coupled with integration of AAP into field monitoring visits and reporting, was game-changing for UNICEF staff to engage with communities. The deployment of an AAP Advisor to the Outpost was maximized in terms of putting more

robust AAP systems in place and providing capacity building to Implementing Partners. It will be important that the Outpost sustains and maintains ownership of these systems in the months to come, to ensure both preparedness and full compliance to the CCCs in programming.

Quality and frequency of needs assessments

Finding 7

In GCAs, UNICEF relied primarily on Implementing Partners to collect data for the response. This process was effective because the partners regularly provided this type of data prior to the earthquake. In GCAs the quality and frequency of needs assessments were enhanced because UNICEF was acting in concert with a wider humanitarian aid architecture in the sectors and leveraging pre-existing relationships with the government. UNICEF was also able to deploy TPMs as an additional resource in assessing needs.

The Syria Country Office faced a challenge from the outset of the response in determining what was earthquake or conflict damage. In the context of GCAs this is a complex issue, owing to varying donor red lines on funding (discussed in more detail in the Overarching Report). The UNICEF Syria Country Office navigated this challenge by conducting several internal assessments and monitoring exercises to assess the needs on the ground. These included, inter alia, the internal CWM exercise, the Standard Monitoring Assessment for Relief and Transitions (SMART) survey identifying national prevalence of global acute malnutrition, and the CP rapid assessment.⁷⁵ UNICEF also played a key role in the development of the SERNA, with the sector coordinators as pen holders for the different sectors that they led. UNICEF's inter-cluster coordinator provided technical support to the UNICEF Syria Country Office-led/co-led sector coordinators and respective programme teams in the SERNA exercise.⁷⁶

UNICEF relied primarily on partners to implement rapid assessments. Partners were trained prior to implementation on issues such as data quality checks and the use of Kobo.⁷⁷ Initially, needs assessments

⁷³ KII GCAS 04/24.

⁷⁴ HPD, Programme Document, Education in emergency for children affected by the earthquake in Aleppo governorate. 2023.

⁷⁵ UNICEF 2023 End of Year Summary Narrative Report. 2023.

⁷⁶ UNICEF MENARO Mission Report Syria Arab Republic, 08-14 July 2023. 2023.

⁷⁷ Kobo is a suite of tools for field data collection for use in challenging environments.

were rapid and focused on identifying basic needs and numbers of affected populations. However, after the situation stabilized, they became more comprehensive. Data collected by UNICEF partners was disaggregated by gender, age and, to a lesser extent, disability. This was facilitated because UNICEF partners had regularly provided this type of data prior to the earthquake. The TPMs and TPFs also participated in the needs assessments. National/local authorities were an additional source of information on the needs of affected populations.



“I think the question is more the ongoing discussion that we had the whole time, which is: in a country that has already been so destroyed, how do you know if it was the earthquake, or if it was because it was already in bad shape? And [...] how do you separate them? It’s so political, what you want to call earthquake-destroyed or not. Especially in areas such as agriculture, like the irrigation canals that would not have been probably as badly damaged, and again, some of the WASH that because it was already in bad shape, it suffered more.” – *Evaluation key informant, UN Syria (GCAs)*

Finding 8

In NGCAs, Implementing Partners led the initial needs assessments. However, the lack of a shared needs assessment tool, both within UNICEF and among UN partners, led to an impractical number of different assessments rather than one shared RNA document that aligned the early L3 response. This fragmented picture of needs, most specifically in the early phase of the response, invited the risks of over-coverage and under-coverage in the NWS earthquake response, but these risks were mostly mitigated by UNICEF.

Internal and external earthquake response evaluations all point to the challenges in conducting quality and consistent needs assessments in NWS. One evaluation documented “an impractical number of RNA conducted by NGOs [non-governmental organizations] alone by March 2023 and a saturation in affected communities with the number of different assessments”.⁷⁸ One evaluation informant recalled that 88 assessments were conducted by the UN and its partners, but no comprehensive intersectoral RNA was completed until 2024.⁷⁹

A UNICEF beneficiary interviewed during this evaluation observed: “I do not know how the need was assessed, and assistance arrived late, perhaps because the tools for carrying out the activities were late.” Indeed, many UNICEF and UN staff pointed to a lack of common tools to undertake needs assessments, coupled with a siloed approach to understanding needs. The lack of a comprehensive RNA to guide the response led to a fragmented flow of data that UNICEF was initially challenged to manage in the absence of a dedicated Information Management Officer (IMO) in the early stages of the response.

As described earlier, the needs data improved with the REACH assessment after the launch of the Flash Appeal. The Peer-to-Peer Operational Review for the broader earthquake response determined that “the availability of sex- and age-disaggregated data or data on people living disabilities remained a problem. This shortage of real-time data and cross-sectoral 4W information,⁸⁰ especially the common operational datasets of new collective shelters, also led to widespread duplication and an overfocus on specific areas of NWS.”⁸¹ According to Implementing Partners

⁷⁸ IMMAP and USAID, [Post-Earthquake Perspective, Challenges and Strategies for Humanitarian Aid in Northwest Syria. System Failure: How the Earthquakes Exposed the Limits of the International System in Northwest Syria](#), Ad Hoc Series Part 1. 15 June 2023, p.19.

⁷⁹ KII NWS 04/24.

⁸⁰ 4W reporting (or “Who”, “What”, “Where”, “When”) is an important responsibility for operational actors and is an essential analysis in order to coordinate an effective humanitarian response.

⁸¹ UNICEF, Syria Earthquake Report. 14 September 2023.

consulted in this evaluation, UNICEF applied flexibility to mitigate this risk by providing the latitude for Implementing Partners to quickly switch assistance to different camps if they found needs already being addressed in their planned intervention sites.

Extent to which the response was multisectoral

Finding 9

In GCAs, UNICEF developed some multisector initiatives in the L3 response which contributed to providing assistance effectively and at scale. Reflecting on good practices to further expand synergies across sectors, especially with CT, is likely to contribute to more effective responses in the future.

Efforts were made to implement multisectoral programming during the earthquake response, and the UNICEF staff survey suggests that integrated programming had either been very much applied (44 per cent) or somewhat applied (38 per cent). The evaluation found some good examples of best practice in integrated programming. Through ADAP interventions, UNICEF collaborated with 975 young volunteers (including 622 females)⁸² to strengthen the youth-led emergency response in Tartous and Latakia governorates. The volunteers were involved in various emergency response activities, such as awareness raising sessions and campaigns that focused on hygiene promotion (HP), CC, health and nutrition (H&N), infant and young child feeding (IYCF) and early child development (ECD)-related topics.⁸³ Volunteer networks were set up, and despite being affected by the earthquake they were able to reach out to more than 18,000 people. The volunteer networks ensured that strong cross-sectoral coordination took place, particularly with the SBC, CP and education sections, through which 650 volunteers reached 8,000 children with RCCE messages, learning sessions and recreational activities.⁸⁴

UNICEF Syria Country Office can capitalize on its good practices to further expand on its multisectoral interventions during emergencies.⁸⁵ For example, the mobile health and nutrition teams (MHNTs) were important to supporting earthquake-affected communities with primary health care consultations, breastfeeding counselling, nutrition screening and referrals for children and PLW. Reflecting on opportunities such as these to further maximize synergies between programmes beyond H&N may be valuable. Other interventions, such as cash assistance, may also be complemented with livelihood assistance and behaviour change interventions.

Finding 10

In NGCAs, prior to the earthquake, cross-border programming was characterized largely by a 'stove-piped' approach. With increased funding provided for the L3 response, the MENARO Outpost staff seized the opportunity to initiate a multisector 'flagship' intervention designed to provide integrated inputs to meet a broad range of earthquake response objectives.

Despite an effective WASH and SBC alignment in the cholera response in 2022, prior to the earthquake there were limited examples of integrated programming in NWS beyond linkages between WASH and education in schools. Indeed, the previous Syria L3 evaluation noted the stove-piped nature of interventions in NWS.⁸⁶ Implementing Partners consulted in this evaluation further highlighted the challenges for UNICEF in creating intersectoral PDs because of prescriptive donor earmarking practices and an institutional legacy of siloed sections. However, the MENARO Outpost, with the support of international surge capacity, was able to use the earthquake (and elevated funding) as an opportunity to instigate WAQTI, an integrated response initiative. Through this intervention, much-needed synergies across the sectors were realized and opportunities were created for enacting positive impact on the gender continuum.⁸⁷

⁸² Syria Humanitarian Situation Report, January – June 2023.

⁸³ UNICEF Humanitarian Programme Document, Integrated response to the earthquake in Latakia Governorate and IDPs Families in Tartous Governorate (Hand-in-Hand). May 2023.

⁸⁴ UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

⁸⁵ UNICEF, [Coping with a Disaster. How Behaviour Change and Community Engagement Supported Survivors of the February 2023 Earthquake in Syria](#). November 2023.

⁸⁶ Syria L3 Evaluation, 2020.

⁸⁷ "Work at multi-sectoral and intersectoral levels. Action at two or more levels or across sectors often adds up to more than the sum of its parts." Rachel Marcus, Fiona Samuels, Shoubo Jalal, and Helen Belachew, [Background Paper Series; UNICEF Gender Policy and Action Plan 2022-2025 - Gender-Transformative Programming](#). 2021, p.5.

Figure 8. Reach figures of the WAQTI response⁸⁸**Supplies provided**

31	Adolescent kits <i>for 1,550 adolescents</i>
141	ECD kits for 7,050 children
50	High-performance tents – 45m2
192	High-performance tents – 72m2
206	Recreational kits <i>for 18,540 children</i>
6,230	School bags
408	School in a box kits <i>for 16,320 children</i>
173	School in a carton <i>for 6,920 children</i>
208	Latrine units
252	Water tanks

Performance indicators

94%	Percentage of children who report improved well-being as a result of their participation in the project interventions
34,782	Children and adolescents benefiting from MHPSS activities
3,896	Girls and boys benefiting from case management for child protection
98,721	Children, adolescents and caregivers reached with key messages and RCCE
94%	Percentage of girls and boys who improved foundational learning skills
30,479	Children provided with non-formal education through mobile learning/mobile teachers
964	Teachers provided with training on psychosocial support and education in emergencies
105	School in a carton <i>for 6,920 children</i>
208	WAQTI Centres provided with integrated WASH interventions
252	Water tanks

WAQTI was intended as a high-intensity, coordinated, timebound response in the most severely affected communities in NWS. In collaboration with World Vision and other local Implementing Partners, 105 WAQTI centres were created in 56 communities in 10 subdistricts in a geographically integrated approach.⁸⁹ The intervention delivered core CP services, including MHPSS, case management, and family tracing and reunification. WAQTI also provided educational support through formal classes and foundational skills for children, and provided training for teachers. Student councils were established to enhance dialogue with school authorities. The WAQTI centres also received sanitary provisions and WASH messaging.⁹⁰ WAQTI worked across six of the activity areas highlighted in the logic model (Figure 1),⁹¹ contributing to six outputs. The performance indicators and results displayed on the left side of Figure 8 show mostly reach numbers of outputs, with only the two percentage indicators measuring change towards outcomes. This

underscores the challenge with assessing outcomes in an emergency response, whereby measurements are reported mostly at output level (reach numbers) rather than at outcome level.

Although some evaluation sources expressed concerns on the timeliness of the WAQTI centres (they were established in May 2023), the recipients of UNICEF services consulted in this evaluation were appreciative of the links made between segregated sanitation in schools (a gender-sensitive rather than gender-responsive intervention) and the awareness messaging on food hygiene and sanitation in the centres. The WAQTI intervention cost approximately US\$7 million and was not considered by UNICEF staff to be a model of integrated programming that would exist into the more sustained period of early recovery. Questions over value for money could therefore be raised through a further detailed evaluation of this intervention.

⁸⁸ Data provided in WAQTI Infographic document shared by MENARO Outpost.

⁸⁹ WAQTI Infographic.

⁹⁰ WAQTI Infographic.

⁹¹ Health, WASH, Education, Protection, AAP and SBC.

B

Effectiveness

Extent to which approaches to coverage, advocacy and internal systems contributed to an effective response⁹²

Section B provides an analysis of the effectiveness of the response in terms of implementation progress to funding and reach targets and commitments to coverage with equity. The findings on implementation towards targets and funding are presented for the WoS.⁹³ This section also addresses the extent to which advocacy and communications, monitoring, and IM systems have supported the effectiveness of the response. Other supporting functions, such as HR (surge), resource mobilization, supply and logistics and the application of the emergency procedures, are addressed in the Overarching Report.



SUMMARY OF FINDINGS

For the WoS, there was an uneven distribution in achieving funding targets between the sectors. Cash transfer was a critical intervention in the response, but it was challenged by UN-agreed financial envelopes, a lack of shared UN positioning on data protection and associated difficulties in horizontal expansion. The evaluation found that indicators for AAP, SBC and youth engagement did not fully capture the extent of UNICEF's engagements in those areas. UNICEF data for sector and cross-sectoral progress against targets was not always aligned between different data sets.

In GCAs and NGCAs, coverage with equity was hard to determine given the fluidity of movement and scale of needs in both regions. The Syria Country Office demonstrated a do no harm approach to addressing needs inside and outside of the shelters and the inclusion of youth volunteers and mobile teams was an effective strategy to cover hard to reach and rural locations.

In GCAs, monitoring was maximized by the (gendered) use of TPMs and TPFs across the six Field Offices. For some sectors, such as CP, limited access to data and evidence for programming and advocacy has been a consistent operational reality. The evaluation found that monitoring systems could be enhanced with deeper consultation with the field offices. In NGCAs the Outpost has maximized the opportunities to monitor on the ground by use of the FMM ETool but both regions lacked sufficient IM officers at the outset of the response to ensure highly effective information management systems.

⁹² This corresponds to the effectiveness criterion on the evaluation matrix.

⁹³ HAC planning and reporting is always on WoS level, not only for the earthquake response.

Coverage and quality

Funding requirements and implementation rates across programme sections

Finding 11

For the WoS, there was an uneven distribution in achieving funding targets between the sectors and some sectors and cross-sectors were slow to make progress against the appeal targets by May 2023 but made stronger progress by the end of 2023. Slower progress in some sectors can be attributed to substantive rehabilitation interventions. CT was a critical intervention in the response, but it was challenged by UN-agreed financial envelopes, a lack of shared UN positioning on data protection and associated difficulties in horizontal expansion. The evaluation found that indicators for AAP, SBC and youth engagement did not adequately capture the extent of UNICEF's engagements in those areas. UNICEF data for sector and cross-sectoral progress against targets was not always aligned between the reporting in SitReps, RAM and dashboards and analysis of the results was complicated by this misalignment.

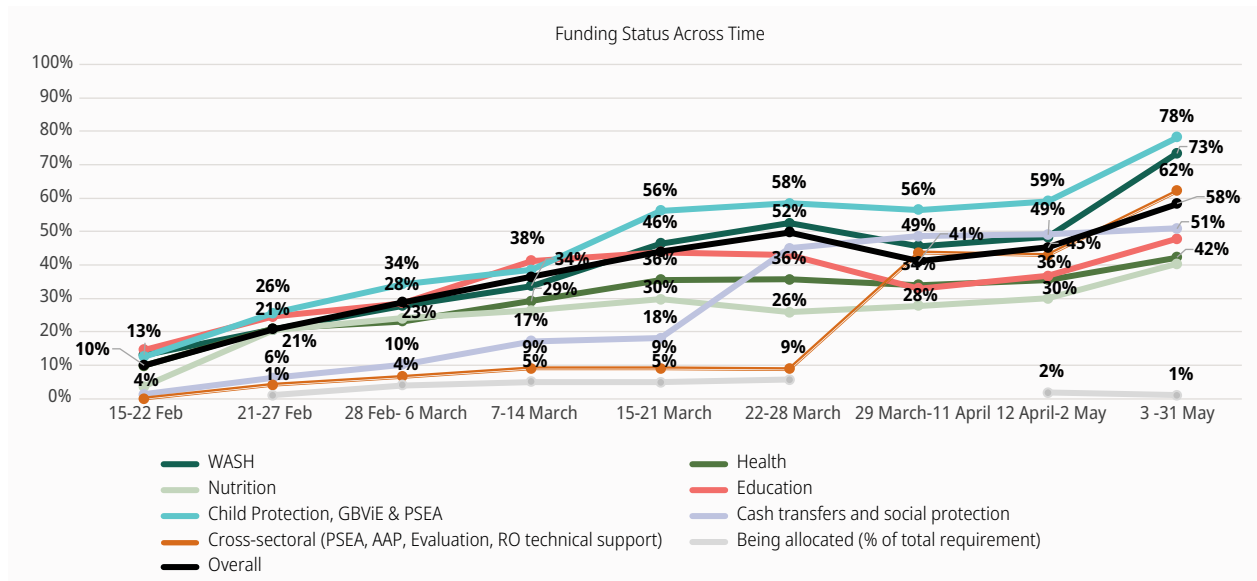
On 16 February 2023, UNICEF launched an Immediate Response Plan (which constituted part of the Inter-Agency Flash Appeal). The funding target for the earthquake response for the WoS was set at US\$172.7 million, with targets per sector as shown in Table 5. The HAC (which was underfunded prior to the emergency) was also revised as a result of the emergency, with a funding appeal for US\$328.5 million.

Table 5. Funding requirements by sector (data presented in SitRep No. 1, 16 February)

Sector	Requirement (US\$)	% per sector
WASH	47,800,008	28%
Health	29,265,371	17%
Nutrition	18,361,542	11%
Education	31,300,000	18%
CP, Gender-Based Violence in Emergencies (GBViE) & PSEA	19,950,000	12%
Cash transfers and SP	23,623,079	14%
Cross-sectoral (PSEA, AAP, Evaluation, RO technical support)	2,400,000	1%
Total	172,700,000	

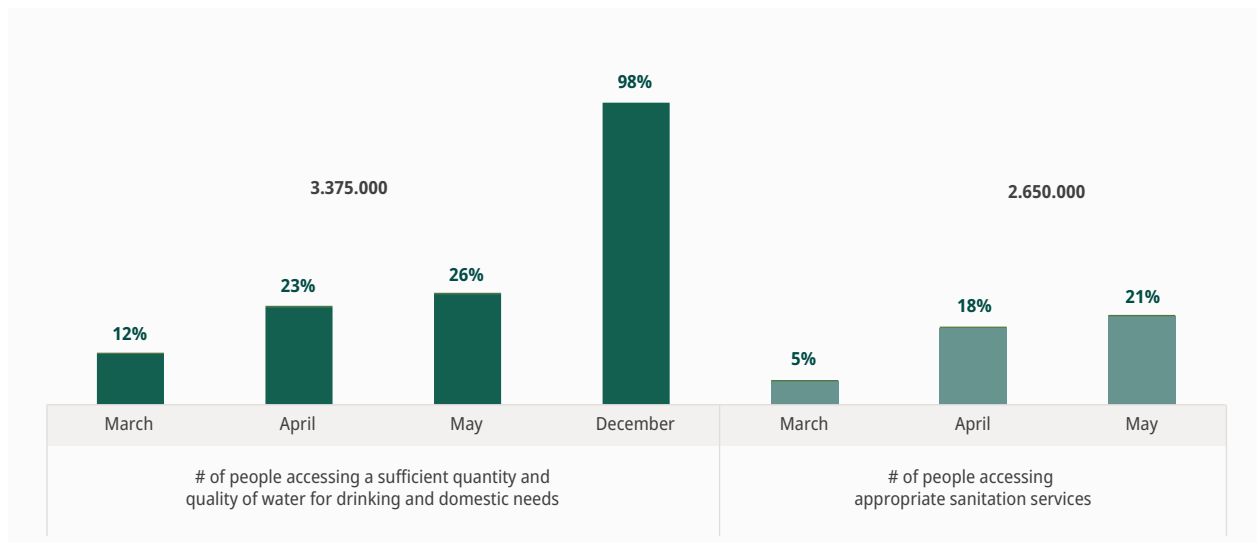
In the concluding SitRep of 31 May 2023, the UNICEF earthquake appeal was 58 per cent funded, but there was an uneven distribution in achieving funding targets between the sectors. Figure 9 indicates that health, nutrition and education were the most underfunded sectors and that CP received the most funds. In the case of cash transfers (CTs), the evaluation found that the budget appealed for in this sector was not the real budget but only 45 per cent, owing to a ceiling imposed for the overall UN appeal.⁹⁴ Other challenges in attaining funding targets related to donor earmarking, which is explored further in the Overarching Report.

⁹⁴ UNICEF Lessons learned Earthquake Response 2023 cash response - 15 May 2023.

Figure 9. Funding status across time, percentage of target met (data from Syria Humanitarian SitReps 1–10)

The evaluation found that UNICEF data for sector and cross-sectoral progress against targets was not always aligned between the reporting in SitReps, RAM and dashboards. In consultation with UNICEF, the Evaluation Team agreed to use WoS dashboard reporting as the primary data source to evaluate

the implementation rates during the L3 response. This data was analysed within the context of shifting targets and priorities (in alignment with updated needs assessments) as the L3 response evolved from the activation to a more sustained phase before deactivation.

Figure 10. Progress achieved against targets – WASH (data from SCO dashboard)

Progress in the WASH sector shows that approximately one-quarter of the target was achieved by the end of May, but more significant progress was made by December 2023. The earthquake was devastating to WASH infrastructure (already weakened through years of conflict related damage), and UNICEF took advantage of the incoming funds to ‘build back better’ by holistically addressing the damages resulting from

the protracted crisis.⁹⁵ Overall, the evaluation found that interventions in this sector did involve substantive rehabilitation work and commitment to sustainable solutions, such as procuring and delivering sodium hypochlorite to the different water facilities to ensure that pumped water met quality standards.⁹⁶ These interventions can take time to accomplish, especially in the complex setting of Syria.

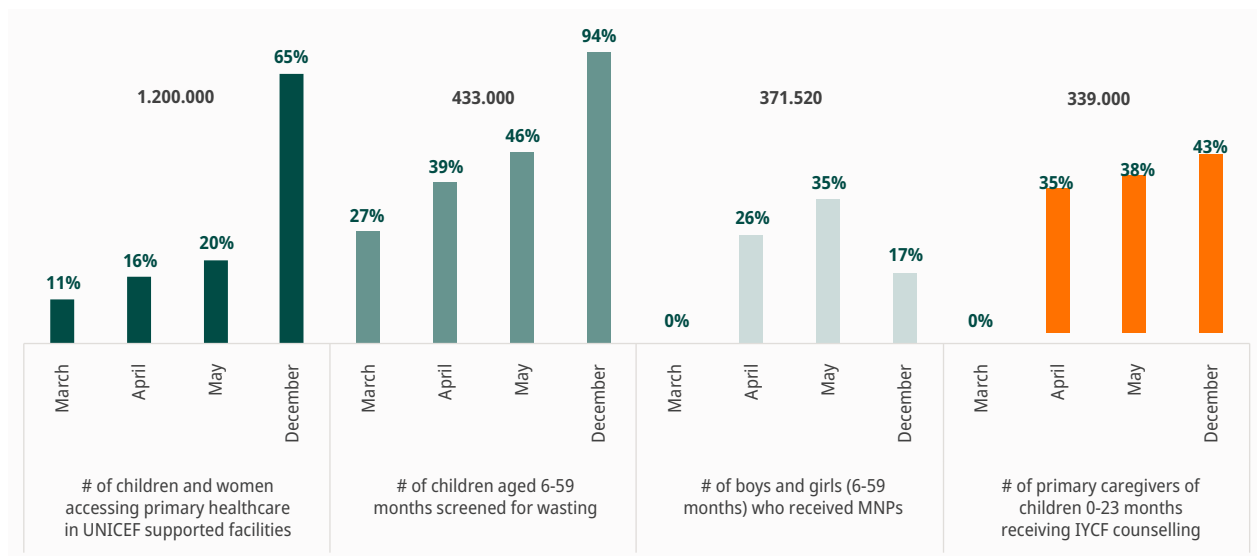
⁹⁵ RAM 2023.

⁹⁶ RAM 2023.

H&N implementation rates were below 50 per cent of progress against targets by the end of May 2023. After deactivation of the L3 and in the early recovery phase of the response, progress towards health targets improved. At the outset of the response, some key informants in this evaluation suggested that initial targets were set on the slightly higher

side, but underreporting (discussed in Section 5.2.2) also impacted the early reporting on implementation rates. Progress was also likely influenced by low rates of funding for these sectors. As shown in Figure 11, H&N had reached only 42 per cent of the funding target by the end of May 2023.

Figure 11. Progress achieved against targets – H&N (data from SCO dashboard)



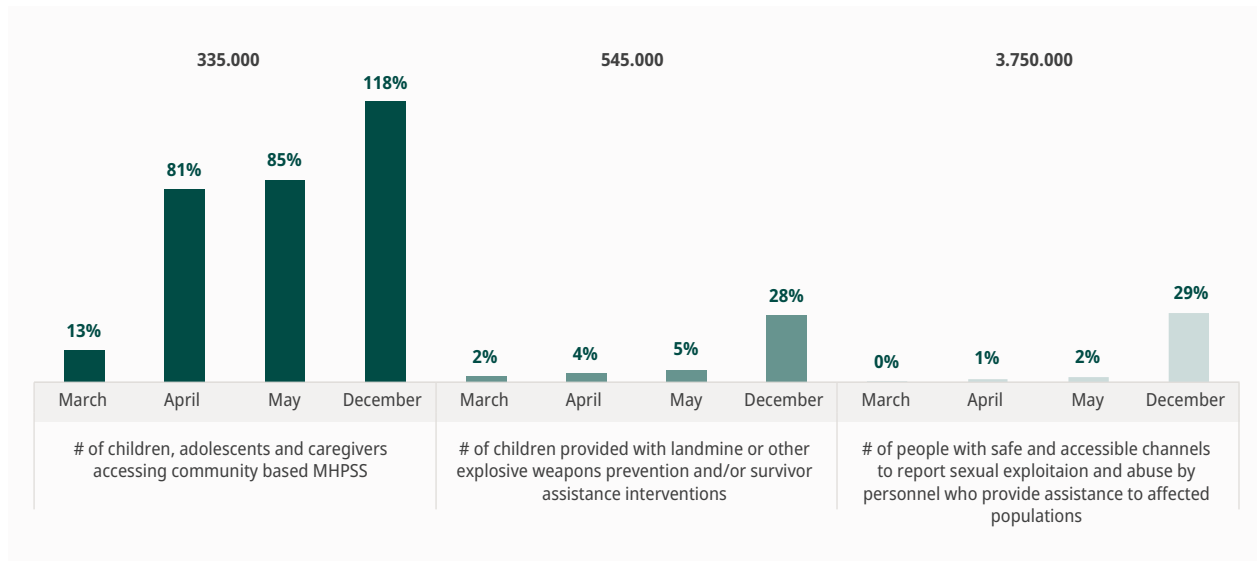
CP advanced rapidly to the targets in the L3 activation phase, and this is in line with UNICEF's prioritization of this intervention and comparatively high funding levels (78 per cent of the target met by the end of May 2023). However, the explosive weapon intervention, Explosive Ordinance Risk Education (EORE), had progressed to only 5 per cent of the target by May 2023. It is understood that this programming was critically underfunded, and UNICEF did not prioritize this intervention at the outset of the L3, owing to conditions on the ground,⁹⁷ resulting in a low result compared to the target. In the case of EORE, data provided from the Outpost contrasts with the data provided in the dashboards, with a significantly higher coverage reported in the Outpost accounting for reach in EORE.⁹⁸

The (limited) PSEA results were surprising given the high level of awareness reported by UNICEF service users in NWS. This result is partially explained by the fact that reporting only included those newly and directly reached to share information on safe, accessible reporting channels, and did not include indirect outreach or a calculation of the population who already had access to these channels. The evaluation also understands that data reporting for PSEA was behind schedule and that by the end of 2023, 100 per cent of targeted affected communities had access to PSEA reporting channels.⁹⁹ This issue again underlines the challenge found in this evaluation of contrasting reach figures as presented in the WoS dashboards, RAM 2023 reporting and in the SitReps.

⁹⁷ Information provided by Outpost office on comments on the draft Syria Country Report.

⁹⁸ End of year reporting for the Outpost states that at the end of 2023, 213,000 boys, girls and adults had been reached (out of the 250,000 target).

⁹⁹ Information provided by Outpost office on comments on the draft Syria Country Report.

Figure 12. Progress achieved against targets – CP, GBViE & PSEA (data from SCO dashboard)

Access to education and civic engagement with adolescents and youth¹⁰⁰ significantly overachieved the target in December 2023. However, this indicator does not capture the full extent of the Syria Country Office's engagement and mobilization of youth during the L3 response (documented in later sections of this report). Key informants, especially those at FO level, point to the fact that Syria Country Office indicators and reporting formats did not enable a full capture of this data.

SP and CTs received a large funding boost between 15 March and 21 March 2023, but this did not immediately impact the progress towards targets. The evaluation found this was the case for two reasons. First, during this period, UNICEF placed a moratorium on the CT programme because it could not ethically fulfil the government's request to provide data on the service users. Another UN agency did acquiesce to this request, weakening the UN-wide standpoint on this issue vis-à-vis the Government of Syria.

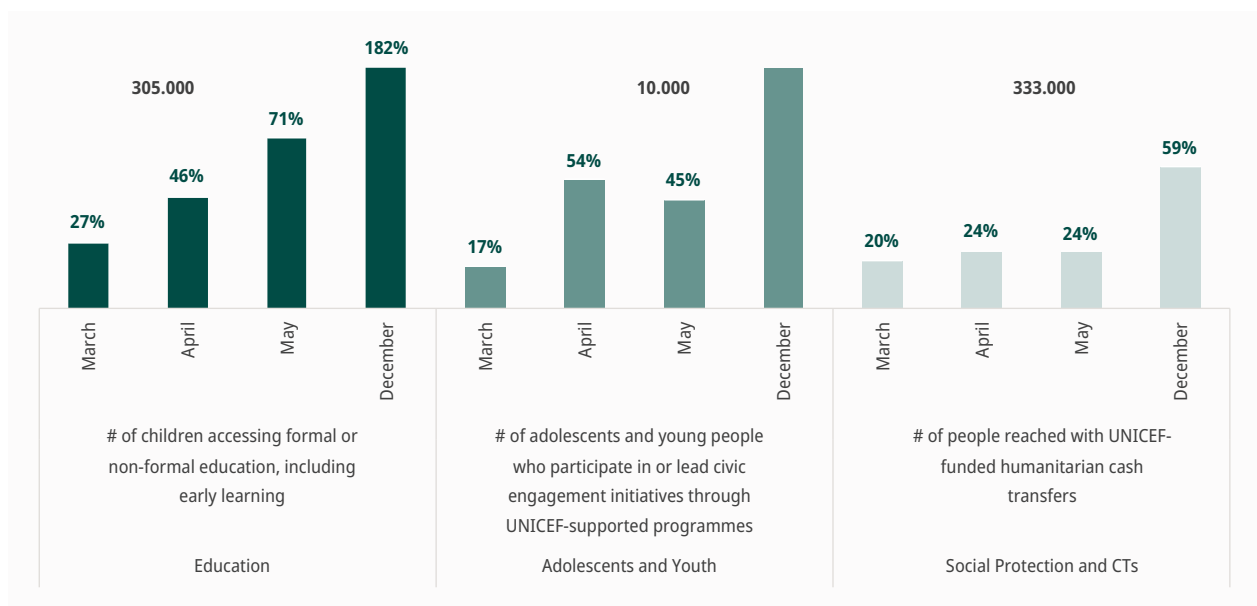
The second reason for the slow advancement to targets is elaborated in UNICEF's own post-monitoring and analysis of the CT programme during the L3 response. This analysis points to the fact that vertical expansion was relatively effective, but that horizontal expansion was not. Reaching beneficiaries through horizontal expansion was a lengthy process.

It required definition of targeting criteria, training of partners, door-to-door identification and registration of affected families in communities, and verification of eligibility. When the response stopped in mid-April 2023, UNICEF had registered 70 per cent of its planned target for the horizontal expansion (140,000 people). By mid-April 2023, 70 per cent of the existing caseload had received cash (vertical expansion) but only 5 per cent of new beneficiaries had received benefits.

Two months after the activation of the L3, SBC interventions had already exceeded the target by 116 per cent. This can be explained by two factors. First, this evaluation found that SBC was particularly effective in the L3 response by grafting to multisector interventions to reach out at scale. However, the SBC indicator ("# of people participating in engagement actions for SBC") was quite vague and does not encompass any specific theme or type of engagement nor does it hint at any outcome of the SBC engagement.

¹⁰⁰ The slight decline in 3–31 May was due to section streamlining the data cleaning process (as reported in the SitRep of May 2023).

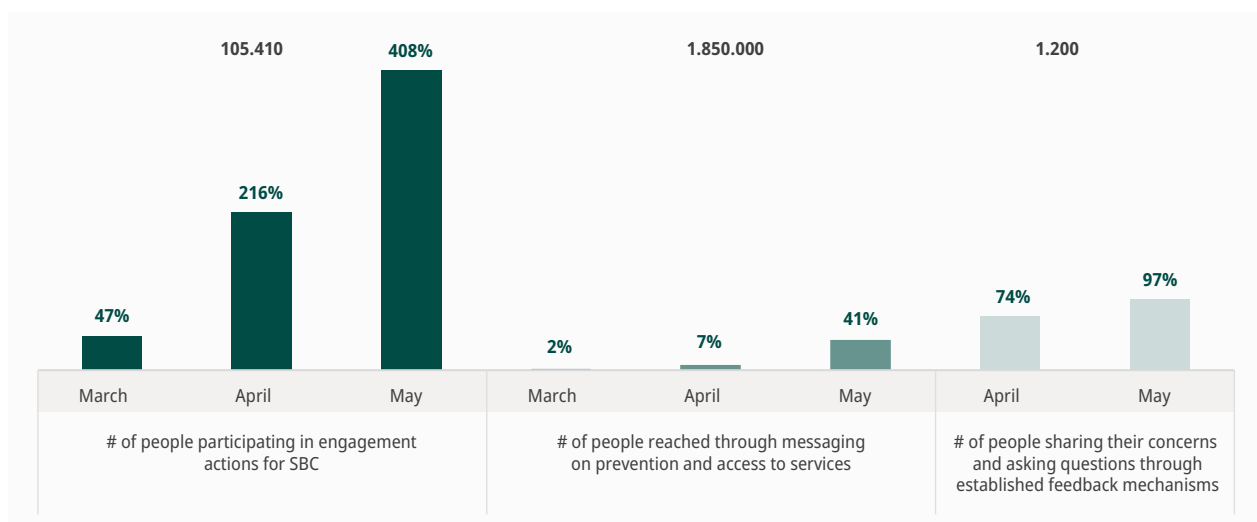
Figure 13. Progress achieved against targets – Education, Adolescents & Youth, Social Protection and CTs (data from SCO dashboard)



The Evaluation Team understands that the AAP indicator and target was only for the Syria Country Office and not for NWS. In GCAs, AAP progress to targets was strong, leading to a 97 per cent achievement rate by May 2023. However, this reporting contrasts with UNICEF's January–June 2023 SitRep, which stated: "UNICEF surveyed 2,102 beneficiaries in UNICEF-supported facilities across all the governorates. The results showed that only 26 per cent of respondents

knew how to submit a complaint, provide feedback, or make suggestions about assistance, proving the need to increase awareness of available safe and confidential complaint mechanisms."¹⁰¹ The AAP indicator only addresses one part of UNICEF's commitments to AAP (feedback mechanisms). There is no indicator to capture if or how affected communities were consulted in the design of interventions. This issue is explored in further detail below.

Figure 14. Progress achieved against targets – Cross-sectoral: HCT, SBC, RCCE & AAP (data from SCO dashboard)



¹⁰¹ Whole-of-Syria-Humanitarian-Situation-Report-Jan-Dec-2023, 13 – 13.

Coverage with equity

Finding 12

In GCAs and NGCAs, coverage with equity was hard to determine given the fluidity of movement and scale of needs in both regions. The Syria Country Office demonstrated a do no harm approach to addressing needs inside and outside of the shelters and the inclusion of youth volunteers and mobile teams was an effective strategy to cover hard to reach and rural locations. In NWS, coverage was in line with the intervention objectives, which were to provide assistance in highly populated areas with large numbers of displacement.

Data provided by the Syria Country Office indicates that the L3 response in GCAs had significant coverage in stress (49 per cent) and severe (51 per cent) areas, with less reach in extreme (28 per cent) and catastrophic (29 per cent) areas. Internal and external primary and secondary sources consulted in this evaluation point to both a UNICEF and UN-wide overfocus on providing emergency assistance in the shelters. It was also challenging for all responding organizations to reach people who had left their homes to take refuge with relatives elsewhere. The evaluation commends the Syria Country Office for instituting both an equitable and a Do No Harm approach in the overall response by targeting interventions in both shelters and in wider communities. For example, in WASH, UNICEF provided services in shelters but also conducted repairs of water networks that would benefit all the people and not just those in the shelters. For CT, UNICEF purposively targeted those in need in host communities rather than those receiving assistance in the shelters.

Although the Syria Country Office lacks the requisite datasets to be able to engage fully on UNICEF's Equity Pilot being rolled out globally, the evaluation found evidence to suggest that it did employ strategies to maximize opportunities for attaining equity. This was manifested in the TPM field monitoring for supplies and services, where beneficiary questionnaires included questions relating to identifying people excluded from the assistance. A key strategy to reach equitable coverage, especially in hard-to-reach areas, was the use of mobile teams and volunteers. In rural Lattakia, mobile teams organized community dialogues and edutainment activities, which were designed to teach children about hygiene and health in an engaging manner. The volunteers emphasized the importance of keeping shelter facilities clean, thus creating a safer environment for

children. Mobile teams worked hand in hand with community volunteers so that the response was community-driven. This involvement fostered a sense of ownership and responsibility among the affected populations, enhancing the effectiveness of the intervention and coverage.

Data provided by the Outpost indicates that the L3 response in NGCAs had significant coverage across the whole of the region but less reach in the catastrophic needs areas on the border with GCAs (Atareb and Daret Azza). During the L3 activation phase in NWS, constraints were experienced in needs assessments and target setting, owing to difficulties in discerning between newly affected and pre-existing camps and IDPs because of the fluidity of displacement and the erection of very ad hoc temporary settlements. This situation was mitigated by the OCHA-led decision to use existing PiN estimates. The evaluation found that the coverage was in line with the intervention objectives, which were to provide assistance in highly populated areas with large numbers of displacement. Coverage with equity is very challenging in all developmental and humanitarian contexts, but especially in a sudden onset emergency of this magnitude. In the absence of a clear picture of needs and a robust equity analysis system to focus the targeting, there will be trade-offs between the importance of expediting the emergency response for the highest number in need while ensuring vulnerable groups such as PWDs receive assistance.



Advocacy and communications

Finding 13

In GCAs, the UNICEF Syria Country Office (with support of the wider organization) was quick to document the emergency on the ground and use local and international media to disseminate messages on the needs of children. The Syria Country Office also piggybacked effectively on MENARO communication LTAs when needed.

UNICEF Syria Country Office communications and advocacy teams were quick to advocate on the situation of children during the earthquake response. A global statement was published less than 24 hours after the earthquake, highlighting the effects on children. The Syria Country Office conducted (with Regional Office support) 100 interviews with regional and media outlets. The Country Office communications and advocacy team maximized engagement with the international media to raise awareness on the pre-existing needs of children in Syria while highlighting needs as a result of the earthquake. Examples to highlight this include content for web and social media, which was disseminated during World Immunization Week. The content showcased UNICEF's efforts to distribute vaccines and ensure that all children, including those affected by the earthquake and in the hardest-to-reach areas, received vaccines.¹⁰²

UNICEF Syria Country Office was active on social media platforms disseminating information on the efforts of frontline workers while also publicly acknowledging the support of donors in the response.¹⁰³ Social media was also harnessed to disseminate SBC messaging.¹⁰⁴ This strategy was perceived as very effective by senior sources consulted in this evaluation. It is therefore surprising that the results for the number of people reached through messaging on prevention and access to services were so low (Figure 14). In the ongoing crisis and in future emergencies involving large numbers of mobile and displaced people, it will be critical to maximize the use of social media platforms to reach people with life-saving messaging.

UNICEF Syria Country Office's modality to document the emergency on the ground was efficient and allowed flexibility and timely documentation of the situation, needs and the organization's response. The UNICEF communications team has a list of freelance photographers/ videographers with whom it works. The Syria Country Office was also able to piggyback on MENARO existing LTAs when needed.¹⁰⁵ Other examples of good practice were the numerous field visits that were carried out by UNICEF Syria Country Office senior representatives and the media interviews conducted to increase visibility. UNICEF ensured that donors were kept updated through disseminating regular SitReps and appeal documents with them. The SitReps were also valued by donors. HQ invited the UNICEF Syria Country Office communications team to speak about how they integrate Children with Disabilities (CwDs) in their work, because they were considered to be one of the frontrunners on communications work reflecting CwD needs.



¹⁰² UNICEF, [Syria Humanitarian Situation Report No. 9 \(Earthquake\): 12 April - 2 May 2023](#), 5 May 2023.

¹⁰³ Syria Humanitarian Situation Report, 11 April 2023.

¹⁰⁴ UNICEF, [Syria Humanitarian Situation Report No. 1 \(Earthquake\)](#), 16 February 2023.

¹⁰⁵ UNICEF Advocacy Communication Resource Mobilisation, 11 April 2022.

Finding 14

In NGCAs, the UNICEF Outpost did not have an overall strategy to guide advocacy and communications work in the response. In terms of raising the visibility of the initial response, UNICEF was effective in joined-up advocacy efforts with the wider UN and in maximizing surge assistance to rebrand UNICEF aid packaging for NWS. However, UNICEF struggled to find a balance between raising awareness on the needs of children in NWS and fundraising objectives. Although the Outpost was effective in raising awareness in the international media, it was less present in the local media.

The evaluation identified three objectives in UNICEF's communications and advocacy approach in the L3 response: first, to raise awareness of the unmet needs of children in NWS and advocate for child rights more broadly; second, to advocate for higher visibility of UNICEF's role in the earthquake response;¹⁰⁶ and third, to raise funds.

In terms of outward-facing advocacy, very early in the response UNICEF (and other UN agencies) had to counter the narrative of both the slow response in NWS (there was a perception that all efforts were on the Turkish side of the border and not in NWS, especially when it came to search and rescue) and the lack of UN visibility in the response.¹⁰⁷ Despite having no advocacy and communications officer in the Outpost, surge personnel and the Head of CP proactively took on multiple international media interviews to raise UNICEF's profile in the initial response. However, according to internal sources consulted in this evaluation, the communications efforts to counter the slow response narrative were much weaker in the local media and local social media sites. This is because UNICEF was somewhat self-restricting in local and regional media, owing to the need to protect the confidentiality of Implementing Partners in NWS. To counter the challenge of low visibility, surge support was used effectively to help the Outpost with its rebranding strategy for aid entering and being distributed in NWS.

Sources consulted in this evaluation point to a tension between finding the right balance between humanitarian advocacy for the purpose of raising awareness on child rights and unmet needs and advocating solely for fundraising purposes. One key informant highlighted: "It was only when the funding started to run out that people became more mobilized on this issue. It is of concern that advocacy and communications is viewed as more important to raise funds (to secure jobs) than as humanitarian advocacy."¹⁰⁸ Yet in surge mission reports there was a very clear focus to try to generate a narrative towards results for children and building community trust in NWS.

Monitoring and information management

Ongoing monitoring for a viable evidence base

Finding 15

In GCAs, monitoring was maximized by the (gendered) use of TPMs and TPFs across the six Field Offices. For some sectors, such as CP, limited access to data and evidence for programming and advocacy has been a consistent operational reality. The evaluation found that monitoring systems could be enhanced with deeper consultation with the field offices and further efforts to capture the full extent of youth and volunteer engagement in the emergency response.

The UNICEF Syria Country Office relied significantly on TPMs and TPFs for monitoring activities during the earthquake response. It deployed between 77 and 94 TPFs across six FOs, covering all sectors and enabling good access to affected areas. The Country Office ensured that there was female representation within the number of TPMs throughout the six FOs, to increase reach and accountability to women and girls in the target communities. It collaborated closely with TPMs and TPFs throughout 2023 to ensure that programmes were adequately monitored

¹⁰⁶ The previous L3 evaluation in Syria highlighted: "Despite the high quality of UNICEF communications work, there is a perception among UNICEF partners that the organization is better at highlighting its own programming than raising the alarm about children's unmet needs." Evaluation of UNICEF L3 Response in Syria.

¹⁰⁷ The lack of visibility had been an inherited challenge from before the earthquake. In the initial stages of response, the UN pre-positioned supplies which were unmarked, owing to the UN's existing intentional low-visibility policy in NWS to mitigate anti-UN sentiment. This contributed to perceptions of a lack of timely UN presence or action, "despite the fact that significant activity in NWS was funded by the UN immediately after the earthquake." UNICEF, Syria Earthquake Report. 14 September 2023.

¹⁰⁸ KII NWS 04/24.

and that technical support was provided to support programme correction and adaptation where needed. Monitoring was also strengthened through enhancing field checklists and making sure that visits by TPMs to UNICEF-supported centres took place on a quarterly basis.¹⁰⁹ In total, 12,517 visits were carried out by TPFs, and the Syria Country Office was able to reach 22 per cent of the 3,285 communities with low to medium accessibility because of issues relating to insecurity and/or control.¹¹⁰

Monitoring of UNICEF's programmes could have been improved by strengthening data collection and analysis through, for example, CWM secondary data analysis and triangulation and designing indicators that more fully reflect the Syria Country Office's engagement with youth across a broad range of programme areas.¹¹¹ An important part of strengthening data collection and monitoring will be consulting the FOs more closely in the design of indicators and data collection, recognizing "the importance of ensuring a bottom-up approach in setting programme targets and indicators by engaging with FOs for increased accuracy."¹¹²

Other challenges experienced during and prior to the earthquake were difficulties in obtaining government approvals for monitoring purposes and limited direct access to affected populations for these monitoring activities.¹¹³ For some sectors, such as CP, limited access to data and evidence for programming and advocacy has been a consistent operational reality. Mitigation strategies have been developed, such as the use of rapid assessments, and CP has drawn heavily on sources such as the Humanitarian Needs Overview. Maximizing all the potential options for collecting credible data will involve continued efforts on the part of the Syria Country Office to build solid working relationships with government officials and ensure that the sectors at national and subnational level are well resourced with UNICEF officers.

The evaluation found that although lack of access to some data sources was a challenge in the response, the management of existing sources was of equal importance. In this respect, this country-level report

and the Overarching Report underline the criticality of role of IM specialists in the Country Office who can maximize UNICEF's digitalization tools to harvest and analyse existing information sources. A cadre of strong IM specialists would be well placed to address the Syria Country Office's self-identified "lack of a clear knowledge management approach."¹¹⁴

Finding 16

In NGCAs, the evaluation found that access into NWS presented UNICEF with new opportunities to monitor on the ground. However, during the L3 activation there was a lack of a structured approach to synthesize fragmented data flows and maximize monitoring data. This was more of a corporate-wide issue rather than an Outpost-specific challenge, and the roll-out of the new Field Monitoring Module (FMM) eTool significantly improved structuring of monitoring data in the latter stages of 2023. The application of situation monitoring in CP has proved to be a highly effective contribution to identifying priority areas in programming and a tool to be used for broader advocacy.

In terms of monitoring systems, the Outpost faced two challenges. First, they did not have the resources to synthesize qualitative and quantitative datasets from monitoring visits. If available, this would have better informed targeting decisions aimed at equity. This is a corporate-wide challenge and not an Outpost-specific issue. The Evaluation Team understands that this challenge has been significantly addressed in the latter stages of 2023, whereby programmatic monitoring visits in NWS have been more structured to meet programme needs as well as the HACT requirements. This has been largely because of the surge support in rolling out the pilot FMM platform and adoption of this module in the Outpost.¹¹⁵ This tool is designed to collect data on partners, risks, allocations and implementation locations into one comprehensive platform to better inform field planning and monitoring. When used systematically, this tool can maximize learning from (the brief) field visits into NWS,¹¹⁶ particularly in terms

¹⁰⁹ UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

¹¹⁰ UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

¹¹¹ UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

¹¹² Ibid.

¹¹³ Ibid.

¹¹⁴ Ibid.

¹¹⁵ The Outpost was among one of the first operations globally to adopt the FMM.

¹¹⁶ The Outpost staff recognized the value of this tool and its use moving forward in "GZT XB NWS Post 2 months Earthquake Mini-Moment of Reflection 6 April notes and action points."

of the analysis of granular data on implementation quality and identification of bottlenecks.

After the early phase of the earthquake response, UNICEF had access to plenty of sources of response monitoring, for example from the clusters and TPM reporting, but less data on situation monitoring. An example of good practice in this regard was in CP, wherein UNICEF developed its own situation monitoring tool (implemented and owned by a network of CP collaborators inside NWS). This tool is flexible enough to adapt to different data requirements. For example, in terms of sensitive questions, e.g., on child recruitment, this can be approached through questions on child separation. The data collection reaches to subdistrict level and contributes valuable granular information to the cluster system and UNICEF's own programme planning. This monitoring can also be used as an evidence-based tool to inform the donors where interventions should be prioritized in NWS.

Gaining access to NWS was a huge opportunity for UNICEF to monitor activities on the ground and verify the findings of the existing TPM monitoring systems. By early May, UNICEF had been able to conduct 27 missions inside Northern Aleppo and Idlib for programme monitoring and operational environment assessments.¹¹⁷ Although this was certainly an achievement, these trips were constrained in number and limited in movement flexibility when conducted as an inter-agency mission, and the distance to travel in one day from Gaziantep limited the actual time at UNICEF field sites. The failure to advance further on the continuum to a 'protective presence' (discussed below) meant that systematic and in-person monitoring by UNICEF staff was still somewhat limited. This has meant that UNICEF cross-border programming still relies on TPMs inside NWS.

Information management

Finding 17

In GCAs and NGCAs, the lack of sufficient IM officers at the outset of the response in both the Outpost and the Syria Country Office reduced the effectiveness of IM. In the Country Office, it led to the burnout of staff who were engaged in the complex and time-consuming SitRep reporting for the WoS. In NWS, the evaluation found that there was a structural challenge whereby the PME Unit had no reporting lines with the three IM specialists. This made the timely availability of information at PME level challenging because the IMOs sometimes prioritized sector-specific tasks. During the early part of the response, it emerged that there was a misalignment between the Outpost and the Syria Country Office's dashboards and SitRep reporting on actual reach numbers, leading to underreporting from the Outpost.

The PME's leadership role in the development of the SitReps was well recognized by sources consulted in this evaluation. It was a complex and time-consuming task to produce timely data for the SitReps, and this did lead to reporting fatigue in the later stages of the response, as reported by staff and documented in the After-Action Review.¹¹⁸ The shortage of staffing in IM significantly constrained the Syria Country Office's overall IM system. Describing the situation, one key informant explained: "By that time [when the earthquake hit] I was [...] triple hatting [...] I broke down in the end, actually. I got really sick and got to stay a week at home." Pressure was also placed on IMOs to produce tools on an ad hoc basis and within tight timelines. One key informant consulted in this evaluation reported that he was requested to create a tool in under a day to present to the Ministry of Education. However, once the tool was finalized the Syria Country Office decided to use another tool developed by OCHA.¹¹⁹ Despite these early challenges, the IM surge support was appreciated in terms of alleviating workload and contributing to a more streamlined and effective IM system. The issue of the needs around IM support in emergencies is explored further in the Overarching Report.¹²⁰

¹¹⁷ Syria Humanitarian Situation Report No. 9 (Earthquake)_ 12 April - 02 May April 2023.

¹¹⁸ UNICEF, Syria Earthquake Response: Internal After-Action Review Summary Note. June 2023; KII GCAs 04/24: KII GCAS 04/24.

¹¹⁹ KII GCAs 04/24.

¹²⁰ UNICEF, Syria Earthquake Response: Internal After-Action Review Summary Note. June 2023.

The earthquake also created opportunities for sectors such as SBC to develop new dashboard systems. The Social and Behavioural Change and Community Engagement (SBC-CE) dashboard helped UNICEF and partners track SBC-CE-related interventions in Aleppo, Idlib, Hama, Tartous and Latakia. UNICEF Syria Country Office also deployed HOPE (its corporate beneficiary database management tool) to help address key risks with the cash assistance (CA) beneficiary data management system.^{121,122}

During the response there was a misalignment between the Outpost and the Syria Country Office's dashboard and SitRep reporting on actual reach numbers. This was because of timing issues related to the Outpost uploading partner data and, at times, a lack of harmonization between narrative and figures. In some reporting periods, NWS partner reports were missing and therefore the Outpost underreported results. This problem was remedied, to some extent, by setting timelines for the sections to reach out to partners for inputs and then uploading this data before it was shared for SitRep narratives and for the Syria Country Office's use in the dashboards.¹²³

In NWS, the evaluation found that there was a structural challenge whereby the PME Unit had no reporting lines with the three IM specialists. This made the timely availability of information at PME level challenging because the IMOs sometimes prioritized sector-specific tasks. Documentation made available to the Evaluation Team indicates that there was a recommendation in May 2023¹²⁴ (after the Outpost Mini-Reflection session) to pool all IM specialists under the PME Unit to create a more streamlined and responsive IM system in the Outpost. If this recommendation is pursued in 2024, it would need to align with recently revised guidance on IM in the MENA region, which provides four options for structuring IM functions.¹²⁵ This Evaluation Team would propose that in an L3 emergency, the Outpost could consider creating an IM hub, then the IM hub staff would report to the PME Unit (with dotted reporting lines to programme sections). Given the unresolved nature of this issue, a deep dive on the needs of programme sections versus the role of PME, to determine the structure collaboratively would bring greater clarity to maximizing the use of IM in emergencies.

¹²¹ MENARO/HQ Peer Review of Syria CO Social Protection/Cash Programming: Mission Report (June 2023). Summary of Key Observations and Recommendations.

¹²² UNICEF, [Syria Humanitarian Situation Report No. 4 \(Earthquake\): 28 Feb - 6 Mar 2023](#). 13 March 2023.

¹²³ UNICEF, [Surge Mission Report Syria Earthquake Response 2023](#). 12 April 2023.

¹²⁴ The recommendation came from the Earthquake mini-reflection sessions and was supported by the (then) WoS Coordinator, Head of Office, Operations Manager on surge, Emergency Specialist and Head of PME. It was recommended to be implemented in September and was later recommended by the WoS Review. Evidence was presented in an email dated 12 May 2023 and written feedback from the Outpost to the Evaluation Team on 07/24.

¹²⁵ The recently revised IM guidance for MENA outlines four structure options for IM: Option 1: For the staff who is dedicated for cluster IM and the country is in onset and large-scale emergency, the post is recommended to report to the cluster coordinator alternatively Chief of Field Operations/humanitarian/emergency section. Option 2: In case, UNICEF CO programme section requires dedicated staff to fulfil UNICEF information management requirement (such as develop and deploy data collection tools, design and maintain database, conduct data collation and analysis, etc.) for emergency response, then the staff post will be IM officer/specialist and the position will report to programme section. **In case where the CO decides to create an IM hub, then the IM hub staff are recommended to report to the Planning and Monitoring section (with dotted reporting line to programme sections). Option 3: When the staff function and work is dedicated to UNICEF country programme (not only limited to emergency response in a section or cluster) and the work covers areas described below, then the staff reports to Planning and Monitoring section. Option 4: When the staff function and work is dedicated to a specific project or programme and the area of work focuses on strengthening the government IM systems (for instance, DHIS II/HMIS, EMIS, etc.) then the post will be named as Management Information System (MIS) officer/specialist and they report to the programme section or planning and monitoring section.

C

Cross-cutting

Extent to which cross-cutting issues were considered and integrated meaningfully into the response

Section C assesses the extent to which the cross-cutting issues of PSEA, SBC, protection, CC, gender, and the needs of persons with disabilities (PwDs) have been considered systematically and integrated meaningfully in the needs assessments, planning, implementation, monitoring and reporting of the response.



SUMMARY OF FINDINGS

In GCAs, the evaluation found that PSEA could be more effectively applied by investing greater efforts in raising awareness and encouraging the application of PSEA with the government and in NGCAs by ensuring that IP methodologies for engagement on PSEA and protection include men. SBC effectively built on the 2022 cholera response but extended beyond health messaging to issues such as disaster preparedness. SBC was most effective when initiated in a multi-sector approach and engaged youth in messaging and trust-building activities within affected communities.

The evaluation observed some climate change initiatives in GCAs, such as the solarization of schools and health facilities. However, climate smart technology that is vital to resilience building in both regions is difficult to fund. Although gender was disaggregated and reported on, there were no specific gender indicators. Such indicators could have told a more evidence-based story on UNICEF commitments to gender in an L3 response. It was difficult to match the scale of the needs on the ground for PwDs, although UNICEF made some targeted responses to reaching children through WASH facilities and psychosocial first aid.

PSEA

Finding 18

In GCAs, surge staff were important to supporting the initial gap in the PSEA work in the Syria Country Office, as were the guidelines and requirements that UNICEF had for partners prior to the earthquake. However, UNICEF could invest more efforts in raising awareness and encouraging the application of PSEA with the Government. This will be important for ongoing and future emergencies.

Surge support from the Regional Office contributed to bolstering capacity for PSEA in the L3 response through, for example, assisting in the recruitment of a PSEA specialist, which reportedly helped to strengthen PSEA across the Country Office,¹²⁶ and strengthening availability of safe reporting channels.¹²⁷ The guidelines and procedures that partners were required to follow prior to the earthquake were also important for ensuring PSEA measures were followed during the response. For example, some partners requested new staff sign codes of conduct and undergo PSEA training as per UNICEF guidelines and zero tolerance for SEA.¹²⁸ Training was provided to 150 partner staff and 200 UNICEF staff. According to a TPM study conducted between January and April 2023, more than 90 per cent of Implementing Partners had received PSEA training.¹²⁹ However, it is not clear whether all community volunteers received PSEA training prior to engaging in the earthquake response.¹³⁰ The evaluation commends UNICEF's strategic engagement of volunteers, and especially youth, in the earthquake response, but would highlight the need to systematically train all future responders in PSEA.

In terms of results, more than 532,734 children and adults were directly reached by awareness raising sessions, dissemination of information, education and communication (IEC) materials, and public media on PSEA.¹³¹ Unfortunately, as reported in the WoS SitRep, this figure is not disaggregated by

gender. Reporting only included those newly and directly reached to share information on safe, accessible reporting channels and did not include indirect outreach or a calculation of the population who already had access to these channels. The indicator is problematic because it does not provide a deeper insight into the impact of this awareness raising on affected populations. In terms of raising awareness of PSEA principles with the government, the evaluation found that some government counterparts were not aware of PSEA during the earthquake response period.¹³² Gaining greater traction with the government on PSEA is important and is returned to in the recommendations section of this report.

Finding 19

In NGCAs, the results of the PSEA reach in NWS were strong, and female recipients of UNICEF services spoken to in this evaluation expressed satisfaction with the awareness raising sessions on PSEA. However, in terms of responsive programming, the awareness sessions would have been more impactful if the engagement of men had been more considered. The MENARO Outpost redoubled its focus on PSEA in the earthquake response in two ways: first, by embedding PSEA indicators into PDs; second, by collaborating with the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) to develop a SEA risk mitigation framework.

In 2022, prior to the earthquake, 95.2 per cent of all sites supported by UNICEF in NWS had been verified as having access to UNICEF-supported PSEA reporting mechanisms. Acknowledging the rising SEA, GBV and safeguarding risks owing to the emergency conditions, the MENARO Outpost redoubled its focus on PSEA in the earthquake response in two ways. PSEA indicators were embedded into PDs. By participating in the PSEA in-country network, UNICEF and UNHCR developed a SEA risk mitigation framework and associated SOPs to ensure confidential, timely handling of SEA allegations when received.¹³³

¹²⁶ UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

¹²⁷ KII GCAs 04/24.

¹²⁸ KII GCAs 04/24.

¹²⁹ UNICEF Humanitarian Situation Report: 1 January to 30 June 2023; UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

¹³⁰ When the Evaluation Team asked Implementing Partners and UNICEF staff if there was PSEA training for all the volunteers who joined in the earthquake response (when the partners expanded to meet the increased needs), they either said no or were not sure if they were trained.

¹³¹ UNICEF Humanitarian Situation Report: 1 January to 30 June 2023.

¹³² KII GCAs 04/24.

¹³³ UNICEF, Syria Humanitarian Situation Report No. 9 (Earthquake): 12 April - 2 May 2023. 5 May 2023.

The results of the PSEA reach in NWS were strong, with 346,544 children and adults reached directly by awareness raising sessions, dissemination of IEC materials and public media on PSEA.¹³⁴ Female recipients of UNICEF services spoken to in this evaluation expressed strong satisfaction with the awareness raising sessions on PSEA and confirmed that information material was clearly displayed in the camps. Some recipients of UNICEF services noted that these sessions would have been more impactful if men had been included, to increase their understanding around PSEA issues. The evaluation finds that this was a missed opportunity to initiate a more transformative approach to PSEA outcomes and would further highlight the need to disaggregate reporting on PSEA in SitReps and also follow-up with Implementing Partners to understand their methodology for reaching men on PSEA issues.



SBC and RCCE

Finding 20

In GCAs and NGCAs, UNICEF effectively built on the 2022 cholera response and extended beyond health messaging to issues such as disaster preparedness. SBC was found to be most effective when initiated in a multi-sector approach and when maximizing the use of local media and social media (as shown in GCAs). In GCAs, youth had an important role to play in trust-building and explaining SBC messaging to affected communities. However, there is a need to systematically address how SBC can access money in section budgets prior to an emergency rather than having these difficult conversations during a response.

UNICEF Syria Country Office's SBC work was strongly informed by the CCCs and other global emergency SOPs as well as the community engagement guidance documents. In terms of awareness raising, SBC teams provided life-saving information on earthquake preparedness measures. Awareness raising campaigns were also carried out on the adoption of healthy and protective behaviour, including PSS self-care practices, and as has been elaborated elsewhere in this report, youth volunteers played a role in SBC messaging and building trust within affected communities.

SBC teams further implemented awareness raising activities which were multisectoral and which actively involved communities in their design, implementation and monitoring.¹³⁵ For example, SBC teams worked closely with the WASH, H&N, Education and Protection sectors to improve access to WASH facilities and services for people living in collective shelters and host communities, enhancing awareness among community members to adopt good hygiene practices.

Despite sensitivities around some SBC interventions in the prevailing context in NWS, the evaluation found that SBC and RCCE were better planned for and integrated in the L3 response (and coordinated with UN partners and IPs) than some UNICEF stakeholders give themselves credit for. The evaluation observed that concerted efforts were made to increase effectiveness of messaging by engaging with people of

¹³⁴ UNICEF, [Humanitarian Situation Report: 1 January to 30 June 2023](#). 2023.

¹³⁵ UNICEF, [Core Commitments for Children in Humanitarian Action](#). 2022; UNICEF, [Coping with a Disaster. How Behaviour Change and Community Engagement Supported Survivors of the February 2023 Earthquake in Syria](#). November 2023.

influence during the earthquake response.¹³⁶ Given that the SBC indicator (#of people participating in engagement actions for SBC) does not provide adequate insight into outcomes, the evaluation followed-up this issue in the FGDs in NWS¹³⁷ and identified seven areas of behaviour change and impact as a result of RCCE interventions.

The impact, as reported by the affected communities in the FGDs, was as follows:

- ▶ UNICEF's women's support sessions (in the camps) helped build a sense of community among recently displaced women.
- ▶ The provision of community play spaces, coupled with parenting skills and psychological first aid (PFA) sessions, reduced aggression among children and improved concentration.
- ▶ Messaging on hygiene for children resulted in a decreased prevalence of lice.
- ▶ There were improved food hygiene practices because of awareness campaigns.
- ▶ There was increased use of positive discipline approaches by mothers.
- ▶ Community sanitation improved with regard to timely removal of garbage from the streets.
- ▶ Increased knowledge on disaster preparedness resulted in reduced stress in adults and children.

The strong results for SBC were because the earthquake response built upon pre-existing cholera SBC interventions and there was a well-capacitated and trained cadre of IPs.¹³⁸ Based on the feedback from UNICEF service users, the Evaluation Team found that UNICEF has instituted SBC change interventions that go beyond disease, disaster risk communications and vaccination campaigns.¹³⁹ However, there is a need to systematically address how SBC can access money

in section budgets prior to an emergency rather than having these difficult conversations during a response.

Protection needs

Finding 21

In GCAs, UNICEF addressed protection issues with effective use of mobile teams and demonstrated strong ethical values in the protection of data vis-à-vis government demands, enhancing its credibility with donors.

In terms of operational response, UNICEF's mobile protection teams rapidly supported earthquake-affected populations by providing them with services such as: PFA sessions in collective shelters (CS); awareness activities on the earthquake response and how to act; case management (including GBV cases); and PSS counselling.¹⁴⁰ The evaluation found that the use of mobile teams was particularly effective at addressing needs in remote and hard-to-reach areas.¹⁴¹ Mechanisms for registration of separated and unaccompanied children were also established, and children, adolescents and caregivers were provided with access to community-based MHPSS.¹⁴² However, the short timelines for closure of CS were challenging and resulted in delays in UNICEF Syria Country Office being able to respond to the needs. Concerns were also raised as to whether families left the CS voluntarily or not.^{143,144}

There were also protection and confidentiality concerns in the CS.¹⁴⁵ UNICEF Syria Country Office demonstrated a highly principled approach by refusing government requests to share confidential protection data. Although this resulted in the temporary suspension of CA, it underlines UNICEF's commitment to maintaining ethical standards, and

¹³⁶ Results included 40 teachers, 28 religious leaders, 8 camp managers, 42 health workers and 55 other influencers participating in engagement activities for positive behavioural change in NWS. UNICEF, [Syria Humanitarian Situation Report No. 9 \(Earthquake\): 12 April - 2 May 2023](#). 5 May 2023.

¹³⁷ The FGDs numbers and gender disaggregation are presented in the Methodology Section of this report.

¹³⁸ MENARO SBC provided SBC training to the NWS IPs during the earthquake response.

¹³⁹ Recommendations on priority programme areas and effective modalities for UNICEF support to children in NW Syria via cross-border: "Social and behavioral change approaches are another UNICEF strength; in NWS these need to be more holistic and strengthened beyond disease and disaster risk communications and vaccination campaigns."

¹⁴⁰ UNICEF, Updates from SCO Field Offices. 08 February 2023.

¹⁴¹ Finding supported by KII GCAs 04/24 and KII GCAS 04/24.

¹⁴² UNICEF, Briefing for the EMT. 11 April 2023.

¹⁴³ UNICEF, Syria Earthquake Response: Internal After-Action Review Summary Note. June 2023.

¹⁴⁴ UNICEF Humanitarian Programme Document, Integrated response to the earthquake in Latakia Governorate and IDPs Families in Tartous Governorate (Hand-in-Hand). May 2023.

¹⁴⁵ KII GCAs 05/24.

this stance also contributed to strengthening credibility and trust with donors.¹⁴⁶ To highlight this, one donor consulted in this evaluation reported: “We appreciated the position taken by UNICEF, the principled position.”

Finding 22

In NGCAs, protection was integrated meaningfully into the planning and implementation of the response with some efforts towards measuring at outcome level. Of note was the immediate prioritization of protection needs at the outset of the response by the Implementing Partners. Through integrating protection needs into a multisector response, UNICEF was able to quickly respond to needs and work at scale. In responding to current and future emergencies, it will be important for UNICEF to understand and track Implementing Partner methodologies for including men in protection activities.

Protection was integrated meaningfully into the planning, implementation, reporting and monitoring of the response. Of note was the immediate prioritization of protection needs at the outset of the response by the Implementing Partners, which was highlighted as very valuable by UNICEF service users.¹⁴⁷ Through integrating protection needs into a multisector response (described in the text box on this page), UNICEF was able to quickly respond to needs and work at scale.

In terms of reach and impact, between January and June 2023, UNICEF provided MHPSS to 30,425 children (14,554 boys and 15,871 girls). Pre- and post-assessments undertaken by Implementing Partners demonstrate efforts to measure at outcome level and revealed an increase in overall psychosocial well-being among the children who regularly participated in the structured MHPSS sessions – from 30 per cent of children before the sessions to 90 per cent afterwards. Children showed increased levels of confidence and compassion and were able to express their emotions when feeling distressed. This positive impact on children’s well-being was strongly reinforced by female recipients of UNICEF services consulted in FGDs. They further elaborated that an improvement in their children’s psychological well-being correlated with an improvement in their own mental well-being and the overall well-being of the family.¹⁴⁸

From January to June 2023, approximately 70,642 caregivers (343 boys, 470 girls, 20,138 men and 49,691 women) were provided with parenting programmes, acquainting them with skills and tools to interact with their children. Female caregivers consulted in this evaluation who attended the programme reported improved communication through non-violent means. However, UNICEF reporting indicates that “fathers and male caregivers showed significantly less interest and commitment in participating.”¹⁴⁹ Female recipients reported to the Evaluation Team that it was a significantly missed opportunity that men were not involved in this programme. Without reaching out to men, the activities fell short of being transformative. For future emergencies, UNICEF Implementing Partners could redouble efforts to reach out more proactively to men, taking into account social gathering spaces and times when men are likely to be reached in higher numbers. It will also be important for UNICEF to understand and track Implementing Partner methodologies for including men in protection activities.

¹⁴⁶ KII GCAs 05/24.

¹⁴⁷ FGD NWS 05/24; KII NWS 05/24.

¹⁴⁸ UNICEF, [Humanitarian Situation Report: 1 January to 30 June 2023](#). 2023.

¹⁴⁹ UNICEF, [Humanitarian Situation Report: 1 January to 30 June 2023](#). 2023.

A multisector response to protection needs

“In NW Syria, an immediate Family Tracing and Reunification Mechanism has been established and centralized after the earthquake, linked to case management, initial screenings and protection assessments. The mechanism and registration modality have been shared across clusters addressed to CP and non-CP actors. Additionally, and to be able to support families managing a compounding crisis, UNICEF and partners will be setting up integrated education and child protection spaces near reception centres of families whose homes were damaged by the earthquake. The centres will provide an integrated service package to children and their parents/caregivers in a nurturing, accessible and safe environment. This will allow children and parents/caregivers to receive MHPSS, PFA, access to information and referrals to critical services, Family Tracing and Reunification, Child Protection Case Management, Emergency Case Fund (ECF), youth and adolescence engagement activities as well as Explosive Ordinance Risk Education (EORE).” – *Syria Humanitarian Situation Report No. 2 (Earthquake) 15-22 February 2023*

Climate change

Finding 23

In GCAs, UNICEF has accounted for climate change (CC) issues during the earthquake response, and there are good examples to highlight this in sectors such as education, where solar panels systems were installed in schools, and ADAP, where youth awareness campaigns promoted CC issues. However, a more overarching strategy is required to guide this issue in the recovery stage of the response, including collective advocacy on key climate health issues.

Good practice around CC includes the inclusion of preparedness measures for climate-related disasters in the EPP 2022. ADAP activities also included interventions that responded to CC needs.^{150,151} Rehabilitated schools and health centres were solarized (thus reducing the demand for fossil fuel energy)^{152,153} and climate resilience was integrated into WASH interventions.¹⁵⁴ UNICEF was able to secure a US\$1 million grant through a readiness proposal approved by the Green Climate Fund, shared with the United Nations Human Settlements Programme (UN-Habitat), for the purpose of undertaking a climate risk analysis.¹⁵⁵ UNICEF and partners also made efforts to reach adolescents through supporting two youth-led local conferences, which contributed to developing the global youth statement for the 28th UN Conference of the Parties (COP28) on CC.¹⁵⁶

The evaluation acknowledges the efforts made towards CC in the Syria Country Office, but a more overarching strategy is required to guide this issue in the recovery stage of the response to build back better. This includes a mechanism for collective advocacy work to promote issues such as sustainable access to safe drinking water for all and promoting renewable energy sources to mitigate the impact of CC in Syria.¹⁵⁷

¹⁵⁰ KII GCAs 04/24.

¹⁵¹ UNICEF Humanitarian Programme Document, Integrated response to the earthquake in Latakia Governorate and IDPs Families in Tartous Governorate (Hand-in-Hand). May 2023.

¹⁵² UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

¹⁵³ UNICEF 2023 End of Year Summary Narrative Report. 2023.

¹⁵⁴ UNICEF, Whole of Syria WASH response. January to October 2023.

¹⁵⁵ UNICEF, Whole of Syria WASH response. January to October 2023.

¹⁵⁶ UNICEF Syrian Arab Republic: Consolidated Emergency Report 2023, p.20.

¹⁵⁷ UNICEF, 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

Finding 24

In NGCAs, UNICEF recognizes the importance of moving towards climate smart technology in the early recovery and resilience building efforts in NWS. However, this goal is hampered by the expense of this technology and by donor red lines or earmarking.

CC has been identified as a key vulnerability to address in the early recovery in NWS.¹⁵⁸ As noted in other parts of this report, the earthquake was and is an opportunity for UNICEF to build back better for a more sustainable recovery. The Outpost has made some tangible process to instituting some CC strategies, most notably in the WASH sector by scaling up solar electrification of WASH services to replace expensive diesel and unreliable supplies from power grids. The evaluation understands that advocacy was carried out within donor communities to fund proposals from the humanitarian organizations to scale up solar electrification. However, resilient interventions such as solar-powered water stations and water treatment plants often tend to be expensive in the short term, and this is challenging in the restricted funding environment. However, these interventions tend to bring long-term savings, making community water and sanitation resilient to new shocks and providing an opportunity to introduce climate smart technology.¹⁵⁹ Despite increased donor support for some small rehabilitation and resilience building interventions, UNICEF is mostly reliant on internal (regular resources) flexible funding to implement sustainable and climate smart initiatives. UNICEF could prioritize using evidence-based advocacy to show potential donors what can be achieved with these types of interventions in terms of supporting the CC agenda and introducing long-term value for money into resilience programming.

Gender needs**Finding 25**

In GCAs and NGCAs, although gender was disaggregated and reported on during the L3 response, there were no specific gender indicators. Such indicators could have told a richer story of UNICEF work on gender in the emergency. The L3 response activities mostly met the intervention objective of gender-responsive programming, although some immediate responses were more gender-sensitive, which is understandable at the outset of a sudden onset emergency of this magnitude. In both contexts, UNICEF could have done more to engage males, for example in parenting skills and in psychological and trauma support, to make the programming more transformative. The evaluation found that there is a need to ensure that Implementing Partners in NWS share UNICEF's core values on gender and the rights of children to express themselves.

UNICEF Syria Country Office has largely been able to ensure that gender-related aspects were accounted for during the earthquake response. However, the evaluation notes that although gender was disaggregated and reported on during the L3 response, there were no specific gender indicators. Such indicators could have told a richer story of UNICEF work on gender in the emergency. Some of the good practices in addressing gender and equity issues during the earthquake response included the integration of GBV and PSEA in case management activities and the collection of sex-disaggregated data allowing for follow-up gender analysis.¹⁶⁰ ADAP programming also engaged young girls in the design and implementation of gender-sensitive interventions in CS and raised awareness of protection and safety procedures.¹⁶¹ WASH teams also improved access to gender-sensitive WASH facilities during the rehabilitation of schools. There was, however, a need to further engage male parents and caregivers in activities that promoted better and equitable parenting skills.

¹⁵⁸ IMMAP and USAID, [Post-Earthquake Perspective, Challenges and Strategies for Humanitarian Aid in Northwest Syria. Building Resilience: An Analysis of Principled Humanitarian Action in the Protracted Crisis of Northwest Syria](#), Ad Hoc Series Part 2. 17 September 2023, p.5.

¹⁵⁹ Recommendations on priority programme areas and effective modalities for UNICEF support to children in NW Syria via cross border, 258.

¹⁶⁰ UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

¹⁶¹ UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

In the L3 response in NWS, gender was integrated and disaggregated in planning, targeting and reporting. To varying degrees, the different needs of women, girls and boys were taken into account with the following interventions:

- ▶ immediate distribution of dignity kits to women,¹⁶² which were appreciated by the female service users consulted in this evaluation¹⁶³
- ▶ provision of separate male/female latrines and disability-appropriate latrines¹⁶⁴
- ▶ organizing male/female distribution lines¹⁶⁵
- ▶ provision of user-friendly facilities, reducing walking distances to water points and designing facilities that address the specific needs of girls, boys, women and men¹⁶⁶
- ▶ provision of WASH facilities, sex-segregated and ensuring adequate lighting in the camps for enhanced safety.¹⁶⁷

In line with the gender continuum model, these interventions represent gender-sensitive and gender-responsive approaches. Looking at the recovery and resilience-building stage of the earthquake response, there is a need for greater UNICEF reflection on structural/mindset change approaches. In any future gender-transformative programming, SBC engagement and a multisectoral approach will help to generate change at scale. A more immediate requirement is to ensure that Implementing Partners share UNICEF's core values on gender, especially with adolescents. This is critical, given an internal NWS mission report that documented that some Implementing Partner employees did not understand or support the rights of children to express themselves, especially girls.¹⁶⁸

People with Disabilities

Finding 26

In GCAs, the UNICEF Syria Country Office implemented some important interventions and approaches to support the needs of PwDs. However, the evaluation found that data could be disaggregated more consistently and training on the Washington Group questions will be an important element of readiness for ongoing and future emergencies. In NGCAs, although efforts were made to ensure that WASH facilities and public water points were made disability-friendly, especially for CwDs,¹⁶⁹ UNICEF did not systematically factor in the needs of PwDs into its response plan.

In GCAs, according to the HNAP, approximately 27 per cent of the population was disabled prior to the earthquake. This number is also likely to have risen after the earthquake. Despite high needs, the Inter-Agency Standing Committee (IASC) Operational Review observed a gap in the application of a disability lens in the UN-wide (i.e., not UNICEF-specific) response and recovery programmes.¹⁷⁰ Not all of UNICEF Syria Country Office's partners were able to collect disability-disaggregated data. The Washington Group questions (targeted questions aimed to provide a quick and low-cost way to collect disaggregated disability data) were not used because of the difficulty of training enumerators on this technique. The PME section did try to integrate some of the Washington Group questions but were not convinced by the results, because data collectors needed more capacity building to complete those questions.¹⁷¹ To enhance preparedness for future emergencies, Syria Country Office could invest time in training a cadre of enumerators on the Washington Group collection methods, or at least have a prepared training plan on hand in the PME section.

¹⁶² KII NWS 05/24.

¹⁶³ FGD NWS 05/24.

¹⁶⁴ KII NWS 05/24.

¹⁶⁵ KII NWS 05/24.

¹⁶⁶ UNICEF, [Syria Humanitarian Situation Report No. 9 \(Earthquake\): 12 April - 2 May 2023](#), 5 May 2023.

¹⁶⁷ UNICEF, [Humanitarian Situation Report: 1 January to 30 June 2023](#), 2023, 9.

¹⁶⁸ UNICEF Mission Report.

¹⁶⁹ RAM 2023.

¹⁷⁰ IASC Operational. Peer Review Mission Report. Syria Earthquake. 2-13 July 2023.

¹⁷¹ KII GCAs 04/24.

PDM data showed that some of the feedback and complaints boxes were in areas that were inaccessible to PwDs.¹⁷² The Evaluation Team acknowledges efforts made by the Syria Country Office to reach PwDs with CTs, but the horizontal expansion (i.e., enrolling new service users) was challenging. This issue is discussed in more depth below. Nevertheless, UNICEF Syria Country Office has good practice to showcase its accounting for PwDs during the earthquake response. For example, UNICEF and partners provided CwDs and caregivers with PSS services, including PFA, recreational activities, case management, mental health PSS and parenting sessions.¹⁷³ UNICEF Syria Country Office also worked closely with government counterparts to improve services for CwDs. For example, it supported the Ministry of Health to establish a team of trainers to provide rehabilitation services for CwDs in Lattakia and Hama.¹⁷⁴ Syria Country Office, together with the Syrian Commission for Family Affairs and Population and other stakeholders, developed a harmonized national parenting manual that includes sections tailored for parents of CwDs.¹⁷⁵

In NWS, prior to the earthquake, the HNAP estimated that 33 per cent of the population were disabled, and this number undoubtedly rose after 6 February 2023. Although efforts were made to ensure that WASH facilities and public water points were made disability-friendly, especially for CwDs,¹⁷⁶ UNICEF did not systematically factor in the needs of PwDs into their response plan, and as a result they could not actively respond to these needs writ large. In the planning of the response, UNICEF acknowledges that there was “insufficient programming for children with disabilities.”¹⁷⁷ This is evidenced in the UNICEF Immediate Response Plan for Syria (February 2023).¹⁷⁸ In this plan, people living with disabilities are only referred to twice under the sector of Cash and SP.

¹⁷² KII GCAs 04/24.

¹⁷³ UNICEF, [Syria Humanitarian Situation Report No. 4 \(Earthquake\): 28 Feb - 6 Mar 2023](#). 13 March 2023.

¹⁷⁴ UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

¹⁷⁵ IASC Operational. Peer Review Mission Report. Syria Earthquake. 2-13 July 2023.

¹⁷⁶ RAM 2023.

¹⁷⁷ UNICEF Briefing for the EMT 11 April, 8.

¹⁷⁸ This initial three-month response plan is part of the inter-agency Flash Appeal for the earthquake response and would be integrated into the revised 2023 UNICEF Syrian Arab Republic Humanitarian Action for Children (HAC). UNICEF-Immediate-Response-Plan-For Syria-(Earthquake)-16-February-2023, p.5.

D

Connectedness

Extent to which the response considered the humanitarian-development-peace nexus and resilience building considerations¹⁷⁹

Section D presents an assessment of the connectedness of the L3 response in terms of opportunities for resilience building in the early recovery phase. This is explored in terms of assessing the extent to which the L3 response built on pre-existing programme strands and provided a basis for multi-year interventions.



SUMMARY OF FINDINGS

The evaluation found that resilience building in the recovery phase of the response was and is critical for both regions in Syria. The Syria Country Office created opportunities for important rehabilitation work in WASH and sewage facilities, and efforts towards early recovery were assisted in part by some donors' increased flexibility towards early recovery programming. Resilience building in NWS has been more constrained, owing to the lack of an agreed early recovery strategy among international organizations, continued uncertainty over the border crossing, and an overall funding drop in NWS. Significantly, there is a lack of formalized governance systems in NGCAs of Aleppo and Idlib to anchor resilience interventions. Despite these challenges, UNICEF has developed creative, if ad hoc, initiatives to build resilience, especially in the area of Child Protection.

¹⁷⁹ This section corresponds to the connectedness criterion in the evaluation matrix.

Extent to which the response built on pre-existing programme strands, for example, in terms of existing development activities

Finding 27

In GCAs and NGCAs, the response was focused primarily on scaling up pre-existing programmes and service provision, mainly through the expansion of already established partnerships. This was a highly relevant approach because it enabled the Implementing Partners to deploy at speed using a set of tried and tested implementation approaches.

Prior to the L3, UNICEF had little presence in earthquake-affected areas such as Lattakia. In the response it was challenging for the Syria Country Office to establish new partnerships to respond in these areas, owing to both GoS and donor conditionalities.¹⁸⁰ These limitations affected UNICEF's ability to respond with speed and at scale in the immediate phase of the response. Finding partners with capacities to provide specialized services such as MHPSS and case management was difficult. To address this challenge, UNICEF engaged a capacity building firm to support in enhancing skills, quality and effectiveness of frontline workers, particularly in relation to MHPSS and parenting programming.¹⁸¹

With regard to the scaling up of pre-existing programmes, the value of having regular and good-quality programmes was important to facilitate the response scale-up, as were the strong partnerships with government counterparts. Examples include UNICEF Syria Country Office's expansion of its cash programming for CwDs and mental health and PSS.¹⁸²

In NWS the needs were overwhelming, with 91 per cent of the 4.5 million people living in the north-west in need of humanitarian assistance.¹⁸³ Given that programming in NWS prior to the earthquake had been predominantly humanitarian, it was relatively straightforward for the Outpost to scale up existing assistance modalities through partnerships with Implementing Partners. This approach was confirmed by affected communities,¹⁸⁴ UNICEF staff¹⁸⁵ and UNICEF reporting.¹⁸⁶ This was an effective approach because time was not lost forming new partnerships or trying to reach new areas unfamiliar to the Implementing Partners.

Extent to which activities, begun as part of the L3, provide a basis for recovery or multi-year interventions

Finding 28

In GCAs, the Syria Country Office invested time and resources to rehabilitate key infrastructure, particularly in regard to WASH provision, thus demonstrating a commitment to more sustainable solutions rather than quick win results. The shift to early recovery continues to be a challenge because of the issues of non-flexible funding and donor conditionalities.

In Syria GCAs, the Evaluation Team found many examples of well-considered and increasingly sustainable recovery and rehabilitation interventions carried out during the L3 response. The WASH response highlights some key early recovery achievements, which include, for example, installation of water tanks and rehabilitation of WASH facilities in schools in Lattakia and Jableh¹⁸⁷ and the repair of damaged water and sewage networks in Aleppo.¹⁸⁸

¹⁸⁰ KIIs GCAs 04/2024.

¹⁸¹ UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

¹⁸² UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

¹⁸³ UNICEF, Syria Humanitarian Action for Children (HAC) 2023 Revision 1. June 2023, p.1.

¹⁸⁴ FGD NWS 05/24.

¹⁸⁵ KII NWS 04/24: "Even before the earthquake, it was an emergency. So we used existing partners and expanded programmes with the funding."

¹⁸⁶ UNICEF, Syria Humanitarian Situation Report No. 1 (Earthquake): 16 February 2023. 18 February 2023: "UNICEF's humanitarian response is scaling up through the expansion of its already existing programmes mobilized to deliver assistance throughout Syria."

¹⁸⁷ UNICEF, Syria Humanitarian Situation Report No. 6 (Earthquake): 15 - 21 March 2023. 24 March 2023.

¹⁸⁸ UNICEF, Syria Humanitarian Situation Report No. 9 (Earthquake): 12 April - 2 May 2023. 5 May 2023.

In close collaboration with the Directorate of Health (DoH), UNICEF rehabilitated earthquake-damaged schools.¹⁸⁹ Further examples of recovery interventions in the education sector include the alignment of multiple education pathway curriculums with the national curriculum, to facilitate transition and placement of children back into public schools.¹⁹⁰ Local recovery interventions, such as skills-building activities and social cohesion interventions¹⁹¹ provided through ADAP teams, were also important activities aiming to achieve sustainable results. While some services were scaled-up in the L3 response, Syria Country Office also invested time and resources to rehabilitate key infrastructure, particularly regarding WASH provision, thus demonstrating a commitment to more sustainable solutions rather than quick-win results (elaborated upon further above).

The shift to early recovery continues to be a challenge because of the issues of flexible funding and donor conditionalities (elaborated upon in the Overarching Report). For example, Syria Country Office faced challenges in connecting 500 schools with the School Integrated Management System because the schools did not have suitable infrastructure and because of a lack of flexible funding.¹⁹² Donors such as the Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office (FCDO) and the Directorate-General for European Civil Protection and Humanitarian Aid Operations (DG-ECHO) reported being supportive of emergency humanitarian assistance combining developmental and sustainable approaches because of the protracted crisis in Syria and the need for more sustainable solutions. FCDO mentioned a shift in its funding towards early recovery and establishing a multi-year agreement with UNICEF Syria Country Office. Although DG-ECHO recognized the value of combining humanitarian and development approaches, political limitations remain.¹⁹³



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¹⁸⁹ UNICEF, Simplified Programme Document: Mosaic, Responding to the earthquake emergency in Lattakia Governorate. June – Sept. 2023.

¹⁹⁰ Syria Humanitarian Response Snapshot. Education. January-October 2023.

¹⁹¹ Syria Humanitarian Situation Report. 11 April 2023.

¹⁹² UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

¹⁹³ KIIs GCA 05/24.

Finding 29

In NGCAs, programming for recovery linked to longer-term resilience building is constrained by a significant funding decrease after the initial earthquake appeals, ongoing uncertainty about the border access, and the lack of formalized governance structures in the region to anchor to sustainable recovery interventions. Despite these challenges, UNICEF has developed creative, if ad hoc, initiatives to build resilience, notably CP programming.

UNICEF staff and documentation consulted in this evaluation recognize that the earthquake response was, and is, an opportunity to make an investment in a long-term recovery and build back better, in a way that is more resilient and more inclusive of the most marginalized.¹⁹⁴ This evaluation has identified three inhibitors that UNICEF will need to address carefully to be able to build back better.

The first is the significant decrease in funding in 2024 (funding had already been decreasing in NWS prior to the earthquake). This will require UNICEF to prioritize key areas of intervention and maximize approaches within the constrained funding environment. The second inhibitor is the political uncertainty with regard to UNSCRs on the border crossing.¹⁹⁵ This uncertainty has been a constraint to programme planning, both before and after the earthquake. The third challenge to multi-year resilience programming is the lack of a formal government in either the NSA-led area of Aleppo or HTS/SSG-led areas of Idlib. This means that there is no formal state infrastructure to which UNICEF inputs can be anchored for them to be sustainable in the longer term.

In the absence of an agreed WoS early recovery strategy that adequately addresses recovery in NWS, UNICEF has initiated some important strategies to overcome, or at least navigate, these three inhibitors. In the case of CP, with a minimal investment, the Outpost Team has been building the capacity of a network of protection specialists inside NWS who can continue key protection activities in the absence of UNICEF and, potentially, serve a future, more formalized state system.¹⁹⁶ UNICEF is also fully aware of the need to redouble advocacy efforts to better share the needs of NWS with the international community.¹⁹⁷ UNICEF key informants in this evaluation and the Outpost's own earthquake reflection documentation have identified the importance of maximizing key funding opportunities such as the Brussels Conference and Senior Officials Meetings (SOMs).¹⁹⁸ The Outpost is also replicating new approaches to PD formulation begun in the earthquake response. Six-month PDs are being formulated, with contingency clauses to allow for a little more predictable programming for partners in NWS.

¹⁹⁴ UNICEF, [Syria Humanitarian Situation Report No. 9 \(Earthquake\): 12 April - 2 May 2023](#). 5 May 2023; UNICEF, GZT XB NWS 2 Months Post-Earthquake Mini-Moment of Reflection. 6 April 2023; KII NWS HQ 06/2024; KII NWS 04/24.

¹⁹⁵ This was an observation made at the Outpost Mini-Moment of Reflection, which stated that UNSCR uncertainty "should not constitute a roadblock to planning strategically to reach children. Historically, it is funding which has been more of a hamper to forward planning, and not the variables at play in NWS." UNICEF, GZT XB NWS 2 Months Post-Earthquake Mini-Moment of Reflection. 6 April 2023.

¹⁹⁶ Although a formal government in either Aleppo or Idlib NGCAs seems a very distant prospect, a recent report by DG-ECHO noted: "the SSG had been steadily 'professionalising' its governance by recruiting staff with experience in the civil service or the humanitarian sector." DG-ECHO, [Cross-Border: Access Coordination in North-west Syria](#). 2023.

¹⁹⁷ UNICEF, GZT XB NWS 2 Months Post-Earthquake Mini-Moment of Reflection. 6 April 2023, 29..

¹⁹⁸ UNICEF, GZT XB NWS 2 Months Post-Earthquake Mini-Moment of Reflection. 6 April 2023, 29; KII NWS RO 05/2024.

Extent to which UNICEF had engaged with relevant government authorities and the UN system¹⁹⁹

Section E presents an assessment of the coherence of UNICEF's L3 response in terms of the extent of meaningful engagement with the government in Syrian GCAs and engagement with the DfAs in NWS (Idlib and Aleppo). This section also explores the quality and outcomes of UNICEF's engagement with the wider UN system.



SUMMARY OF FINDINGS

In GCAs, while UNICEF was proactive in leveraging relations with existing government interlocutors during the L3 response, more could be done to build strategic relationships with government authorities in charge of emergency response, i.e., developing relations beyond UNICEF's existing ecosystem of Syrian counterpart ministries. The Syria Country Office contributed to a coherent wider UN response and was praised by other UN Agencies for its collegial approach. It also seized important opportunities to engage in strategic and policy-level matters through close relations with the Resident Coordinator (RC) Office.

In NGCAs, the earthquake provided an opportunity in crisis to engage with the DfAs in Idlib and Aleppo. This opportunity was seized in the early phases of the response but became increasingly self-restricting, because of ambiguity over who would lead this engagement and a lack of strategy for the engagement. Overall, the Outpost collaborated constructively with the wider UN system working on the cross-border response. However, UNICEF's initial appetite for risk with regard to access in NWS, coupled with its forward-leaning duty of care policies, created some tensions with some UN agencies.

¹⁹⁹ This section corresponds to the coherence criterion in the evaluation matrix.

Collaboration and engagement with relevant government authorities

Engagement by the SCO in GCAs

Finding 30

In GCAs, while UNICEF was proactive in leveraging relations with existing government interlocutors during the L3 response, more could be done in building strategic relations with government authorities in charge of emergency response, i.e., developing relationships beyond their existing ecosystem of Syrian counterpart ministries. There is also a need to re-double efforts to build a better understanding within relevant government departments on issues of AAP and PSEA.

As highlighted above, despite the best efforts on the part of the Evaluation Team and Syria Country Office, only three government key informants were available to participate in this evaluation. Therefore, evidence has been drawn from international stakeholders, partners and secondary sources.

A clear strength of the Syria Country Office response in GCAs was its pre-existing relationship with government counterparts, which it was able to leverage during the response. Examples of this are provided in surge reports, RAM reporting and in internal documentation. One example of how UNICEF leveraged these relationships was advocacy applied to the MoH to speed up customs clearance for emergency medical supplies.²⁰⁰ UNICEF also supported the Government to develop key strategies and advocate for the health rights of children,²⁰¹ and engaged with Syria Trust and DoH to ensure coordinated distribution and monitoring of breast milk substitute (BMS) during the earthquake response.²⁰² The Syria Country Office advocated to the MoH and other line ministries for improved access for vulnerable children and women to H&N services. These efforts were reflected early on during the response, when UNICEF Syria Country Office coordinated with the MoH and responded from day one of the earthquake. Overall, the experience that government counterparts had

with UNICEF Syria Country Office during the earthquake response contributed to further consolidate the relationship. Nevertheless, more advocacy was needed from UNICEF Syria Country Office for flexible funding to allow work with government counterparts such as the Ministry of Education (MoE) on areas such as rehabilitation work and systems strengthening.²⁰³

UNICEF Syria Country Office also collaborated with local authorities and government counterparts to help de-conflict earthquake response interventions. For example, in February 2023 UNICEF H&N officers conducted a mission to Lattakia to assess the situation and enhance coordination with all actors under leadership with the DoH.²⁰⁴ UNICEF Syria Country Office worked closely with the Ministry of Social Affairs and Labour (MoSAL) to deliver emergency CA to earthquake-affected families through the vertical and horizontal expansion of two humanitarian CT programmes.²⁰⁵ However, the relationship with the Government was challenging in CT programming, particularly over issues of data protection as described in earlier sections of this report.

The evaluation found that while UNICEF was proactive in leveraging relations with existing government interlocutors during the L3 response, more could be done in building strategic relations with government authorities in charge of emergency response, i.e., develop relationships beyond their existing ecosystem of Syrian counterpart ministries. There is also a need to re-double efforts to build a better understanding within relevant government departments on issues of AAP and PSEA. These findings are returned to in the recommendation section of this report.

²⁰⁰ UNICEF MENARO Mission Report Syria Arab Republic, 08-14 July 2023. 2023.

²⁰¹ Syria Humanitarian Response Snapshot. Health and Nutrition. January-October 2023.

²⁰² UNICEF, Syria Surge Final Report, Sourav Bhattacharjee. 2023.

²⁰³ UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

²⁰⁴ UNICEF, Updates from SCO Field Offices. 08 February 2023.

²⁰⁵ UNICEF, [Key Highlights: Rapid Post-Distribution Monitoring Survey – Hama Governorate: Emergency cash assistance to earthquake-affected families caring for children with disabilities](#). May 2023.

Finding 31

In NGCAs, despite the complexities of the DfA arrangements in Idlib and Aleppo, the earthquake response provided an opportunity in a crisis to engage with the DfA for the rights of children and to plan for a recovery that would be more focused on sustainability and resilience. The technical engagement approach on children and armed conflict (CAAC) in Aleppo yielded strong results. However, the Outpost has become increasingly self-restricting in its appetite for engagement. The impact of this is twofold: first, a lack of nuanced understanding of the recovery agenda of key stakeholders in NWS (especially Idlib); second, from a risk perspective, UNICEF will have little recourse to dialogue with the DfA to resolve any threats to project implementation.

In the L3 response, UNICEF clearly recognized (at HQ, regional and Outpost – including surge – levels)²⁰⁶ that it could not work on recovery programming without engaging the DfA and that “early recovery is not just about inputs, it’s about relationships with the DfA and communities.”²⁰⁷ Although much ground-work was done by EMOPS at the outset of the L3 to look at the development of a strategy for engagement, this is still lacking. The May 2023 mission of UNICEF Emergency Director to Idlib was a significant moment in opening a dialogue with the DfA, who were, reportedly, very open and pragmatic in sharing their concerns over water and the safety of children. Since that visit, there has been an attenuated interest in engagement, particularly compared to the approach taken by WHO and OCHA. Instead, UNICEF has been more comfortable for OCHA to lead the engagement and dialogue. Key informants at UNICEF regional and HQ levels consulted in this evaluation consider that this was a missed opportunity for UNICEF to substantively engage in NWS, per its right, articulated in the CCCs, as a humanitarian organization.²⁰⁸ This lack of a forward-leaning approach can be understood partly as a result of a lack of clarity within UNICEF on who should lead the engagement,²⁰⁹ especially within the complex architecture of the WoS. The implementation of the WoS Review recommendations in 2024 could be an opportunity to revisit thinking on engagement with the DfAs in NGCAs.

This is not to say that the more cautious technical engagement approach has not yielded results. UNICEF’s advocacy with the Syrian National Army (SNA) on CAAC has led to the formulation of an action plan, which was signed on 3 June 2024. This is a strong achievement and another opportunity for UNICEF to use this action plan as an advocacy platform to further the rights of children in NWS, especially in terms of a lever for strengthened adolescent programming for prevention and reintegration.²¹⁰ It may also be a gateway to engaging with the SSG/HTS on CAAC, although this will be complex and challenging given that they are on international terrorist lists, and subject to sanctions and donor red lines. In terms of other opportunities to capitalize upon, there is some low-hanging fruit on which UNICEF can seek meaningful engagement with the DfA in terms of strengthening of primary health care systems and ongoing routine immunization efforts.

Engagement with the UN system

Finding 32

In GCAs, UNICEF has put effort into collaborating with UN agencies to ensure a coordinated response that is operated at scale, and it has been recognized by other UN agencies for its collegial approach to coordination during the L3.

As leads/co-leads for four sectors, UNICEF Syria Country Office was active in coordinating the response with sector partners to ensure a coherent response. For example, UNICEF as WASH sector lead coordinated the response/plans of WASH sector partners in Latakia governorate through sharing information and gaps in order to avoid duplication in the response.²¹¹ According to a peer review, UNICEF SP engaged actively in the Cash Working Group (CWG), particularly at subnational level, providing technical inputs and sharing best practices.²¹² UNICEF has also engaged strategically with UN partners over the issue of building resilience during the recovery period. This has been done through strengthening its partnership with the RC’s Office through the UN Strategic

²⁰⁶ KII NWS HQ 06/24; KII NWS RO 04/24; KII RO 05/24; KII NWS 04/24.

²⁰⁷ KII NWS 05/24.

²⁰⁸ KII NWS RO 05/24; KII NWS HQ 06/24; KII NWS HQ 06/24.

²⁰⁹ However, it is understood that the job description for the new Emergency Specialist to lead the Outpost (to be recruited in mid-2024) does include the role of leading on engagement with the DfA in NWS.

²¹⁰ UNICEF Briefing for the EMT 11 April, 13.

²¹¹ UNICEF, Updates from SCO Field Offices. 08 February 2023.

²¹² UNICEF MENARO/HQ Peer Review of Syria CO Social Protection/Cash Programming: Mission Report. June 2023.

Framework for Syria 2022–2024, to implement the UN Joint Work Plan and Joint Programme and to support the Voluntary National Report process in partnership with the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO), the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), the United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA), UN-Habitat and the World Food Programme (WFP). UNICEF internally reported in the 2023 End of Year Summary Narrative that these partnerships produced concrete and measurable resilience and recovery-oriented results across all results areas.²¹³

One example of UNICEF's collaborative approach in the wider UN system during the L3 response was in nutrition, where the Syria Country Office collaborated closely with WHO and WFP to jointly lead on technical advocacy with the MoH.²¹⁴ UNICEF worked with OCHA, UNHCR and other UN agencies to deploy a cross-sectoral needs assessment using SYNAT in communities in Tartous governorate and neighbourhoods in Lattakia city.²¹⁵ UNICEF Syria Country Office also reached an agreement with UN agencies on referrals and case management, to address the different needs of earthquake-affected populations in an effort to strengthen AAP.²¹⁶ It also coordinated closely with OCHA to update and integrate the earthquake response into the Humanitarian Response Plan (HRP).²¹⁷

Finding 33

In NGCAs, overall, UNICEF's engagement with the UN system was active and cooperative. In the key area of coordinating access into NWS, initially the collaboration was productive, but UNICEF's appetite for risk outstripped that of some other UN agencies. However, UNICEF's forward-leaning duty of care policies put it at odds with its sister agencies, creating lingering tensions in the wider UN community.

Access leading to a 'protective presence' in NWS was an extraordinary opportunity for the UN and its partners to pivot from remote programming and engage with communities and authorities inside Idlib and Aleppo. From the first inter-agency visit to Idlib on

14 February 2023 to 14 May 2024, the UN was able to conduct 469 inter-agency missions into NWS.²¹⁸ Despite this achievement, some UNICEF Outpost²¹⁹ and surge personnel felt that one-day trips into NWS were not time-effective and that there was a need for a more sustained presence.²²⁰ The phased approach for reaching a 'protective presence' was to: establish a hub on the Türkiye side of the border; conduct sleepover missions in NWS; and establish a mini-presence/small hub inside NWS. Internal and external sources consulted in this evaluation suggest that UNICEF initially pushed UN agencies hard for this presence, but UNICEF stakeholders felt that too much time was spent talking and that ultimately this led to derailing the 'protective presence' idea.²²¹ The evaluation found that in the early response, UNICEF's risk appetite was often higher than that of its sister agencies, in particular the United Nations Department for Safety and Security (UNDSS).

One policy area where UNICEF did not align at pace with the UN system was on the issue of duty of care to staff and Implementing Partners. UNICEF was very forward-leaning in developing an (internally) well-regarded duty of care policy. However, despite various UN-wide meetings on the issue, consensus could not be reached. OCHA followed UNICEF's lead, but other UN agencies felt that this should have been agreed as a collective group and that UNICEF's 'go it alone' attitude created dissatisfaction within their own cadre of staff and partners at a particularly traumatic time. This caused some lingering tensions between UN agencies operationalizing the cross-border response. Looking forward, the evaluation would advocate that common ground needs to be found on duty of care policies internally in UNICEF and among the wider UN family, to be better prepared for future emergencies. The issue of duty of care to Implementing Partners is also examined in the Overarching Report.

²¹³ UNICEF 2023 End of Year Summary Narrative Report. 2023.

²¹⁴ UNICEF, Syria Surge Report, Sourav Bhattacharjee. 2023.

²¹⁵ Syria Humanitarian Situation Response. 11 April 2023.

²¹⁶ Syria Humanitarian Situation Response. 11 April 2023.

²¹⁷ UNICEF, Syria Earthquake Response: Internal After-Action Review Summary Note. June 2023.

²¹⁸ OCHA, Situation Report for Northwest Syria, 15 May 2024.

²¹⁹ KII NWS Surge 05/24; KII NWS Surge 06/24.

²²⁰ Mission Report, NWS 2023.

²²¹ KII NWS Surge 05/24; KII NWS Surge 06/24; KII NWS RO 04/24; KII NWS HQ 06/04.

F

Coordination

Extent to which UNICEF has provided coordination in the Cluster/sectors and formed effective partnerships with implementing partners²²²

Section F analyses the criterion of coordination in the L3 response. This criterion is looked at in terms of cluster/sector leadership and AoR, effective partnerships with national partners, and the extent to which UNICEF has advanced the localization agenda in the L3 response.



SUMMARY OF FINDINGS

In GCAs, the evaluation found that UNICEF played a strong role in the national-level sectors but was less prominent in subnational sectors because of understaffing in the early stages of the response.

For both GCAs and NGCAs, Implementing Partners were the fulcrum of the L3 response on the ground. National partners expressed very high satisfaction levels with their relationship with UNICEF, particularly highlighting equality in the relations. In NWS, the pivot from remote programming to on-the-ground monitoring opportunities tested the relations between UNICEF and its Implementing Partners but ultimately did not impact on the functionality of the partnerships.

In GCAs and NGCAs, UNICEF provided Implementing Partners with a range of capacity building opportunities, particularly emergency preparedness training, in line with the CCCs on localization. Although UNICEF is providing more than double the 25 per cent Grand Bargain funding target to national NGOs, this alone is not a key criterion for measuring the advancement to localization principles. Despite some creative approaches in PD extensions instigated in the L3 response, multi-year planning and funding is challenging to achieve. Further progress is required to ensure that, “Localization of humanitarian and development programming is supported through multi-year, predictable and flexible funding. Systems are in place to track, monitor and report on these investments.” (CCC Resource mobilization 3.6)

²²² This section corresponds to the coordination criterion in the evaluation matrix.

Cluster leadership and AoR

Finding 34

In GCAs, UNICEF showed strong leadership in sector coordination at the national level. However, the Syria Country Office fell short of CLARE II evaluation recommendations on staffing of the sectors and was less prominent at the subnational level during the initial stages of the earthquake response.

Prior to the earthquake, UNICEF did not have dedicated coordinators for the Nutrition or Education sectors or for the WASH, CP and Nutrition subnational sectors.^{223,224} In the L3 activation, UNICEF Syria Country Office brought in additional surge staff to support the sectors at the national and subnational levels. However, the recruitment of surge staff took time, for various reasons such as availability of rostered staff and willingness of UNICEF country offices and departments to relinquish staff for surge missions. This issue is explored more thoroughly in the Overarching Report.

The lack of IM support (for sector coordination mechanisms) was a gap that UNICEF struggled with even prior to the earthquake. These gaps in IM staffing have been highlighted globally as problematic in the CLARE II evaluation (2022)²²⁵ and in the evaluation of UNICEF's L3 crisis in Syria (2022).²²⁶ The prioritization of surge staff to support subnational sector coordination contributed to strengthening UNICEF's role at the field level. Key achievements of UNICEF's leadership of the sectors included reinforcing the SOP on BMS for Syria,^{227,228} consolidating the sector inputs into the SERNA, actively contributing to the drafting of the HRP,²²⁹ and actively negotiating for access and delivery of life-saving services across all sectors.²³⁰ Through its leadership in the CP AoR, UNICEF

provided guidance, mentorship and standardization of interventions (such as joint rapid assessments, awareness raising and case management) across the 52 national, local and international sector partners.^{231,232,233} As reported by external key informants in this evaluation, UNICEF's role in sector coordination was greatly valued by sector partners, donors and government stakeholders. However, there was some frustration that capacities during the surge did not remain after the initial response.²³⁴

These findings shine light on the issue of sustainable solutions to ensure continued cluster/sector staffing. UNICEF as the CLA has not yet put in place the systems and resources globally needed to ensure that sector coordination positions remain filled without depending on surge rosters.²³⁵ The CLARE II evaluation has highlighted that despite achievements in the staffing of coordination positions in countries, staffing gaps remain at the country level, and clusters/sectors have taken on more responsibilities, usually at the expense of more strategic work.²³⁶



²²³ KII GCAs 05/24.

²²⁴ UNICEF, Syria Earthquake Response: Internal After-Action Review Summary Note. June 2023.

²²⁵ UNICEF, [Evaluation Report. Evaluation of the UNICEF Role as Cluster Lead \(Co-Lead\) Agency \(CLARE II\)](#). January 2022.

²²⁶ UNICEF, [Evaluation of the UNICEF Response to the Level 3 Humanitarian Crisis in Syria](#). October 2022.

²²⁷ UNICEF also coordinated on this issue with NGOs that were not part of the sector, such as Syrian Arab Red Crescent (SARC) and Médecins Sans Frontières (MSF) to coordinate distribution and monitoring of BMS, particularly from private donors.

²²⁸ UNICEF, Syria Surge Report, Sourav Bhattacharjee. 2023.

²²⁹ UNICEF, Syria Surge Report, Sourav Bhattacharjee. 2023.

²³⁰ UNICEF 2023 End of Year Summary Narrative Report. 2023.

²³¹ UNICEF 2023 End of Year Summary Narrative Report. 2023.

²³² UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

²³³ UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

²³⁴ KII GCAs 04/24; KII GCAs 04/24.

²³⁵ UNICEF, [Evaluation Report. Evaluation of the UNICEF Role as Cluster Lead \(Co-Lead\) Agency \(CLARE II\)](#). January 2022.

²³⁶ UNICEF, [Evaluation Report. Evaluation of the UNICEF Role as Cluster Lead \(Co-Lead\) Agency \(CLARE II\)](#). January 2022.

Extent to which UNICEF has formed effective partnerships with its Implementing Partners and advanced the localization agenda

Consultation and reliance on NGO IPs

Finding 35

In GCAs, local partners were a significant asset to UNICEF's L3 response and were at the forefront of implementation. They acted as key interlocutors with earthquake-affected communities and were actively involved in the development of SBC community action plans. However, it was not clear how actively partners participated, and were consulted with, in coordination mechanisms.

UNICEF made sure to actively engage partners in the design and implementation of the response. This was mentioned across all the interviews with Implementing Partners. The UNICEF staff survey findings show that 94 per cent of staff reported that local NGOs/civil society organizations (CSOs) were consulted (56 per cent said to a large extent and 38 per cent said to some extent) in the design and rollout of the responses when this became possible. UNICEF SBC teams, for example, co-developed community action tools with local partners and communities. They were trained on the tools and participated in identifying solutions to community problems and developing plans and activities based on these exercises.

UNICEF's partners were also the key interlocutors with the earthquake-affected communities, consulting with them to ensure that the response addressed their needs. For example, when planning to distribute winter clothing for earthquake-affected communities, partners went into the field and assessed their specific needs and preferences in terms of types of clothing, to ensure that the support was relevant. UNICEF also capitalized on its local partners to collect data in locations where access to communities was

difficult. In terms of consultations with partners in the UNICEF-led/AoR sectors, the picture of consultation is less clear. The evaluation found that UNICEF made efforts to ensure that local partners participated in the sector coordination mechanisms, formulating PDs requiring them to attend sector coordination meetings to avoid duplication.²³⁷ However, it is not clear how actively partners participated, and were consulted with, in these coordination mechanisms.

Finding 36

In NWS, the MENARO Outpost's cohort of national partners was the fulcrum of the L3 response and will be integral to the shift to more resilience and sustainable programming in NWS. UNICEF access into NWS tested the relationship between UNICEF and its national partners, leading to hidden frictions on both sides, but the evaluation found that this did not affect the functionality of the partnerships.

In 2023, the Outpost was working with 19 NGO partners in NWS.²³⁸ Of these, 16 were national NGOs with offices and registration in Türkiye.²³⁹ UNICEF had been working with these partners on a long-term basis. Given the remote programming modality before the earthquake, UNICEF was heavily dependent on these partners for implementation, and UNICEF used TPMs for monitoring and quality assurance. Based on five KIIs with UNICEF Implementing Partners and in concert with previous evaluations,²⁴⁰ the Evaluation Team found UNICEF's Syrian NGO partners to be of notably high calibre and with strong capacities. This was evidenced through a review of their internal monitoring and AAP architecture, their exposure to various capacity trainings provided by UNICEF (and other partners), and UNICEF's own internal reflections on their partnerships.²⁴¹ It is therefore logical that this cohort of national partners was the fulcrum of the immediate L3 response and will be integral to the recovery shift to more resilience and sustainable programming.

It is hard to overestimate the impact on the emotional and mental well-being of national partners impacted by the earthquake on both sides of the border. However, Implementing Partners quickly mobilized,

²³⁷ UNICEF, Simplified Programme Document: Mosaic, Responding to the earthquake emergency in Lattakia Governorate. June – Sept. 2023.

²³⁸ Partnership data provided to the Evaluation Team by the PME Unit in the Outpost.

²³⁹ It is a legal requirement for the Turkish Government that Syrian NGOs must have a registered office in Türkiye to be able to receive funds from international organisations.

²⁴⁰ Evaluation of UNICEF's L3 Response in Syria (UNICEF 2022); Recommendations on Priority Programme Areas and Effective Modalities for UNICEF Support to Children in Northwest Syria via Cross-Border Operations (Whole of Syria Review, 2023).

²⁴¹ UNICEF, GZT XB NWS 2 Months Post-Earthquake Mini-Moment of Reflection. 6 April 2023.

most immediately for debris and rescue work and then to conduct needs assessments. It is important to note that in the immediate response, communication lines were down with Türkiye, so there was very little opportunity for consultations between UNICEF and IPs inside NWS at the outset and initial design of the response. This had an impact on the ability of partners inside Syria to report needs to their own offices in Gaziantep, who could then relay information on to UNICEF. As noted above, Implementing Partners lacked a unified needs assessment tool, creating fragmented data flows for response planning. This indicates a weakness in terms of institutionalizing the Grand Bargain Workstream 5 on needs assessments and UNICEF's own CCCs in this regard.²⁴²

The test of the relationship between UNICEF and its national partners came with UN access into NWS, i.e., a hard pivot away from the remote programming approach. 'Hidden frictions'²⁴³ emerged in these relationships. From UNICEF's side, some staff mentioned Implementing Partners positioning themselves as gatekeepers to the communities²⁴⁴ and pointed to some discomfort from IPs because of UNICEF's increased capacity to monitor partners on the ground.²⁴⁵ As documented in external evaluations²⁴⁶ and by KIIs in this evaluation, some Implementing Partners began to feel exposed with the high visibility of the UN missions into NWS, especially those working in the sensitive area of CP. The Evaluation Team did not find that these tensions qualitatively affected the partnerships; indeed, Implementing Partner satisfaction with their relationship with UNICEF was very positive, with one key informant reflecting on genuine equality of the partnership with UNICEF.²⁴⁷

Resources dedicated to capacity development and commitments to the localization agenda

Finding 37

In GCAs and NGCAs, before, during and after the L3 response, UNICEF provided Implementing Partners with a range of capacity building opportunities, particularly emergency preparedness training, in line with the CCCs on localization. Although UNICEF is providing more than double the 25 per cent Grand Bargain funding target to national NGOs, this alone is not a key criterion for measuring the advancement to localization principles. Despite some creative approaches in PD extensions instigated in the L3 response, multi-year planning and funding is challenging to achieve. Further progress is required to ensure that, "Localization of humanitarian and development programming is supported through multi-year, predictable and flexible funding. Systems are in place to track, monitor and report on these investments." (CCC Resource mobilization 3.6)

In the initial aftermath of the earthquake, Implementing Partners described capacity development as primarily a form of 'on-the-job training.' However, when it was possible, UNICEF Syria Country Office provided various capacity building opportunities to partners and TPM teams, such as training on AAP and PSEA.²⁴⁸ A capacity building firm was also brought in to build the technical skills of frontline CP workers.²⁴⁹ Partners were provided with training on self-care and PSS for frontline workers.²⁵⁰ UNICEF Syria Country Office's efforts to strengthen partners' capacities in reporting are also in line with the Grand Bargain commitments.²⁵¹ These include, for example, training provided to 165 education sector partners to ensure quality reporting mechanisms.²⁵²

²⁴² WORKSTREAM 5: Improve joint and impartial needs assessments. CORE COMMITMENT: 5.1. Provide a single, comprehensive, cross-sectoral, methodologically sound, and impartial overall assessment of needs for each crisis to inform strategic decisions on how to respond and fund, thereby reducing the number of assessments and appeals produced by individual organisations.

²⁴³ KII MENARO 04/24.

²⁴⁴ FGD NWS Internal 04/24.

²⁴⁵ Mission Report NWS 04/24; FGD NWS Internal 04/24; KII NWS 04/24.

²⁴⁶ iMMAP and USAID, Post-Earthquake Perspective: Challenges and Strategies for Humanitarian Aid in Northwest Syria. System Failure: How the [Earthquakes Exposed the Limits of the International System in Northwest Syria](#), Ad Hoc Series Part 1. 15 June 2023.

²⁴⁷ KII NWS 04/24.

²⁴⁸ UNICEF, Briefing for the EMT. 11 April 2023.

²⁴⁹ UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

²⁵⁰ Syria Humanitarian Situation Report. 11 April 2023.

²⁵¹ Grand Bargain Commitments by Workstream.

²⁵² UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

The evaluation found that capacity building interventions with youth were a particularly effective strategy in terms of enhancing their role as trust-builders within communities. Youth volunteers became an important part of the earthquake response, capacitated by UNICEF in areas such as life skills in emergency,²⁵³ developing assessments and evaluations,²⁵⁴ stress management, and newborn care at home.^{255 256}

In the case of government stakeholders, sanctions meant that UNICEF Syria Country Office's partnership with government counterparts involved primarily technical engagement, and significant efforts were invested at this level. For example, Syria Country Office supported the MoH with a consultancy to have the SMART Manager Training in Syria with Action Against Hunger Canada, and also supported on enforcing the national code of marketing of BMS.²⁵⁷ The context analysis of textbooks used for Curriculum B and the consultative joint work with the MoE strengthened trust with UNICEF and facilitated greater discussion on sensitive topics (see Sections 6 on cross-cutting and 7 on connectedness for more on institutional strengthening). UNICEF Syria Country Office, in collaboration with the Ministry of Water Resources (MoWR), has improved the overall management, reporting and planning of the Water and Sanitation sector in the country through developing an intricate IM system that measures and monitors the key sector performance indicators at both national and subnational levels. These efforts are also aligned with the Grand Bargain commitments to enhance reporting systems to enable better access to information and better capture results.²⁵⁸

In NWS, capacity building and commitments to the Grand Bargain are analysed through two interconnected lenses. The first is the tangible and relevant capacity building inputs that UNICEF has provided to its national partners. The second is the contribution of these inputs to an outcome whereby national Implementing Partners are empowered to be the leaders on the recovery towards resilience in NWS.

Although UNICEF Implementing Partners were already highly capacitated in many areas, UNICEF partners received a variety of capacity building trainings both prior to and during the earthquake response. These included, inter alia, SBC, emergency response and preparedness planning, lines of communication on UN operations in NWS (in conjunction with other UN agencies), risk management and AAP. Implementing Partners reported that the SBC training (provided by the MENARO SBC team during the response) was considered highly effective in terms of being able to understand and introduce SBC approaches into their response programming.²⁵⁹ The emergency response training was effective because Implementing Partners were able to integrate this knowledge into broader awareness raising campaigns in NWS. The results of this approach were underlined by the service users and health and education providers interviewed in this evaluation, who expressed the importance of the emergency preparedness training to their mental well-being and preparedness in the future.²⁶⁰



²⁵³ SCO, Earthquake Updates from Field Offices. 9 February 2023.

²⁵⁴ UNICEF, Syria Humanitarian Situation Report No. 6 (Earthquake): 15 - 21 March 2023. 24 March 2023.

²⁵⁵ UNICEF, Humanitarian Situation Report: 1 January to 30 June 2023. 2023.

²⁵⁶ UNICEF, Syria Humanitarian Situation Report No. 9 (Earthquake): 12 April - 2 May 2023. 5 May 2023.

²⁵⁷ UNICEF 2023 RAM Report. 2023.

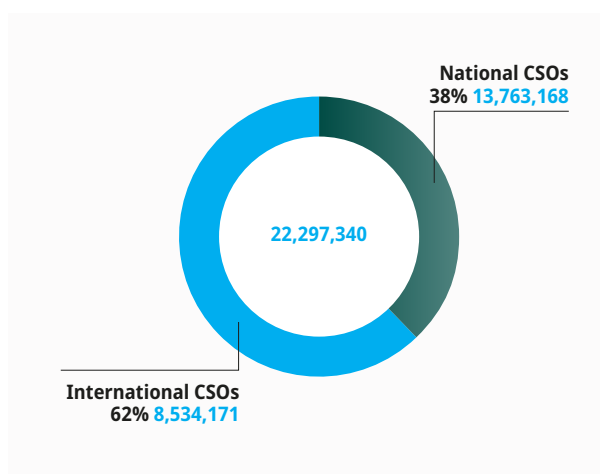
²⁵⁸ Grand Bargain Commitments by Workstream.

²⁵⁹ KII NWS 04/24; KII NWS 04/24.

²⁶⁰ FGDs NWS 05/24; KII NWS SP 05/24.

UNICEF has made some sound contributions in terms of contributing to the outcome of empowering national partners to lead a sustainable longer-term resilience programming in NWS. The first of these is meeting the Grand Bargain commitment to providing at least 25 per cent of humanitarian funding to local responders. The Outpost dashboard (as of April 2024) indicates that 62 per cent of funding is being allocated to national NGOs/CSOs. Although this is one indicator on the road to operationalizing the localization agenda, it does not necessarily lead to empowerment of local partners and responders.

Figure 17. Allocation of funding to CSOs



The Grand Bargain Workstreams on multi-year planning, funding, and reducing donor earmarking and UNICEF's own CCCs to support multi-year agreements and funding are more challenging to implement.²⁶¹ Despite the increased use of contingency PDs in the Outpost during the earthquake response, donor funding is still subject to short-term funding cycles and, at times, earmarking. Regardless of the status of the cross-border mandate, there is a case for much stronger management of aid in Syria by Syrians themselves. In this regard, two pooled fund mechanisms have been set up for cross-border support in NWS: the Syria Cross-Border Humanitarian Fund (SCHF), managed by OCHA, and the more recently established Aid Fund for Northern Syria (AFNS). Both funds have clearly articulated strategies with regard to furthering the localization agenda. A donor consulted in this evaluation believed that these funds were an effective vehicle for advancing the localization agenda in NWS: "The Syria Cross-Border Humanitarian Fund is an important mechanism contributing to localization. It focuses on supporting local NGOs. It directly funds NGOs with a sound monitoring framework."²⁶² Within the agenda of localization, UNICEF will need to assess its added value and effectiveness in its partnership portfolio versus a future role that is geared more to technical support for Syrians leading on their own recovery.

²⁶¹ WORKSTREAMS 7 & 8: Increase collaborative humanitarian multi-year planning and funding & Reduce the earmarking of donor contributions.

²⁶² KII WoS 05/24.



5

Conclusions

Overall conclusions

Overall, the evaluation found that UNICEF enacted a well-considered and effective earthquake response situated within a discrete and timebound framework of the L3 Emergency Procedures from February 2023 to August 2023. The response mostly met the intervention objectives of delivering on immediate life-saving and urgent humanitarian needs of girls, boys, adolescents and families through an integrated and gender-responsive approach prioritizing highly affected areas and areas of large displacement. A cadre of well-capacitated Implementing Partners on the ground and a collegial and strategic approach to UN coordination (particularly in the case of the Syria Country Office) contributed to the effectiveness of the response. UNICEF staff were able to seize opportunities in crisis to improve systems and innovate with potentially transformative and multisectoral initiatives in NWS. However, the response was also marked by some self-restricting approaches to donor red lines, access issues and engagement with the DfA in NWS.

UNICEF's ways of working (as identified in the reconstructed logic model) were clearly guided by the CCCs, with the activities contributing to the outputs but not always achieving targets. Given that UNICEF has measured results mostly in terms of outputs, it is difficult to be definitive on the contribution to outcomes. This finding is not unique to this L3 response and has been cited in other emergency evaluations and

in OIAI audits. Looking at contributions to the three outcome areas in the reconstructed logic model, the evaluation found:

Outcome 1: Immediate humanitarian needs are responded to. The L3 response made a strong contribution to this outcome through, inter alia, coverage strategies, multisector responses with the amplification of SBC approaches, and maximizing relations with national partners and the UN to expedite the response.

Outcome 2: Essential services are continued at scale. The L3 response contributed to the continuance of essential services, but at the outset of the emergency it was difficult to implement at scale, given the gravity of the earthquake destruction and identified programming constraints.

Outcome 3: Life-saving and early recovery services also foster resilience. The evaluation found that in terms of life-saving and early recovery, the fostering resilience element in this outcome was hard to attain, particularly in NWS, given donor redlines, political volatility, an absence of formalized governance structures to anchor initiatives to, and a lack of shared vision on what an early recovery strategy should look like. Given this conclusion, the recommendations have a significant formative element focusing on the recovery stage of the response and resilience building.

Appropriateness

The earthquake impact on partners and staff was immense, and considerations of the appropriateness of strategies to meet the intervention objectives must be understood in this context. The measures taken by the UNICEF Syria Country Office and the Outpost Office to adapt to the context, align with the needs of affected populations and implement integrated responses were mostly appropriate to achieving the intervention objectives. Significantly, the L3 scale-up measures were predicated on the CCCs, which provided clear guidance at the design and implementation phases of the response.

In terms of preparedness, although the EPP did not account for the contingency of an earthquake, this was not perceived by staff as a barrier to their response activities in either region. The pre-earthquake EPP training undertaken in the Syria Country Office was of key importance and was highly appropriate. It helped to shift people's mindsets to emergency preparedness and helped build familiarity with the individual and departmental responsibilities in an emergency response. This conclusion underscores the importance of planning and implementing iterative EPP training exercises, regardless of the context in which UNICEF is operating.

In both regions, Implementing Partners were at the front and centre of operationalizing AAP principles in affected communities. Formal feedback mechanisms were well established, most notably in NWS, where there was high awareness of various feedback and complaint modalities open to them. However, more emphasis (in both monitoring and reporting) was placed on access/usage of mechanisms rather than measuring the extent to which UNICEF prioritized putting people at the centre of identifying their own needs.

Integrated programme initiatives were evident in both regions, with activities that had potential to be transformative leading to sustained change beyond the earthquake response. The evaluation considers the Syria Country Office's focus on involving adolescents in multisector awareness raising campaigns to be highly appropriate in terms of working at scale and maximizing the potential of adolescents to build trust in communities in support of SBC approaches (recommendation 6 - GCAs).

The WAQTI initiative in NWS was a model adapted from the Ukraine and Ethiopia emergencies and was appropriate in terms of its ambition to enact change

across multiple sectors and lay the groundwork for opportunities to create positive impact on the gender continuum. Despite the discontinuance of the initiative, it has been effective at changing staff mindsets on siloed programming. The evaluation would advocate for more learning from this initiative and the need for a detailed evaluation of the WAQTI intervention looking at impact of the cross-sector approach, value for money, and what this could mean for multi-sector resilience programmes moving forward (recommendation 1 - NGCAs).

Effectiveness

The criticality of CT in emergencies is well-documented, thanks to careful monitoring and analysis of this intervention by the Syria Country Office in the L3 response. However, overall targets were difficult to reach owing to circumscribed UN-agreed financial envelopes, a lack of shared UN positioning on data protection and associated difficulties in horizontal expansion. In future emergencies, it will be important to find ways to improve horizontal expansion while also ensuring that lessons learned are shared with the Outpost and impact evidence of CT is provided to donors (recommendations 1, 2, 3 – GCAs).

Coverage with equity is complex to plan and monitor for in the broader UNICEF organization in both development and humanitarian emergency contexts. Given the challenges of reliable data for both regions of Syria, it will be difficult to fully join UNICEF's new equity modelling pilot. The use of monitoring tools (employed by the Syria Country Office) to identify those excluded from assistance will continue to be important, especially for ensuring coverage of CWDs and identifying pockets of exclusion.

Information management in the emergency has emerged as a critical issue. In line with UNICEF's strategic priority on digitalization, the role of Information Specialists is critical, both during an L3 response and in recovery phases. Therefore, it is key that the Outpost and Syria Country Office have the requisite IM resources (in emergency and recovery phases) and that line-management maximizes the role of IMS (recommendations 2, 3 – NGCAs).

A UNICEF corporate-level response will be required to address misalignment in results and financial reporting cited in this report (see recommendations in the Overarching Report).

Cross-cutting

Although surge staff provided much needed assistance in ramping up PSEA in GCAs, there is still limited traction and understanding from the Government on the importance of this issue (inside and outside of emergency contexts). The evaluation concluded that more efforts could be invested in building government (and partner) understanding and ownership on this issue (recommendation 9 – GCAs). In both regions, the evaluation concluded that PSEA and protection awareness raising and trainings could have more systematically included more men. This was a missed opportunity to initiate a more transformative approach to PSEA and some protection outcomes and highlights the need to follow-up with Implementing Partners to understand their methodology for reaching men on these issues.

SBC was highly effective in reaching the planned targets of the L3 response, but as with AAP, the evaluation questions whether the indicator captured the true extent of the intervention. The review of SBC in emergencies was valuable to look deeper into strategies leading to transformative outcomes. The evaluation concluded that there is more scope to look at how SBC interventions can be maximized both by using a multi-sector approach and by engaging youth (recommendation 1 – NGCAs and recommendation 6 – GCAs).

Connectedness

The response in both regions was focused primarily on scaling up pre-existing humanitarian programmes and service provision, mainly through the expansion of already established partnerships. In GCAs, the earthquake response created opportunities for UNICEF to scale up efforts in early recovery with notable investments in a sustainable solutions approach in infrastructure rehabilitation, and this was assisted, in part, by some donors showing more flexibility in terms of emergency humanitarian assistance, combining developmental and sustainable approaches. The evaluation concludes that multi-year resilience programming on both regions will involve recalibrating approaches to funding with donors (elaborated upon in the Overarching Report) and re-doubled efforts at pushing forward on the localization agenda with government and partners (discussed below).

Coherence

Pre-existing Syria Country Office relationships with the Government, at both ministerial and directorate levels, were both tested and strengthened in the earthquake response. Those relationships were critical to the effectiveness of UNICEF's L3 response in terms of expediting customs clearances and visa waivers. At times, the relationships were tested over issues relating to access and data collection. Learning from this L3 response, the Syria Country Office can be better prepared for future emergencies by developing bilateral and UN-wide strategic relations with government authorities in charge of emergency response, i.e., developing relationships beyond their existing ecosystem of Syrian counterpart ministries (recommendations 8, 10 – GCAs).

In NGCAs, the evaluation recognizes the importance of UNICEF's continuing efforts to engage with the wider UN family, especially OCHA, in engaging with the DfAs in NWS. However, there are some compelling reasons for the Outpost (and the WoS team in Amman) to redouble efforts on engagement with the DfAs and to clarify the leadership within UNICEF to spearhead this engagement. In terms of coherence and sustainability, there is a need to anchor UNICEF's programming within the prevailing systems in NWS. It is also appropriate for the Outpost to mitigate programme risk by developing sound communication channels with the DfAs while ensuring UNICEF's adherence to core commitments of a principled humanitarian approach in NWS (recommendation 4 – NGCAs).

Coordination

National partners in both regions were the fulcrum of the L3 response on the ground. Satisfaction on the equality of these relationships was expressed throughout the evaluation by Syrian partners. UNICEF has invested efforts to advance the CCCs localization agenda through capacity building and surpassing Grand Bargain targets in budget allocations to national responders. However, a viewpoint expressed by some donors in this evaluation, and underlined in the WoS Review, is the need to progress more substantively on the localization agenda in GCAs and NGCAs. The evaluation proposes that UNICEF can provide this support by filling capacity building needs for national NGO partners in emergency preparedness and resource mobilization for

longer-term funding (recommendation. 5 – NGCAs and 4,5 GCAs). At the same time, it is recommended that UNICEF offices be accountable to localization principles above and beyond capacity building and financial allocations and could systematically measure accountability to the CCCs on localization (recommendation 7 – NGCAs and 7 – GCAs).



6

Recommendations

Syria NGCAs and Syria GCAs

Two separate sets of recommendations have been developed for Syria NGCAs and GCAs. The recommendations for NWS address multisector programming approaches; IM; engagement with the DfAs and continued advocacy on CAAC; and localization linked to early recovery and resilience building. The recommendations for the Syria Country Office address effectiveness of CTs; localization; and coordination with the Government on emergency preparedness and response and PSEA.

This report has highlighted the challenge of discrepancies in various results datasets. Because this is a wider UNICEF corporate issue, a recommendation in this regard has been elevated to the Overarching Report. Additional recommendations relating to the corporate dimension of the response, and to aspects of L3 operations that spanned both Syria and Türkiye, are presented in the evaluation's Overarching Report. Those recommendations touch on HR and surge; resource mobilization and allocation; supply and logistics; and the Emergency Procedures.

The recommendations for Syria NGCAs and GCAs are complementary and should be read in conjunction with each other and with the recommendations presented in the Overarching Report.

Recommendations for Syria NGCAs

Recommendation	Rationale	Specific actions to be taken	Responsible parties
Appropriateness: Multisector programming			
1. <i>Increase knowledge base on multisector programming to apply in future sudden onset emergencies and in early recovery and resilience building stages</i>	The evaluation found that the Outpost implemented some promising multisectoral programming initiatives in the L3 response. The WAQTI initiative is the most notable example of convergent programming. The evaluation recommends that there are important lessons to learn in how this initiative contributed to an effective response to a large sudden onset emergency; and if and how this model could be used to respond to the continuing early recovery efforts in NWS, especially in light of the constrained funding environment and the exigency for cost-effective and impactful programming.	1.1 Conduct an evaluation of the WAQTI programme to assess: (a) cost-effectiveness, (b) impact, (c) contribution to transformative outcomes, i.e. opportunity to move further on the gender continuum, (d) role of SBC to develop responses based on community needs/priorities and amplify messaging, and (e) opportunities for replicability in protracted emergencies/early recovery and sudden onset emergencies.	Outpost (PME Unit), MENARO Evaluation Unit and technical departments, e.g., gender
		1.2 If the resources and global corporate appetite are sufficient, then the two similar models of this approach initiated in the Ukraine and Ethiopian L3 emergencies could also be evaluated.	HQ Evaluation Office, Regional Offices

Effectiveness: IM and HR

2. Revisit the regional and global surge rosters and adjust to ensure IM specialists (at all levels) are well represented, facilitating a quicker drawdown of these skills in an L3 emergency

As UNICEF globally pursues the strategic agenda of digital transformation, the demand for IM skills and resources has grown. In the Outpost, two challenges were identified during the L3 response in this area. The first was receiving timely and well-suited surge to provide IM support. The evaluation found that IM specialists are often needed for longer durations than an eight-week deployment circumscribed in the Emergency Response Team deployments, and country offices would prefer surge staff who have regional knowledge. The second challenge the Evaluation Team identified was the need to better streamline the structure of IM within the Outpost to increase effectiveness in an emergency. Currently IMO's are under programme sections rather than PME, and this has contributed to a siloed approach to IM.

2.1 Review current regional surge rosters to ensure there are an adequate number of people with IM skills (at all levels) on roster lists. It is recommended that regional experience be prioritized through the planned use of standby partners and linking professional development plans of national staff in the MENA region with stretch assignments.

HR in MENARO, in coordination with DHR

EMOPS

3. Attain greater clarity on IMS management in the Outpost– in line with revised guidelines issues by MENARO

3.1 After the Programme and Budget Review (PBR) process has been fully implemented in 2024, initiate a deep dive on the needs of programme sections versus the role of PME to determine collaboratively the structure that would bring greater clarity to maximizing the usage of IM in emergencies, based on the MENARO's four options for structuring IM functions.

Outpost Operations, PME, MENARO HR

Coherence: Dialogue and advocacy with the DfAs

4. Develop a phased strategy for UNICEF engagement with DfAs

The evaluation recognizes the importance of UNICEF's continuing efforts to engage with the wider UN family, especially OCHA, in engaging with the DfAs in NWS. However, there are some compelling reasons for the Outpost (and the WoS team in Amman) to redouble efforts on engagement with the DfAs and clarify the leadership within UNICEF to spearhead this engagement. In terms of coherence and sustainability, there is a need to try to anchor UNICEF's programming with the prevailing systems in NWS. It is also appropriate for the Outpost to mitigate programme risk by developing sound communication channels with the DfAs while ensuring UNICEF's adherence to core commitments of a principled humanitarian approach in NWS.

4.1 Develop a phased strategy, including (a) granularity in the phases of approach; (b) a well-defined purpose of the engagement; (c) a risk analysis for both engaging and not engaging; (d) clarity around the UNICEF 'red lines' for engagement; and (e) identification of interlocutors (from both within UNICEF and the DfAs).

4.2 Appoint Head of Outpost as the day-to-day lead for engagement with DfAs, with accountability in key performance indicators (KPIs).

Head of Outpost supported by the Head of WoS (liaising with the SCO), MENARO.

Connectedness and coordination: Localization linked to multi-year early recovery

5. Provide support for Implementing Partners to access longer-term and more predictable funding sources

A viewpoint expressed by some donors in this evaluation, and underlined in the WoS Review, is the need to progress more substantively on the localization agenda with Implementing Partners in NWS. The evaluation proposes that recovery and localization agendas could be more strategically linked. UNICEF has invested in long-term capacity building of its NGO partners, and they ultimately must be the leaders of recovery in NWS.

5.1 Provide further resource mobilization capacity building to Implementing Partners to allow them to apply for more sustainable funding streams, i.e., the existing two multi-donor cross-border funds.

Outpost sectors,
Partnership
Manager

5.2 As recommended by the WoS Review, advocate with donors to put funds into NGOs and the pooled NGO funds.²⁶³

5.3 Continue the good practice established in the L3 response, to use contingency options in PDs to enable programme implementation for one year.

6. Introduce accountability to progressing the localization agenda, as described in the CCCs ("Localization of humanitarian and development programming is supported through multi-year, predictable and flexible funding. Systems are in place to track, monitor and report on these investments." (CCC Resource mobilization 3.6))

6.1 Outpost to select and adapt two localization indicators from the CCCs to report on annually.

Outpost Sectors,
PME

6.2 At partnership level, commitments to localization targets, for example resource mobilization training, should be discussed and defined with the partner and made accountable in the PDs.

7. Develop a shared multisector vision on early recovery with national partners

7.1 Initiate two workshops per annum (starting end 2024) with relevant UNICEF Outpost staff and all Implementing Partners with a well-defined agenda to discuss priorities and strategies for resilience programming in NWS. This will encourage a stronger national voice in planning but also it will help strategizing across the sectors to look for more multisectoral synergies.

Outpost sectors,
Outpost Senior
Management,
with
implementing
partners

Recommendations for Syria GCAs

Recommendation	Rationale	Specific actions to be taken	Responsible parties
Effectiveness: Cash transfers			
<i>1. Coordinate with UN partners to finalize an agreed set of standards in CT</i>	CTs (for basic needs and families with CwDs) were shown (through the PDM) to be a highly effective and empowering mechanism to meet needs in the earthquake response. The targeting of vulnerable groups outside of the camps also ensured a broader Do No Harm approach to counterbalance the predominance of earthquake assistance (UN and NGOs) that was provided to people in the collective camps. However, delays were experienced in the horizontal expansion of the transfers, and there were issues around sharing recipients' data with the Government and a lack of harmonization with some UN agencies.	1.1 Coordinate with other UN agencies providing CT, UNHCR in particular, to develop a UN-wide agreed set of standards on data sharing with the government and eligibility criteria for CT (2024).	Social Policy (SP) Team in SCO, UNICEF Senior Management in CO
<i>2. Enhance timeliness and effectiveness of CT in emergencies</i>		2.1 Contribute to expediting CT in emergencies by enrolling the Integrated Management Information System-SP to build a social registry (2024–2025). 2.2 Undertake a review to determine the most effective ways to distribute cash, e.g., ATM cards, bank transfers, mobile money, including lessons learned and approaches in similar contexts such as Myanmar (2025).	Social Policy Team in SCO, PME Unit in SCO (in 2.1 only), with support from MENARO Evaluation
<i>3. Use the solid evidence on CT for evidence-based advocacy and credibility-building to donors</i>		3.1 Use the PDM analysis to undertake targeted evidence-based advocacy to donors to scale up both strands of the CT in the recovery phase (2024–2025) and demonstrate UNICEF's value added in CTs.	Social Policy Team in SCO HR in SCO and RO, Head SP in SCO

Coordination: Localization

4. Progress further on the localization agenda for increasing national NGO responder capacities in emergency response

A viewpoint expressed by some donors in this evaluation, and underlined in the WoS Review, is the need to progress more substantively on the localization agenda in GCAs and NGCAs. The evaluation proposes that UNICEF can provide this support/filling capacity building needs for national NGO partners in emergency preparedness and resource mobilization for longer-term funding.

4.1 Conduct a capacity assessment of all NGO partners to identify further areas of support and capacity building required in emergency preparedness and response. Develop resourced plan to action these capacity requirements (2025).

Field Operations Team in SCO

5. Provide capacity building for Implementing Partners in financial management and risk in order for them to be better positioned to (independently) access predictable funding sources

5.1 As recommended by the WoS Review, advocate with donors to put funds into NGOs and the pooled NGO funds (2025).

Partnerships and Resource Mobilization team in SCO, with support of RO Head of sections

5.2 In accordance with Implementing Partner needs, provide financial management and risk capacity building.

5.3 Use contingency options in PDs to enable programme implementation for one year.

Implementing Partnership Management team (HACT) in SCO

6. Harness the role of youth as trust-builders in communities to enhance AAP in emergencies

6.1 Building on good practice from the L3 response, in the EPP, explicitly outline the role of youth in trust-building in communities to identify their own needs in emergencies.

Field Operations team and ADAP, SBC, PME team

6.2 Increase investment and conduct research with and for young people in humanitarian action.

PSEA Lead, PME Unit and ADAP team in SCO

6.3 Develop a rapid rollout training course in PSEA and AAP in emergencies to be delivered to youth volunteers at the outset of an emergency engagement.

7. Introduce accountability to progressing the localization agenda

The evaluation also found that youth volunteers played an important role in building trust in communities and helping people to identify their own needs in the response. Therefore, it will be important for future programming in emergencies to understand how youth volunteers can be pivotal trust-builders within communities to improve AAP. At the same time, it is recommended that UNICEF Syria Country Office be accountable to localization and can measure the progress made on this agenda.

7.1 SCO to select and adapt two localization indicators from the CCCs to report on annually.

PME Unit in SCO

7.2 Include localization agenda in SCO's partnership strategy, including HACT

7.3 At partnership level, commitments to localization targets, for example resource mobilization training or preparedness training, should be discussed and defined with the partner and made accountable in the PDs.

All sectors with support from Implementing Partnerships team in SCO

Coherence: Working with government authorities on emergency preparedness and response and PSEA

8. Work with UN agencies to improve joint UN–government coordination in emergency preparedness and response

The evaluation found that UNICEF was able to leverage pre-existing relationships with the Government and authorities to contribute to a timely and effective earthquake response. However, there were also challenges in terms of access, approvals for data collection (often this was at local rather than central government levels) and pressure to disclose data for CT recipients. In the event of future sudden onset emergencies, there is a strong rationale for reflecting with the Government on how this earthquake response was enacted (reflecting on areas where the Government may also require emergency preparedness and response capacities moving forward) and operationalizing joint UN–government emergency preparedness/response workshops to enhance coordination in future emergencies.

8.1 UNICEF active participation in OCHA-led series of joint UN–government workshops (at national and governorate level) on emergency preparedness and response to promote/advocate child rights needs in 2025. This should lead to a tangible document with agreed SOPs on coordination and identification of areas of needed capacity in response and preparedness.

Senior Management in SCO, supported by Field Operations team, sector and cross-cutting sectors

9. Attain greater traction with the Government, NGO and INGO partners on PSEA in emergencies

9.1 Build on the CCCs publication previously shared by UNICEF with the Government and partners and, building on PSEA activities in the L3 response, initiate dialogue and advocacy on PSEA in protracted/sudden emergencies to reach agreement on complete dissemination of awareness raising material and rollout of reporting mechanisms in communities and in government premises.

PSEA lead in SCO

10. Build strategic partnerships building with MoLAE as an essential part of preparedness for future emergencies.

The evaluation found that while UNICEF was proactive in leveraging relations with existing government interlocuters during the L3 response, more could be done in building strategic relations with government authorities in charge of emergency response, i.e., develop relationships beyond their existing ecosystem of Syrian counterpart ministries.

10.1 Senior Management to have regular visits to MoLAE, as well as technical meetings to brief on SCO programmes, including their shock-responsiveness component.

Senior Management in SCO



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